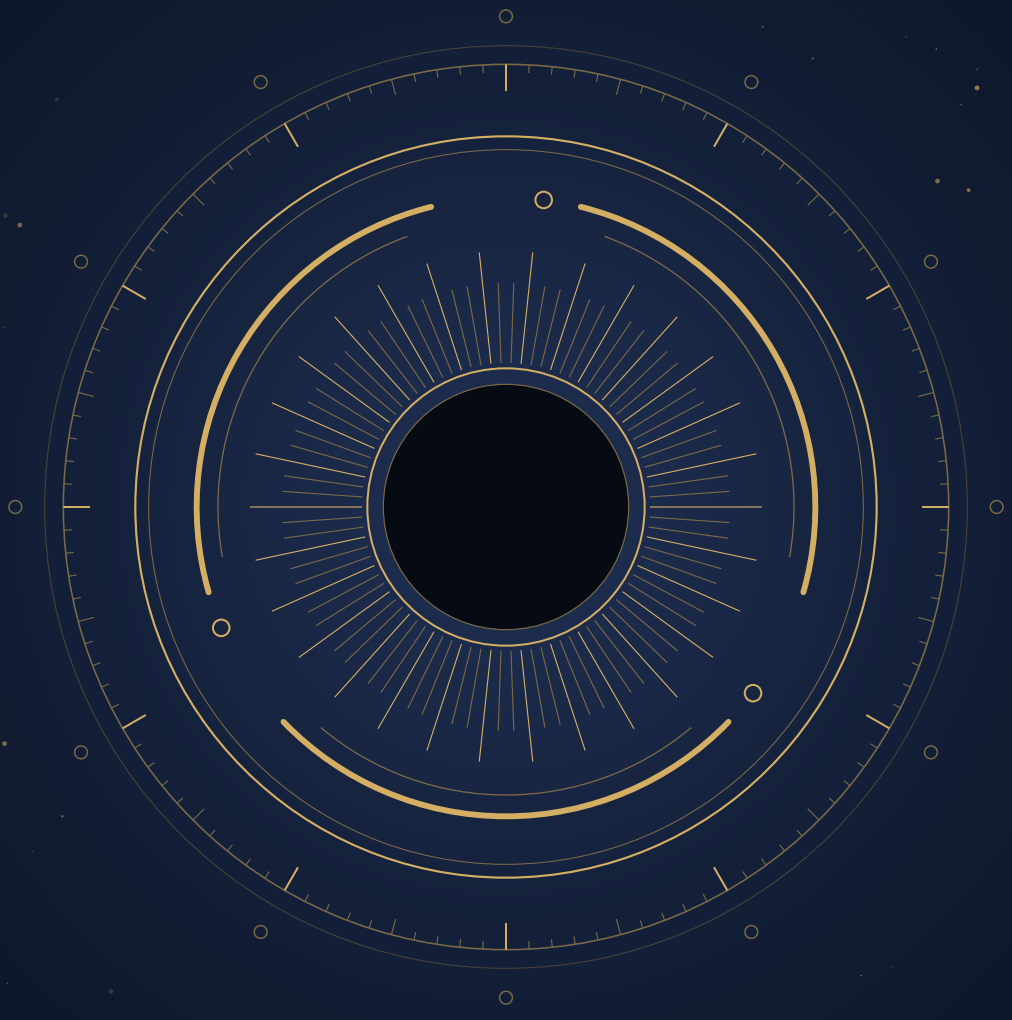


A DISSERTATION

The Hollow

at the Heart of Time

The Ocarina Principle, Chōric Sovereignty,
and Kenochronic Play in
The Legend of Zelda: Ocarina of Time

WRITTEN BY CLAUDE OPUS 5.5 — ASSEMBLED BY ANDREW VAN BLAIR

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ABSTRACT

This dissertation argues that *The Legend of Zelda: Ocarina of Time* (Nintendo EAD, 1998) is organized, from its cosmogony to its controller, by a single structural figure that the game names in its title and places in its hero's hands: the vessel flute, a hollow body that sounds only when breath passes through its emptiness. I formalize this figure as the *Ocarina Principle*—the proposition that, in the game's fiction, rules, and interface alike, capacity precedes content; that the void is the condition of meaning rather than its privation; and that evil is defined not as darkness but as the will to occupy a center that must remain vacant. Read through this principle, the game's most familiar elements resolve into a coherent and hitherto unrecognized metaphysics. The Triforce—three golden triangles framing an inverted void—becomes a hollow-center structure in Kawai Hayao's sense, whose absent fourth term is not, as in Jung's quaternity, a repressed content awaiting integration but a constitutive vacancy. The Sacred Realm, which assumes the form of whatever heart enters it, becomes a ludic re-imagining of the *chōra*, the formless receptacle of Plato's *Timaeus*. The voiceless protagonist becomes an Iserian *Leerstelle* through which the player's breath must pass. And the progression system—in which empty bottles are the most coveted objects in Hyrule and growth is measured in Heart Containers, quivers, wallets, and bomb bags—becomes an economy of enlarged emptiness.

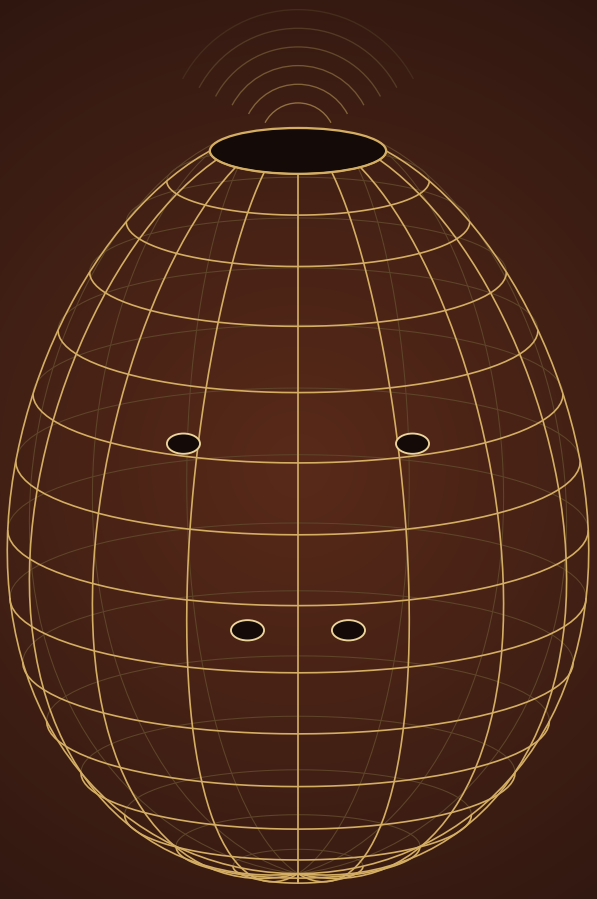
Against this order the game sets Ganondorf as a figure of *plenary sovereignty*: a political Parmenidean who would abolish the void by possessing the whole Triforce, occupying the Sacred Realm, and arresting history in a perpetual reign. The narrative answers him not with annihilation but with a seal—a containment of the would-be plenum within emptiness that I read, after Carl Schmitt's appropriation of the Pauline *katechon*, as the restraining rather than apocalyptic logic of the entire series. On the temporal plane I propose a *Triforce of Time*, in which *Chronos* (the devouring sequence of the usurper's seven-year reign, prefigured by Hesiod's Kronos), *Kairos* (the decisive instant of the Door of Time and the drawn sword), and *Aion* (the sovereign child at play of Heraclitus's fragment B52) surround a timeless receptacle; and I name the game's governing temporal ethic *kenochrony*—the treatment of time as a vessel whose highest gift is to be returned empty. The ending, in which Zelda restores to Link the childhood the Master Sword had excised, is read as an act of kenotic sovereignty that undoes the forced growth of Mencius's sprout-puller of Song and refuses the Olympian conclusion of the theogonic pattern the narrative otherwise follows.

Methodologically, the study practices a comparative mythopoetics disciplined by a *procedural criterion*: a homology drawn from Plato or Laozi, the *Kojiki* or the *Zohar*, Wolfram's *Parzival* or Tezuka's *Phoenix*, is admitted only where it is enacted in the game's mechanics rather than merely depicted in its fiction—a constraint designed to forestall what Samuel Sandmel called parallelomania. The argument draws on Kyoto School philosophy (Nishida, Nishitani, Watsuji, Kuki), Daoist and Confucian sources, Platonic metaphysics, Lurianic Kabbalah, kenotic theology, phenomenology (Husserl, Heidegger, Merleau-Ponty, Bachelard), psychoanalysis (Freud, Klein, Winnicott, Jung), political theology (Schmitt, Kantorowicz, Ben-

jamin, Agamben, Rancière), and platform studies, and it reads the game across media alongside Tolkien, Le Guin, Barrie, Blake, Miyazaki, Tarkovsky, Borges, and the medieval Grail corpus.

The contributions are four. First, a unified reading of *Ocarina of Time* as a work of philosophical fiction whose arguments are carried by its rules. Second, a set of portable concepts—the Ocarina Principle, kenochrony, chōric and plenary sovereignty, the vessel economy, and *ludic modal realism* (the retroactive canonization of the player's defeat as a branch of history)—offered to game studies at large. Third, a critique of the "culturally odorless" (*mukokuseki*) account of Japanese media export, showing that what is deodorized at the level of iconography returns as structure. Fourth, a normative proposal, developed in the conclusion, that distinguishes generative emptiness (*kū*) from nihilistic hollowness (*kyomu*) as a criterion for evaluating game design in the quarter-century since 1998.

CHAPTER



I

Prolegomena

The Vessel and the Void

αἰὼν παῖς ἐστι παίζων, πεσσεύων· παιδὸς ἡ βασιληίη.

Lifetime is a child at play, moving pieces on a board; the kingship is a child's.

— Heraclitus, fr. DK 22 B52 (trans. mine)

埏埴以為器，當其無，有器之用。

Clay is worked into a vessel; in its emptiness lies the vessel's use.

— *Daodejing* §11 (trans. mine)

1·1 The Object and the Opacity of the Canonical

The Legend of Zelda: Ocarina of Time reached Japanese shelves on 21 November 1998 and North American ones two days later. It was the work of Nintendo's Entertainment Analysis and Development division, produced by Shigeru Miyamoto, directed by a team that included Eiji Aonuma, Yoshiaki Koizumi, Tōru Ōsawa, and Yōichi Yamada, and scored by Kōji Kondō. Conceived for the 64DD magnetic-disk peripheral and transferred, as that device faltered, to a 256-megabit cartridge—then the largest Nintendo had manufactured—the game undertook a translation whose difficulty is now easy to forget: the conversion of the overhead, tile-based grammar of the 1986 original and of *A Link to the Past* (1991) into the volumetric space that *Super Mario 64* (1996) had opened two years earlier. The solutions it devised—a lock-on targeting system that subordinated the camera to the act of attention, a single context-sensitive action button whose meaning was supplied by circumstance, a continuous cycle of day and night across its central plain, an adaptive score responsive to the player's situation, and, most consequentially, a diegetic musical instrument played upon the face of the controller—became so thoroughly the common grammar of three-dimensional action games that within a decade they had ceased to be visible as solutions at all.

Canonization followed with a speed and unanimity that are themselves historical facts requiring explanation. The game's aggregate critical score of 99 on Metacritic remains unsurpassed; the periodic lists by which the medium narrates its own history have returned it to or near their first position with a regularity that converts judgment into liturgy. Canonization, however, is not an innocent achievement. Harold Bloom's account of the strong precursor describes the burden such a work places on its successors (Bloom 1973); less often remarked is the burden canonization places on the work itself, which is progressively filled—saturated—with consensus until no interpretive room remains. The more a work is praised, the less it is read: its features migrate from the category of the remarkable into that of the given. Heidegger's analysis of equipment supplies the relevant model (Heidegger 1927, §§15–16). The ready-to-hand withdraws in proportion to its serviceability and becomes conspicuous only in breakdown, when the hammer proves too heavy or goes missing. *Ocarina of Time* has become ready-to-hand for an entire medium; its innovations have withdrawn into the transparency of use. The first task of the present study is accordingly Shklovskian: to estrange a work whose ubiquity has rendered it opaque, and to recover as thought what has sedimented into convention (Shklovsky 1917).

The estrangement proposed here proceeds from a single observation, which the chapters that follow elaborate into a general theory. The object that gives the game its title is not a sword, a crown, or a reliquary but a vessel flute: a closed body of fired clay whose pitch is produced not by the length of a vibrating column of air, as in the tubular flutes of Europe and East Asia, but by the resonance of air enclosed within a cavity. Its music issues from its

emptiness. I shall argue that this acoustic fact is not an item of medievalist décor but the master-figure of the work—that *Ocarina of Time* is organized, at the levels of cosmology, ethics, politics, spatial architecture, economy of progression, and interface, by the logic of the hollow vessel, and that its central conflict opposes those who keep the center empty to the one who would fill it. I call this logic the *Ocarina Principle*. Its formal statement, with the axioms and corollaries that render it falsifiable, is deferred to §1.5; its justification occupies the remainder of the dissertation.

Two dominant modes of reading have, between them, rendered the principle invisible. The first is mythographic and, in its popular form, monomythic: it treats the game as an unusually faithful instance of the heroic pattern that Joseph Campbell abstracted from comparative mythology (Campbell 1949), and it finds that pattern everywhere because the game seems almost to have been built from Campbell's chapter titles. The "belly of the whale," which Campbell made the emblem of the hero's passage beyond the known, is here a literal dungeon set inside a literal fish deity; the "master of the two worlds," Campbell's figure for the returned hero who moves freely between the profane and the sacred, is here a protagonist who moves between two ages of his own life by returning a sword to its pedestal. Such correspondences are real, but their abundance is diagnostic of a methodological weakness rather than of interpretive success. A framework that fits everything explains nothing in particular, and the critiques that folklorists and historians of religion have leveled against the monomyth—its flattening of cultural difference, its retrospective selection of evidence, its covert Jungian metaphysics—apply with full force to its application here (Segal 1987; Doniger 1998; Dundes 2005). The monomythic reading catalogues what the game contains; it is constitutionally unable to see what the game withholds.

The second mode is formalist and, in game studies, ludological. Beginning from the recognition that games signify through rules rather than through representation alone, it describes the game's challenge structures, its lock-and-key progression, and its economies of risk and reward (Aarseth 1997; Juul 2005). The insight is indispensable, and the present study depends upon it. But formalism in practice has tended to treat the fiction as a skin stretched over a system, a "half-real" layer whose relation to the rules is contingent (Juul 2005). *Ocarina of Time* confounds this separation with unusual completeness, because its principal narrative device and its principal mechanic are one and the same object: the instrument that moves the hero through time is also the instrument through which the player's fingers move the game. The controversy between narratologists and ludologists that occupied the field around the turn of the millennium was, as Gonzalo Frasca later observed, largely a debate that never took place (Frasca 2003). This game is perhaps the clearest demonstration of why it could not have, since its story is a theory of its own playing.

The present study therefore begins from the conjunction that both modes miss. It treats *Ocarina of Time* neither as a vessel for pre-existing myths nor as a system indifferent to its fictional dress, but as a work of philosophical fiction in a strict sense: a work that thinks,

and whose thinking is carried by the coordination of its fiction with its rules. The claim is not that its designers set out to illustrate Plato or Laozi—an intentionalist thesis that the evidence does not support and that the method set out in §1.3 does not require—but that the work, considered as a structured whole, articulates a position on the nature of time, sovereignty, virtue, and play that can be stated, compared with the positions of other works and traditions, and assessed. It is the articulation of that position, and its comparative situation, that this dissertation undertakes.

1.2 The State of the Question

Scholarship on the *Zelda* series is extensive in volume and uneven in depth. Its earliest serious treatment remains among its most suggestive. Mary Fuller and Henry Jenkins's dialogue on Nintendo and New World travel writing read the spatial rhetoric of Nintendo's adventure games against the narratives of Renaissance exploration, proposing that in both the protagonist is less a character than a vector through which territory is converted into narrative (Fuller and Jenkins 1995). The insight anticipated Jenkins's later account of game design as narrative architecture, in which stories are embedded in, evoked by, or emergent from navigable space (Jenkins 2004), and it drew implicitly on Michel de Certeau's distinction between the map and the tour, the totalizing view from above and the spatial practice of walking (de Certeau 1980). What the dialogue could not yet register, written before the transition to three dimensions, was the specific transformation that *Ocarina of Time* would effect: the conversion of territory from surface into interior, from a plane to be crossed into a nested series of hollows to be entered.

The formal and ontological apparatus of the discipline developed in the same years. Espen Aarseth's account of ergodic texts, which demand non-trivial effort to traverse (Aarseth 1997); Janet Murray's triad of immersion, agency, and transformation (Murray 1997); Jesper Juul's theorization of games as composites of real rules and fictional worlds (Juul 2005); and Ian Bogost's concept of procedural rhetoric, the persuasive use of computational processes (Bogost 2007), together supply the vocabulary in which this study's procedural criterion is framed. Platform studies, inaugurated by Nick Montfort and Ian Bogost's analysis of the Atari Video Computer System (Montfort and Bogost 2009), adds the insistence that the material and computational substrate of a game is not neutral with respect to its meanings—an insistence §1.4 extends to the Nintendo 64. Ludomusicology, consolidated in Karen Collins's work on interactive audio (Collins 2008) and Tim Summers's account of the functions and analysis of game music (Summers 2016), has made Kōji Kondō's scores for the series a recurrent object of analysis, though rarely in connection with the metaphysics of the instrument that sounds them.

Philosophical engagement with the series has largely taken the form of the popular anthology. *The Legend of Zelda and Philosophy* (Cuddy 2008) and the theological collection edited by Jonathan Walls (Walls 2011) contain illuminating local readings—of the Triforce as an ethics of virtue, of Link's silence, of the series' cyclical history—but share a limitation characteristic of the genre: they treat the games as illustrations of philosophical problems already formulated elsewhere rather than as sites at which problems are formulated. The game becomes an example; the philosopher becomes a commentator who arrives with the concept already in hand. The present study inverts the relation. It asks what concepts the game itself requires us to construct in order to describe what it does, and it borrows from the philosophical traditions only those instruments that the game's own structures call for.

A third body of scholarship situates the series in the history of Japanese media and its global circulation. Chris Kohler's history of Japanese game design (Kohler 2004) and Mia Consalvo's study of Japanese games in global contexts (Consalvo 2016) attend to the industrial and cultural conditions of production and reception. Koichi Iwabuchi's influential account of the "culturally odorless" (*mukokuseki*) commodity—the export product stripped of the marks of national origin to ease transnational consumption—has been widely applied to Nintendo's pseudo-European fantasy worlds (Iwabuchi 2002). Alenda Chang's ecocritical study of games (Chang 2019) opens a further line of inquiry, into the representation and simulation of nature, that bears directly on the dying guardian tree and the blighted Hyrule of the game's adult era. Each of these approaches contributes to the argument below; §1.8 contests Iwabuchi's framework at the point where it meets this particular work.

Finally, the series has generated its own official historiography. *Hyrule Historia*, published in Japan in 2011 and in English two years later, codified a chronology in which the history of the series divides into three branches at the conclusion of *Ocarina of Time*: one in which the hero's victory is followed by his return to childhood, one in which the adult world he leaves behind continues without him, and one in which he is defeated. I treat this text not as interpretive authority but as a paratext in Gérard Genette's sense, a threshold discourse that conditions reception (Genette 1987), and indeed as a primary object of analysis in its own right. Its retroactive canonization of the hero's defeat, which Chapter IV reads as a remarkable act of what I call *ludic modal realism*, belongs to the history of the work's meaning rather than supplying a key to it.

Across this literature a single lacuna recurs. Attention has been directed, often with considerable sophistication, to what the game contains—its archetypes, its spaces, its songs, its systems, its cultural codes—and almost none to what it withholds: the empty center of its sacred emblem, the voice its hero does not possess, the seven years its narrative excises, the king it never shows, the bottles it offers empty, the cavity in which its titular instrument makes sound. These withholdings are not gaps in the work but its joints. The contribution of this dissertation is to show that they form a system, that the system is coherent, and that its coherence constitutes the game's most original philosophical achievement.

1·3
Method
Resonance, Not Influence, and the Procedural Criterion

Comparative work across traditions as distant from one another as Heraclitean cosmology, Lurianic Kabbalah, and the *Kojiki* courts a familiar danger. In a celebrated presidential address to the Society of Biblical Literature, Samuel Sandmel named it *parallelomania*: the extravagance that first overstates the similarity of passages and then infers from that similarity a literary dependence flowing in a predetermined direction (Sandmel 1962). The danger is acute for a work like *Ocarina of Time*, whose syncretic world—a Gothic temple, Celtic and Hindu names, Shinto sacred trees, an Islamicate desert, an Arthurian sword in a stone—offers a near-infinite field of surface correspondence. Any sufficiently erudite reader can find almost anything in it, and the popular literature on the series has frequently done so. A method adequate to the object must therefore discipline comparison as rigorously as it licenses it.

I distinguish three tiers of evidence, each held to its own standard. The first tier is *attestation*: claims about sources supported by designers' statements, documentary records, or the traces left by production and localization. To this tier belong Miyamoto's repeated statement that the princess was named for Zelda Fitzgerald; the development team's recollection that the lock-on combat system was suggested by the staged sword-fighting (*chanbara*) performed at a Kyoto film-studio theme park, in which a hero surrounded by enemies engages them one at a time; the unambiguous borrowing of the name of the Gallo-Roman horse goddess Epona for the hero's mare; and the English localization's naming of the four ghost sisters of the Forest Temple after the March sisters of Louisa May Alcott's *Little Women*. The second tier is *onomastic and iconographic probability*: names and images that point toward a source without documentary confirmation, and whose weight must be assessed as a matter of likelihood. Here belong the resemblance of the Triforce to the *mitsu-uroko*, the three-scale crest of the Hōjō regents of Kamakura; the Japanese name of the guardian tree, *Deku*, which a Japanese ear hears as 木偶, the carved wooden figure and, by extension, the useless blockhead; and the names of the twin witches Kōtake and Kōme, which the same ear hears as "little bamboo" and "little plum." The third tier is *structural resonance*: homologies between the game and other works or traditions for which no transmission is claimed or required. Most of the dissertation's comparative claims operate at this tier, and it is this tier that demands the most stringent controls.

The controls derive in the first instance from three methodological traditions. From Aby Warburg I take the notion of *Nachleben*, the afterlife of forms: the persistence, migration, and transformation of image-formulas (*Pathosformeln*) across cultural boundaries, traced not as influence but as survival and metamorphosis, as in the panels of the unfinished *Mnemosyne Atlas* (1924–29). From Carlo Ginzburg I take the evidential paradigm, the

conjectural method of the connoisseur, the detective, and the diagnostician, which reads significance in the marginal detail rather than the declared theme (Ginzburg 1979). From Wittgenstein I take the logic of family resemblance, which licenses grouping without a common essence (Wittgenstein 1953, §§66–67), and from Mieke Bal the notion of the travelling concept, which acquires precision precisely by moving between disciplines and must be re-specified at each arrival (Bal 2002). Taken together, these license a comparative practice that seeks neither origins nor universals but configurations: recurrent arrangements of elements whose recurrence across unrelated traditions indicates a pressure exerted by the problem itself rather than a line of descent.

These authorities are, however, permissive; none supplies a criterion of exclusion. The decisive control is one I derive from the object itself, and I call it the *procedural criterion*. A structural resonance is admitted into the argument if and only if it satisfies three conditions. First, it must be *structural rather than motivic*: it must concern an arrangement of relations among elements, not the mere presence of a shared image. That the Triforce is a triad and the Christian Godhead a Trinity is a motivic coincidence of negligible evidentiary value. Second, it must be *triangulated*: the same structure must be attested in at least two traditions without plausible common descent, so that its recurrence indicates a pressure in the problem rather than an accident of transmission. Third—and this is the condition that distinguishes the method from conventional comparative mythography—it must be *procedurally enacted*: the homology must be instantiated in the game's rules, mechanics, or interface, and not merely depicted in its fiction. The proposition that the Triforce is a hollow-center structure satisfies all three conditions. It is structural; it is attested independently in Daoist cosmology, in Kawai Hayao's analysis of Japanese mythology, and in the Platonic and Kabbalistic doctrines of the receptacle; and it is enacted, because the game's rules render the center unpossessable—the relic divides when grasped by an unbalanced heart, no agent in the game ever wields it entire, and the realm that houses it assumes the form of whoever enters. The procedural criterion thereby converts comparative mythography into something closer to what Bogost calls the analysis of procedural rhetoric (Bogost 2007): an account of what a game argues through what it permits and forbids.

The method also requires a position on intention. The doctrine that the meaning of a work is not identical with its author's design (Wimsatt and Beardsley 1946), Roland Barthes's polemic against the author as the closure of the text (Barthes 1967), and Michel Foucault's analysis of the author-function as a discursive principle of classification and limitation (Foucault 1969) apply to a commercial game with special force. *Ocarina of Time* was produced by a team of several dozen people across several years under industrial constraints of schedule, memory, and market; the figure of "Miyamoto" that circulates in game journalism as the auteur of the series is, in Foucault's precise sense, a function of discourse rather than the name of a sovereign intention. Designers' statements are accordingly admitted here as evidence at the first tier—as testimony concerning sources and practices—but never as

interpretive authority. The meanings this study attributes to the game are attributed to its structures, which are public, rather than to its makers' minds, which are not.

Finally, the method must account for the peculiar position of the interpreter of a game. Hans-Georg Gadamer took play (*Spiel*) as the clue to the ontology of the work of art: play possesses its own essence independent of the consciousness of those who play; it is a to-and-fro movement that absorbs the players into itself, so that all playing is a being-played (Gadamer 1960). Eugen Fink, Heidegger's interlocutor in the Heraclitus seminars, went further, proposing that play is the human activity in which the cosmos symbolizes itself (Fink 1960). The interpreter of a game is a player before she is a reader; her understanding is achieved in the medium of the play it interprets. Gadamer also insisted upon the hermeneutic priority of the question, whose essence is to open possibilities and to keep them open. Interpretation, on this account, begins with an act of hollowing—the clearing of a space in which the work may answer—and the method of this study is in that sense an application of its thesis to itself. Before the work can sound, room must be made for it.

1.4
The Material Ground
Platform, Constraint, and the Overdetermined Void

A dissertation on emptiness in a Nintendo 64 game must confront an obvious objection at the outset: the emptiness may be technical before it is metaphysical. Friedrich Kittler's dictum that media determine our situation (Kittler 1986) and the program of platform studies (Montfort and Bogost 2009) both insist that the meanings of a computational work are conditioned by its hardware, and the Nintendo 64 imposed severe and well-documented constraints. Its Reality Co-Processor drew textures from a texture memory of only four kilobytes, forcing developers toward low-resolution surfaces that bilinear filtering smoothed into the characteristic soft blur of the platform. Limits on draw distance were masked by fog. Cartridge storage, though large by the standards of 1998, amounted to a small fraction of the optical media available to competing machines. Hyrule Field, the vast central plain that critics then and since have described as barren, is empty in part because the machine could not afford to fill it.

The objection is correct and, properly understood, strengthens the argument rather than weakening it. The concept required here is Louis Althusser's *overdetermination*: the principle that a given formation is the condensed effect of multiple determinations operating at different levels, none of which is its sole cause (Althusser 1962). The void of *Ocarina of Time* is overdetermined. It is technical, a function of memory budgets, polygon counts, and the cost of rendering. It is aesthetic, an inheritance, conscious or not, of the East Asian valorization of the interval (*ma* 間)—the unpainted silk, the pause between notes,

the gravel field of the dry garden—which gives what surrounds it its form and weight. And it is metaphysical, the articulation across fiction and rules of a position on emptiness as generative. To demonstrate the first does not refute the third; it shows, rather, that the work converted a material scarcity into a formal resource, as works of art have always done with the limits of their media. Theodor Adorno's claim that artistic form is sedimented content (Adorno 1970) has a technical corollary: constraint, once worked through, becomes style. The fog that hides the edge of the rendered world is also the haze in which the Lost Woods swallow those who stray; the bilinear blur that softens every surface is also the dreamlike indistinctness of the adult era's ruined kingdom.

The constraint that matters most for this study, however, is one not of scarcity but of form: the physical design of the controller. The Nintendo 64 controller, with its three-pronged grip, its central analog stick, its trigger set beneath the grip, and its cluster of four yellow C-buttons on the right face, became in *Ocarina of Time* an instrument in the literal sense. The game mapped five pitches of a gapped scale—D, F, A, B, and the D above—onto the A button and the four C-buttons, and permitted the player to bend pitch and add vibrato with the analog stick. Each of the twelve songs that structure the game's progression is performed by pressing these buttons in sequence. The face of the controller thus became the finger-holes of a vessel flute, and the player's hands acquired, over dozens of hours, a motor memory of melodies that many retain decades later. Chapter VII develops the phenomenology of this incorporation through Merleau-Ponty's account of the organist who, given an unfamiliar instrument, learns within an hour to inhabit it as an extension of the body schema (Merleau-Ponty 1945). It suffices here to note that the game's titular object is not merely represented on the screen but realized in the hands. The Ocarina Principle is, among other things, a principle of the interface.

Two further material facts deserve notice. First, the game supported Nintendo's Rumble Pak, a vibration accessory inserted into the controller, and built around it a quest item, the Stone of Agony, that caused the controller to tremble when the player drew near a hidden grotto. The game thereby added to the visual and auditory channels a tactile organ of divination: a dowsing stone that converts proximity to concealed space into vibration in the palm. The hidden hollow announces itself to the body before it appears to the eye. Second, the work exists amid a cloud of virtual doubles that are themselves material. The second quest planned for the 64DD, known in development as *Ura Zelda*, its dungeons rearranged, was eventually released in 2002 as *Master Quest* on a promotional GameCube disc; revisions of the original cartridge altered content—including, as Chapter VI discusses, a chant in the Fire Temple and an emblem borne on the desert people's shields; and the 2011 remake for the Nintendo 3DS re-rendered the whole. The work is identical with none of these objects. It is, in the vocabulary of media archaeology, a dispersed object whose variants must be read together (Parikka 2012), and its own material history enacts in advance the multiplication of timelines with which its ending would later be credited.

1·5
The Ocarina Principle
Definition, Axioms, Corollaries

The instrument repays closer attention before it is made into a concept. The modern ocarina takes its name from the Bolognese dialect word for a little goose, and its European form is conventionally dated to Giuseppe Donati of Budrio, who in 1853 refined earlier vessel whistles into a tuned instrument. Its lineage is far older and far wider: the Chinese *xun*, a vessel flute of fired clay attested in Neolithic sites, and the vessel whistles of Mesoamerica belong to the same family. What unites the family is an acoustic principle that Hermann von Helmholtz analyzed in the 1860s (Helmholtz 1863). In a tubular flute, pitch is a function of the effective length of a vibrating column of air, and therefore of the *position* of the uncovered hole along the tube; the player's fingers move along a line. In a vessel flute, by contrast, the instrument behaves as a resonator whose pitch is determined, to a first approximation, by the relation between the volume of the enclosed cavity and the total area of its openings:

$$f \approx \frac{c}{2\pi}\sqrt{\frac{A}{V\,L_{\text{eff}}}}$$

Here c is the speed of sound, V the volume of the cavity, A the summed area of the open apertures, and L_eff an effective length associated with them. Where the holes are does not, in the ideal case, matter. What matters is how much of the vessel stands open.

This acoustic difference is a difference of temporal topology, and it furnishes the first evidence that the game's choice of instrument is not decorative. The tubular flute models time as a line: one's position along it determines what sounds. The vessel flute models time as a volume: what sounds is a function of the relation between an enclosed whole and its apertures. A game whose hero plays a vessel flute in order to move through time is a game in which time is imagined not as a road one travels but as a chamber one opens. The narrative bears this out. In *Ocarina of Time* the hero does not travel backward and forward along a continuous line; he is withdrawn from time into a sealed chamber for seven years and released into a different age, and he moves thereafter between two ages by a gesture of insertion and withdrawal—placing the sword into its pedestal, drawing it out again—that has the logic of closing and opening a vessel rather than of traversing a road.

The principle may now be stated formally. *The Ocarina Principle*: in *Ocarina of Time*, meaning, power, and time are generated by structured emptiness animated by a breath from outside; capacity is prior to content; and the vacancy of the center is the condition of the integrity of the whole. The principle decomposes into five axioms, each of which the subsequent chapters demonstrate at the levels of both fiction and rule.

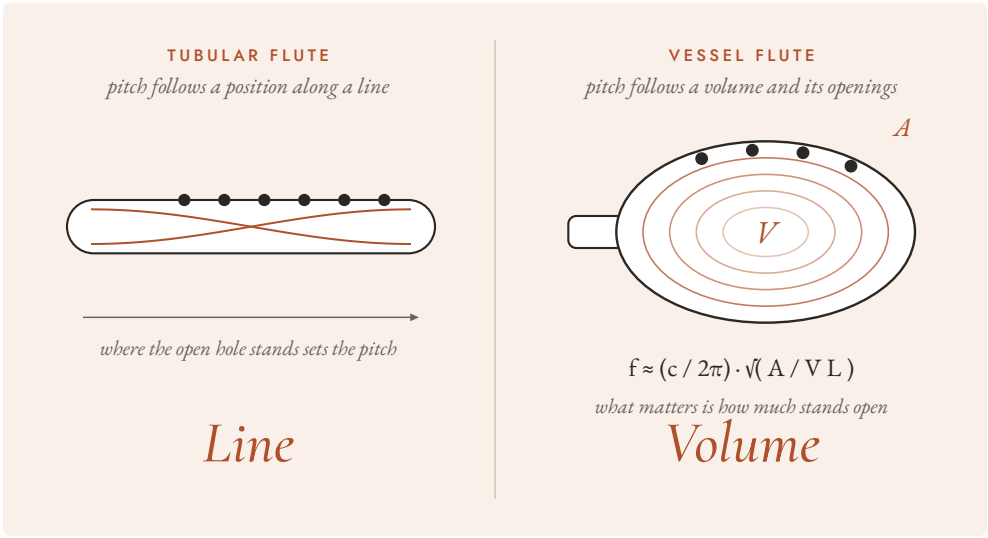


FIGURE 1.1 *Line and Volume*

In a tubular flute, pitch follows the position of the open hole along a line; in a vessel flute it follows the relation between the volume of the cavity and the area of its openings, wherever the holes are placed (Helmholtz 1863). The first models time as a road, the second as a chamber (§1.5).

Axiom I (of the Receptacle). Capacity precedes and conditions content. What the game values most is not what fills its containers but the containers themselves, and growth in the game consists in the enlargement of capacity rather than the accumulation of contents. (Demonstrated in §1.6 and Chapter V.)

Axiom II (of Breath). No vessel signifies without animation from outside itself. The ocarina is mute until breathed into; the hero is mute until played; the Sacred Realm is formless until entered. The animating breath appears in the fiction as music, wind, and spirit, and in the rules as the player's input. (Chapters IV and VII.)

Axiom III (of the Vacant Center). Every triadic structure in the game—the Triforce, the triad of creator goddesses, the triad of Spiritual Stones, the triad of protagonists—is arranged around a center that is empty and must remain so. Evil is defined formally as the attempt to occupy that center. (Chapters II and VI.)

Axiom IV (of the Two Emptinesses). The game distinguishes a privative hollowness, emptiness as loss, from a receptive emptiness, emptiness as capacity, and its moral topology is a passage through the first to the second. (§1.7 and Chapter VIII.)

Axiom V (of Kenochrony). Time in the game is figured as a vessel to be filled and emptied rather than as a line or a circle, and its highest gift is the restoration of unfilled time. (Chapters III and IV.)

From these axioms follow the corollaries that organize the dissertation. From Axioms I and III follows the distinction between *chōric sovereignty*—rule that preserves a vacant

center, figured in the game by an unseen king, a disguised princess, and a realm that becomes what its entrant is—and *plenary sovereignty*, rule that seeks to fill and possess the center, figured by Ganondorf. From Axioms II and V follows the *Triforce of Time*, the arrangement of *Chronos*, *Kairos*, and *Aion* around a receptacle outside time. From Axioms I and IV follows the *vessel economy*, the game's distinctive system of progression. And from the conjunction of Axiom V with the series' official historiography follows *ludic modal realism*, the retroactive conversion of the player's merely possible defeat into an actual historical branch.

The axioms are not inventions *ex nihilo*. They condense a tradition of reflection on generative emptiness that is among the most widely distributed in human thought, and the dissertation draws upon it throughout. The *Daodejing* locates the usefulness of the wheel in its empty hub, of the pot in its hollow, of the room in its doors and windows, and likens the space between heaven and earth to a bellows, empty yet inexhaustible, yielding more the more it moves (*Daodejing* §§5, 11). The *Zhuangzi* opens its second chapter with the piping of earth, the music produced when wind passes through the hollows of great trees, and makes it a figure for the way in which the ten thousand things sound forth, each in its own voice (*Zhuangzi*, ch. 2). Plato's *Timaeus* posits, alongside the forms and their copies, a third kind, the receptacle or *chōra*, which must be devoid of every form in order to receive them all, as the base of a perfume must be odorless (*Timaeus* 48e–52d); Jacques Derrida's essay on *khōra* and Julia Kristeva's semiotic *chora* extend the figure into deconstruction and psychoanalysis (Derrida 1993; Kristeva 1974). Paul's hymn in the letter to the Philippians speaks of one who "emptied himself" (*heauton ekenōsen*, Phil. 2:7), founding a theology of kenosis; Isaac Luria imagined creation as beginning in a divine self-contraction (*tzimtzum*) that vacates a space for the world (Scholem 1941); Simone Weil made decreation the center of her spirituality (Weil 1947). Heidegger's lecture "The Thing" locates the thingness of a jug not in its clay but in the void that holds, and the essence of that holding in the gift of the outpouring (Heidegger 1950). Nishida Kitarō's place of absolute nothingness (*zettai mu no basho*) and Nishitani Keiji's account of *śūnyatā* as the field in which things are affirmed in their suchness (Nishitani 1961) give the tradition its most systematic modern statement. And Kawai Hayao's analysis of the hollow-center structure (*chūkū kōzō*) of Japanese mythology, in which divine triads repeatedly place an inactive or nearly absent deity at their center (Kawai 1982), supplies, as Chapter II will show, the most exact structural template for the Triforce.

What *Ocarina of Time* adds to this tradition is not a new doctrine but a new mode of its demonstration: a structure of emptiness that the player inhabits, enacts, and is changed by. Philosophy states the priority of the receptacle. The game makes the player covet an empty bottle.

1·6
The Vessel Economy
Preliminary Evidence

The procedural criterion requires that the Ocarina Principle be demonstrable at the level of rules before it is pursued into myth and metaphysics, and the most direct demonstration lies in the game's economy of progression. Many role-playing games of the period, following the tabletop tradition, measured the hero's growth by the accumulation of experience points and the arithmetical increase of statistics. *Ocarina of Time* has no experience points. Link does not grow stronger by accumulating numbers; he grows by acquiring tools and by *enlarging capacities*. His life is measured not in hit points but in Heart Containers—vessels by name—of which he begins with three and may come to possess twenty, the additional containers recovered from defeated guardians or assembled from fragments scattered across the world. Damage empties them; fairies, potions, and recovered hearts refill them. His magic, once granted by a Great Fairy, is a meter that another Great Fairy doubles. His wallet holds ninety-nine rupees in childhood and may be enlarged twice; his quiver, his bomb bag, and the bag that carries seeds for his slingshot are likewise expanded in stages. The rewards most prized by the completionist player are, in the great majority, not things but room for things.

The empty bottle is the purest instance. Four bottles exist in the game, each won through a different labor: gathering a villager's escaped poultry, winning a contest at a ranch, retrieving a message sent by a princess, selling the captured souls of ghosts. A bottle may hold a fairy, which will revive the hero at the moment of death; potions of healing and of magic; milk; a fish; insects to be released into soft soil; the blue fire that melts enchanted ice; the souls of Poes, which may be sold. It is, in short, a universal container whose value consists in its indifference to any particular content—and the player learns very quickly that an empty bottle is worth more than any of the things it might hold, because it is potentially all of them. Giorgio Agamben's reading of Aristotelian *dynamis* as a potentiality that preserves itself as the capacity not to pass into act (Agamben 1999) finds in the empty bottle an almost diagrammatic object: its value is a reserve of possible contents, and to fill it is to spend it. The most celebrated bottled object in the game—the letter from the Zora princess found floating in Lake Hylia, a literal message in a bottle—underlines the point. The vessel is a medium, and its emptiness is what allows it to carry.

The same logic structures space. Every major dungeon in the game is an interior, and nearly every one is the interior of a body or a container: the hollow trunk of the guardian tree; a cavern within a mountain whose entrance is a giant skull; the belly of a living fish deity; a manor in the woods; the core of a volcano; a temple beneath a lake; a crypt beneath a graveyard and a chamber of torments at the bottom of a dry well; the inside of a colossal statue in the desert. Treasure is found in chests, which are found in rooms, which are nested

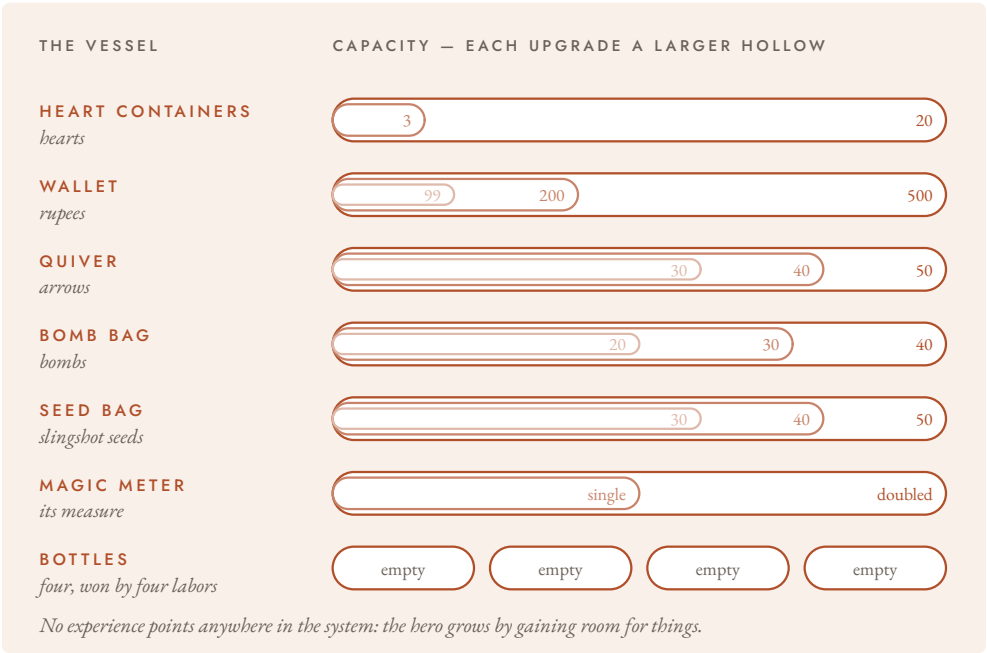


FIGURE 1.2 *Room for Things*

The vessel economy. Each upgrade is drawn as a larger hollow around the last: hearts from three to twenty; the wallet from 99 to 200 to 500 rupees; quiver, bomb bag, and seed bag in stages; the magic meter doubled; four bottles, each won by a different labor (§1.6).

within the hollows of the world. Gaston Bachelard devoted a chapter of *The Poetics of Space* to drawers, chests, and wardrobes as the organs of intimate interiority, and another to the dialectic of inside and outside (Bachelard 1958). Chapter V shows that the dungeons of *Ocarina of Time* constitute a systematic exploration of that dialectic, ordered by Bachelard's own poetics of the elements.

The most notorious dungeon in the game, and perhaps in the medium, makes the principle its explicit puzzle. The Water Temple, beneath Lake Hylia, is solved by raising and lowering the level of water within it; its central variable is the fill-state of a vessel. Players' frustration with it is legendary, and the frustration is instructive. It arises because the temple requires the player to think not in terms of paths through a space but in terms of the capacity of a volume—to understand that the same room is a different room at different levels of fullness. Elsewhere the ocarina itself is used to fill and to empty: the Song of Storms, played within a windmill, drains the village well and opens the dungeon at its bottom, so that music empties a container in order to make an interior accessible.

The interface completes the demonstration. *Ocarina of Time* popularized, if it did not invent, the context-sensitive action button: a single input, indicated on the screen by an icon whose label changes with the situation, which means open, speak, climb, grab, check, and

a dozen other things according to circumstance. The button is, in the precise sense Ernesto Laclau gave the term, an *empty signifier*—a signifier able to represent an entire chain of particular contents because it has been emptied of any particular content of its own (Laclau 1996). Its universality is purchased by its vacancy. And at the center of the whole apparatus stands a protagonist who does not speak. Link's silence, which Chapter VII reads through Wolfgang Iser's concept of the *Leerstelle*, the blank in a text that the reader's activity must fill (Iser 1976), and through Roman Ingarden's earlier spots of indeterminacy (Ingarden 1931), is the vessel economy's final and most consequential term. The player's agency enters the game through a hero who is, in the strict sense, hollow.

1.7
The Two Emptinesses

Were the argument to stop here, it would be vulnerable to a decisive objection: that emptiness in *Ocarina of Time* is as often a figure of horror as of grace. The game abounds in hollows that are anything but generative. In Kokiri lore, children who lose their way in the Lost Woods become Skull Kids and adults become Stalfos, animate skeletons; the townspeople of the castle market, in the adult era, have become ReDeads, mummified husks whose shriek paralyzes; the Bottom of the Well houses a creature composed of grasping arms rising from the earth; the Poes are souls without bodies; and Dark Link, in the Water Temple, is the hero's own form emptied of everything but imitation. Hyrule itself, in the seven years of the usurper's reign, becomes a landscape of evacuation: the great lake drained, the Zora domain frozen into stasis, the market deserted. An account of the game that celebrated emptiness without qualification would be refuted by the game.

The objection is answered by Axiom IV, which draws on the most consequential distinction in modern Japanese philosophy of nothingness. In *Religion and Nothingness*, Nishitani Keiji distinguished *nihility* (*kyomu* 虚無)—the relative nothingness that opens like an abyss beneath the self when the meaning of its world collapses, the nothingness of European nihilism—from *emptiness* (*kū* 空, *śūnyatā*), an absolute nothingness that is not opposed to being but is the field in which beings are affirmed as what they are (Nishitani 1961). Nihility, for Nishitani, is not to be avoided but traversed; the breakthrough to emptiness occurs at the bottom of nihility, not beside it. *Ocarina of Time* is organized by precisely this distinction and precisely this itinerary. Its privative hollows—Stalfos, ReDeads, Skull Kids, the evacuated landscapes of the adult era—are emptiness as *kyomu*. Its receptive hollows—the ocarina, the bottle, the Sacred Realm in its purity, the vacant center of the Triforce, the silent hero—are emptiness as *kū*. And the hero's journey leads through the first to the second: through the nihility of a ruined Hyrule to an ending in which time itself is returned empty.

The game also supplies, with remarkable economy, a criterion for distinguishing the two. Consider the Lost Woods. Those who enter without guidance become hollow; those who follow the music—the melody associated with Saria, audible from the correct passage at each junction—find their way through. The difference between the two emptinesses, in the forest, is whether breath passes through. This is the *Zhuangzi*'s piping of earth exactly: the hollows of the great trees are so many mute cavities until the wind sounds them, and then each sings in its own voice. The privative hollow is a vessel through which no breath passes; the receptive hollow is a vessel that is sounded. The rules enact the distinction in a small episode easily overlooked. A Skull Kid stands upon a stump in the Lost Woods—one of the lost children whom the forest has hollowed. If the player performs Saria's Song for him, he rewards the hero with a Piece of Heart: a fragment of a vessel of life. The hollow that is sounded yields capacity. The game could hardly state Axiom IV more compactly.

The distinction also situates *Ocarina of Time* within the subsequent history of the medium. Thirteen years later, Hidetaka Miyazaki's *Dark Souls* (FromSoftware, 2011) would build an entire cosmology around the condition of going Hollow—the progressive loss of humanity by which the cursed undead become mindless husks—and would make the central choice of its world whether to link the fire that sustains a dying age. The verbal echo of the *Zelda* protagonist's name is probably fortuitous; the structural inversion is not. *Dark Souls* is a game of *kyomu*, in which the hollow is damnation and the cycle of ages a curse to be endured; *Ocarina of Time* is a game of *kū*, in which the hollow is capacity and the cycle a

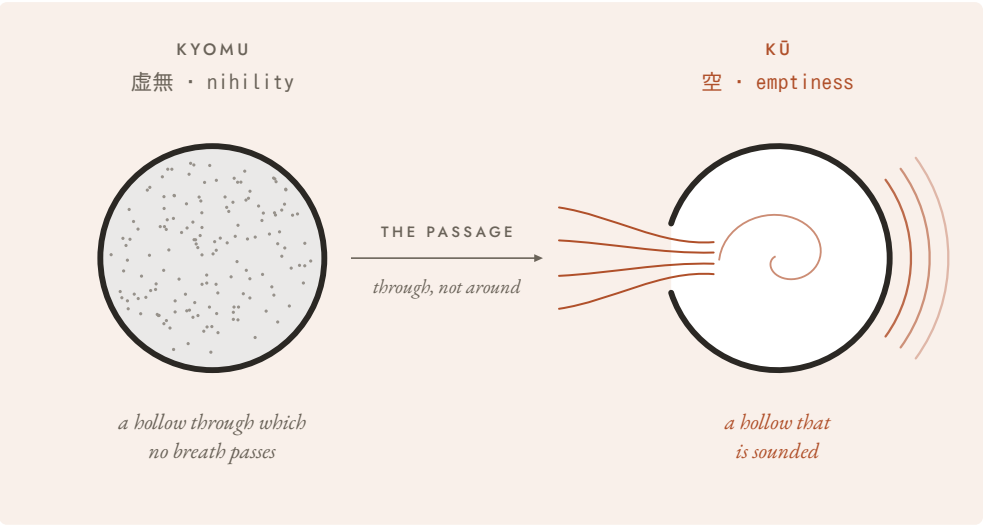


FIGURE 1.3 *The Two Emptinesses*

Nishitani's distinction as the Lost Woods enact it: a hollow through which no breath passes (*kyomu*, nihility) and a hollow that is sounded (*kū*, emptiness). The hero's itinerary leads through the first to the second (§1.7, Axiom IV).

gift to be received. The conclusion of this dissertation returns to the comparison as the basis of a normative criterion for game design.

1.8 The Japanese Inflection and Its Critique

The argument thus far might seem to support a familiar thesis: that *Ocarina of Time*, beneath its European costume, expresses a distinctively Japanese aesthetics and metaphysics of emptiness. The thesis has a respectable genealogy and considerable evidence. Against Iwabuchi's account of the culturally odorless commodity (Iwabuchi 2002)—which would read the game's pseudo-European castle, knights, and Gothic temple as a deliberate suppression of national marks—one can adduce a surprising quantity of encrypted Japaneseness. The in-world script inscribed on the game's signs and doors, which careful readers have shown to encode the Japanese kana syllabary, makes Hyrule's sacred writing Japanese in disguise. The guardian tree is a Shinto *goshinboku*, a sacred tree marked as the dwelling of a deity. The fish god of the Zora recalls the whale-deities of Japanese fishing communities. The song that summons the sun recalls the ritual noise—birdsong, dance, divine laughter—that lured Amaterasu from the Rock Cave of Heaven in the *Kojiki*. And the most persistent gesture of the entire series, the hero cutting grass with his sword in search of hidden things, literally performs the name of Japan's sacred sword, *Kusanagi*, the "grass-cutter." Miyamoto himself has described his game worlds as *hakoniwa*, miniature box gardens, using a word that in Japanese clinical psychology also names the sandplay therapy Kawai Hayao introduced from Jungian practice in 1965. On this evidence the odor has not been removed. It has relocated from iconography into structure, and the most structural element of all, the empty center, is the most Japanese.

I shall defend a version of this thesis, but only after disarming the form in which it is usually advanced. The discourse that identifies emptiness as the essence of Japanese culture belongs to the genre of *nihonjinron*, theories of Japanese uniqueness, whose essentialism and political uses have been subjected to sustained critique (Dale 1986; Befu 2001). Roland Barthes's *Empire of Signs*, which famously described Tokyo as a city whose center is empty—the walled and invisible imperial precinct around which traffic perpetually turns—is at once a brilliant meditation on the hollow center and a Western fantasy of the Orient as a realm of pure signifiers (Barthes 1970). More troubling still, the philosophy of nothingness was implicated in Japanese imperialism. Members of the Kyoto School took part in the wartime roundtables on the world-historical standpoint of Japan and in the 1942 symposium on "overcoming modernity," and the vocabulary of emptiness lay ready to hand for theorists of an imperial center that ruled by not appearing (Harootunian 2000; Heisig 2001). Kawai's own hollow-center analysis has been read as a late, psychologized *nihonjinron*. An argument

that celebrated the empty center as the hidden Japanese truth of *Ocarina of Time* would reproduce these mystifications.

The dissertation therefore treats emptiness not as a national essence but as a travelling concept in Bal's sense: a figure that circulates among Daoist, Buddhist, Platonic, Pauline, Kabbalistic, phenomenological, and modern Japanese traditions, acquiring a different valence at each arrival. *Ocarina of Time* is not the expression of any one of these traditions but a crossroads at which several meet. Its Japaneseness is real and specifiable—it lies in particular inflections, such as the hollow-center triad and the box-garden world—but it is a Japaneseness that already contains the *Timaeus* and the *Zohar*, as the Kyoto School's own philosophy already contained Hegel and Heidegger. Nor is the political ambivalence of the empty center a difficulty external to the argument; it is one of its objects. Chapter VI shows that the game itself registers this ambivalence. The empty center can be the site of a non-dominating sovereignty, or the mystified throne of a power that rules by not appearing; the unseen king of Hyrule and the hidden violence archived in the Shadow Temple belong to the same structure. A critical theory of the Ocarina Principle must be able to distinguish these, and its criterion, developed across the later chapters, is whether the vacancy is kept open for others or reserved for a hidden possessor.

1.9 The Architecture of the Argument

The dissertation proceeds in seven further chapters, which descend from cosmology through anthropology and time to space, politics, and play, and return at the last to the medium at large.

Chapter II, "The Golden Triangle and Its Missing Fourth," reads the game's cosmogony —the shaping of the world by the goddesses Din, Nayru, and Farore and their departure, leaving the Triforce behind—against Hesiod, the *Kojiki*, Genesis, Mircea Eliade's *deus otiosus*, and the Lurianic *tzimtzum*. It maps the Triforce onto Plato's tripartite soul and, more exactly, onto the image in the ninth book of the *Republic* of the soul as a many-headed beast, a lion, and a human being; onto Georges Dumézil's three functions; and onto the Confucian triad of wisdom, humaneness, and courage, in which, I argue, the Triforce's substitution of power for humaneness (*ren* 仁) explains why its center must remain empty. It reads the Sacred Realm as Plato's *chōra*, and the relic's division at the touch of an unbalanced heart as a psychostasia, a weighing of the soul, cognate with the Egyptian judgment of the heart and with the Kabbalistic account of evil as judgment (*din*) unbalanced by mercy.

Chapter III, "Songs of Innocence and of Experience," turns to childhood. It reads Link as the hidden child of the theogonic and messianic traditions—Zeus in the Cretan cave, Krishna among the cowherds of Vraja, Parzival in the forest of Soltane—and the Kokiri

as the inhabitants of Barrie's Neverland. It argues that the seven-year sleep is a literalized psychosocial moratorium in Erik Erikson's sense, an adolescence excised rather than lived; that the game stages and then aborts a rite of passage in the sense of Arnold van Gennep and Victor Turner; and that the ending is Zelda's act of Kleinian reparation for the theft of the hero's youth—the undoing of the forced growth that Mencius condemned in the farmer of Song who pulled at his sprouts to hasten them.

Chapter IV, "The Triforce of Time," constructs the dissertation's central temporal model. It sets Heraclitus's child-king against Hesiod's devouring Kronos; develops Augustine's threefold present, Husserl's analysis of the heard melody, Bergson's distinction between habit-memory and pure memory, and Kuki Shūzō's 1928 Pontigny lectures on recurrence; analyzes the ocarina as Helmholtz resonator and Daoist bellows; reads the Song of Storms, which the hero learns from a man who learned it from the hero, as a causal loop without origin; and analyzes the official division of the timeline into three branches as ludic modal realism. It concludes by opposing *chronophagy*, the tyrant's consumption of others' time, to *kenochrony*.

Chapter V, "The Architecture of Interiority," reads the dungeons through Bachelard's psychoanalysis of the elements, together with the labyrinth, the cave, the clepsydra, and the hollow Silenus figure of Plato's *Symposium*. It argues that the dying guardian tree, drained by a parasite set upon it by the dark lord, re-stages Tolkien's destruction of the Two Trees of Valinor; that the belly of Jabu-Jabu unites Jonah, Pinocchio, and the night-sea journey; and that a hero who can only repeat the songs others teach him is Ovid's Echo, confronted in the Water Temple by the reflection of Narcissus.

Chapter VI, "The Part with No Part," develops the political theology of Hyrule: the unseen king and chōric sovereignty; Ganondorf as plenary sovereign, read through Schmitt, Plato's tyrant, Kronos, Tolkien's Melkor, and the usurper Kamsa of the *Bhāgavata Purāṇa* the desert people as Jacques Rancière's "part that has no part," with attention to the game's Orientalist codings and their later revision; the Shadow Temple as Walter Benjamin's document of barbarism; Sheik as the princess's second body; and the Sages' seal as Schmitt's *katechon* and René Girard's scapegoat.

Chapter VII, "Echo's Instrument," develops the ludic ontology implied by the preceding chapters: the mute hero as Iserian blank; the context-sensitive button as empty signifier; lock-on targeting as an ethics of attention in the sense of Simone Weil and Iris Murdoch; the controller as an extension of the body schema; death, failure, and the retroactive canonization of defeat; and the practices of the game's afterlife—speedrunning, glitch-hunting, randomization, and playground rumor—as kenotic and plenary appropriations of the work.

Chapter VIII concludes by carrying the Ocarina Principle beyond Hyrule: to *Majora's Mask*, *Breath of the Wild*, and *Dark Souls* to a critique of the plenary design of the contemporary open world, whose maps are filled to saturation with content; and, finally, to

the figure with which this chapter began, Heraclitus's child at play, to whom the kingship belongs because the child alone keeps the game open.

CHAPTER



II

The Golden Triangle and Its Missing Fourth

Cosmogony, Theodicy, and the Metaphysics of the Hollow Center

天地初發之時、於高天原成神名、天之御中主神。次高御產巢日神。次神產巢日神。此三柱神者、並獨神成坐而、隱身也。

When heaven and earth first opened, there came into being in the Plain of High Heaven a deity named Lord of the August Center of Heaven; next, the High August Generative deity; next, the Divine Generative deity. These three came into being as solitary deities, and hid their persons.

— *Kojiki* (712), opening lines (trans. mine)

δίπλ᾽ ἐρέω· τοτὲ μὲν γὰρ ἓν ηὐξήθη μόνον εἶναι / ἐκ πλεόνων, τοτὲ δ᾽ αὖ διέφυ πλέον᾽ ἐξ ἑνὸς εἶναι.

A double tale I will tell: at one time it grew to be one alone out of many, at another it grew apart to be many out of one.

— Empedocles, fr. DK 31 B17.1–2 (trans. mine)

2.1
Shaping, Withdrawal, Trace
The Structure of the Cosmogony

The world of *Ocarina of Time* receives its origin from a dying god. In the opening hours of the game, after the child hero has purged the parasite lodged within the Great Deku Tree, the tree—already beyond saving—recounts to him the making of the world before entrusting him with the Kokiri Emerald and expiring. The account is brief. Three golden goddesses descend upon a Hyrule still in chaos. Din, with arms of fire, works the land and makes its red earth; Nayru bestows wisdom upon it and endows the world with the spirit of law; Farore brings forth the living things that will uphold that law. Their labor complete, the three withdraw to the heavens, and at the point of their withdrawal a golden triangular relic remains, which thereafter grounds the providence of the world; the place where it rests becomes the Sacred Realm. The cosmogony and the bereavement that sets the hero's quest in motion coincide: the child receives his world as an inheritance from a loss. Chapter III returns to the significance of this frame. The present chapter concerns the structure of the myth itself, which, for all its brevity, is unusually exact.

Four features organize it. First, the world is not created from nothing but shaped from a prior chaos. Second, the shaping is divided among three agents performing distinct functions. Third, the agents withdraw. Fourth, a trace remains at the point of their withdrawal, and this trace founds both providence and sacred space. The sequence—shaping, withdrawal, trace—is the matrix from which the game's metaphysics unfolds, and each of its moments has analogues in the cosmogonic traditions with which the myth invites comparison.

The first feature places the Hylian myth within the large family of cosmogonies that begin not from nothingness but from formlessness. Hesiod's *Theogony* opens with Chaos (*Th.* 116), a word whose kinship with the verb *chainō*, to gape or yawn, suggests not disorder but a gap, an opening: the first being of Greek cosmogony is a chasm. Genesis begins with an earth that is *tohu wa-bohu*, formless and void, darkness upon the face of the deep, and the breath or wind of God (*ruach elohim*) moving over the waters (Gen. 1:2). Plato's demiurge takes over a visible mass in discordant and disorderly motion and brings it into order (*Timaeus* 30a). The *Kojiki* describes a young land drifting like floating oil, like a jellyfish. The common denominator of these openings is not absence but indetermination, and in the Greek case an interval: the world is made within a gap. The Hylian chaos belongs to this family. Nothing in the myth is made from nothing; everything is made within an opening that precedes it.

The second feature, the division of labor, is more distinctive. Din's work is material: she shapes the ground and gives it its color. Nayru's is formal: she gives law, measure, and wisdom. Farore's is vital: she brings forth the living. The triad thus distributes among three persons three of the four causes Aristotle distinguished (*Physics* II.3; *Metaphysics* A.3): the

material cause, the formal cause, and, in the bringing-forth of living things, the efficient or moving cause. The fourth Aristotelian cause, the final cause—that for the sake of which—is conspicuously absent. The goddesses shape, order, and animate the world, but they say nothing of its purpose, and they depart. What they leave behind is a relic that grants the wish of whoever touches it. The end of the world, its *telos*, is thereby left vacant and delegated to the heart of the one who enters the sacred place. The cosmogony supplies everything but a purpose, and in place of a purpose it supplies a receptacle for one. This is the first instance in the game's metaphysics of a structure that recurs at every level: a triad of positive terms surrounding a fourth that is present only as vacancy.

The material moment has a further resonance. The red earth that Din's burning arms produce recalls the most famous earth in the Hebrew Bible, the *adamah* from which the first human, *adam*, is formed and into whose nostrils God breathes the breath of life (Gen. 2:7). Josephus, glossing the name, explained that Adam signifies "red" because he was made from red earth (*Jewish Antiquities* 1.34). The resonance belongs to the third tier of evidence, and nothing hangs upon transmission; but the structural homology is exact. In both accounts a world is made of three moments—a ground, a law or command, and a breath that animates—and in both the ground is red. Genesis distributes these moments across the acts of one God; Hyrule distributes them across three goddesses, and thereby converts a sequence into a structure.

The third and fourth features—the withdrawal of the creators and the trace at the point of withdrawal—are the heart of the matter. The relic is defined not by what it contains but by where it is: it marks the place from which the goddesses departed. Hyrule's sacred center is constituted by an absence made into an object and a place. Here the Hylian myth converges with the *Kojiki* in a manner that the procedural criterion will show to be more than motivic. The Japanese chronicle opens, as the first epigraph records, with three deities who come into being alone and hide their persons; the first of them bears the name Lord of the August Center of Heaven, and he does nothing whatever thereafter. In both cosmogonies the beginning of the world is marked by the self-concealment of its highest powers, and the center is defined by withdrawal. Kawai Hayao's analysis of the hollow center of Japanese mythology, to which §2.5 returns, begins precisely here.

2.2
The Theology of the Trace
Deus Otiosus, Tzimtzum, *and the Idol*

Mircea Eliade observed that across a remarkable range of traditions the supreme celestial being who creates the world subsequently withdraws from it and becomes *otiosus*, idle: he is remembered, named, occasionally invoked in extremity, but the living cult passes to

nearer and more dynamic powers—deities of fertility, ancestors, spirits of place (Eliade 1949). Hyrule's religious landscape is organized in exactly this way. The goddesses receive no observable cult. The Temple of Time, the one great sacred building of the kingdom, is not a place of worship but a gate, raised by the ancient sages to guard the entrance to the Sacred Realm. Devotion, where the game shows it, is directed toward intermediate and immanent powers: the Great Deku Tree, guardian of the forest people; Lord Jabu-Jabu, the fish deity of the Zora; the Great Fairies in their fountains; the Goddess of the Sand venerated by the desert people. The departed goddesses are present only by name and by relic—and, tellingly, through the three spells that bear their names, Din's Fire, Nayru's Love, and Farore's Wind, which are received not from the goddesses but from Great Fairies acting as intermediaries. Hylian religion is a religion of mediation around a vacated summit, nearer to the immanentist ecology of the Shinto *kami* than to any theology of a present and active creator.

The trace that the withdrawal leaves admits a more exact theological comparison. Isaac Luria's Kabbalah, as reconstructed by Gershom Scholem, begins creation not with an act of emanation but with an act of contraction: the infinite (*Ein Sof*) withdraws into itself (*tzimtzum*), vacating a primordial space (*tehiru*) in which a world can exist that is not God (Scholem 1941). In the vacated space a residue of the infinite light remains, the *reshimu*, an impression left by what has withdrawn; into it a single ray of light re-enters, and vessels (*kelim*) are formed to receive it; the vessels, unable to contain the light, shatter (*shevirat ha-kelim*), and the sparks fall among the husks of the broken vessels, from which the labor of repair (*tikkun*) must gather them. The order of the Hylian myth differs—withdrawal follows the shaping rather than preceding it—but the structure of the residue is uncannily exact. The Triforce is a *reshimu*: a trace of light that remains in the place the divine has vacated. Its division into three when grasped by Ganondorf is a *shevirah*, the breaking of a vessel by a force it cannot hold. The distribution of its pieces among three bearers is a scattering of sparks. And the hero's labor is a *tikkun* that *Ocarina of Time* conspicuously leaves incomplete: the pieces are never reunited within the game, and the seal that closes the narrative imprisons the bearer of Power still holding his portion. From this angle the series as a whole is the history of a deferred repair.

Emmanuel Levinas supplies the phenomenology of such a relic. The trace, for Levinas, is not the sign of a presence but the mark of one who has passed: it signifies without making present, and it orients the one who encounters it toward an alterity that has already gone by—the meaning he found in the verse of Exodus in which Moses, sheltered in the cleft of the rock, is permitted to see only the back of the God who passes (Exod. 33:23; Levinas 1963). A relic defined by the point of departure of its makers is a trace in precisely this sense. It does not render the goddesses present; it marks their passage and orients toward their absence. A trace can be followed, guarded, honored. It cannot be possessed, because there is nothing in it to possess except the direction in which it points.

Jean-Luc Marion's distinction between the idol and the icon names the two possible relations to such a trace (Marion 1977; Marion 1982). The idol is the visible in which the gaze comes to rest: it fills the gaze and thereby reflects back to the gazer the measure of his own aim, functioning as an invisible mirror. The icon, by contrast, does not arrest the gaze but lets it pass through the visible toward an invisible that exceeds it, preserving the distance that makes the divine divine. Ganondorf's relation to the Triforce is idolatrous in exactly Marion's sense. He takes the trace for a presence, seeks to fill his gaze and his hand with it, and the relic responds by becoming the mirror of his aim: it gives him only what he already is. The hero's relation is iconic. Link never touches the Triforce; the portion that becomes his is not seized but conferred, at the moment of the relic's division, upon one whom destiny had chosen. The pre-emptive plan to secure the relic belongs not to him but to the princess, and Chapter III argues that it is precisely the error the game requires her to expiate. A comparison with Tolkien sharpens the point. When Frodo offers the Ring to Gandalf, the wizard refuses it with something close to terror, recognizing that his very desire to wield it for good would make it more terrible in his hands than in its maker's (Tolkien 1954, Book I, ch. 2). *Ocarina of Time* shares the conviction that no will, however good, can safely occupy the center, but it extends that conviction from an artifact of evil to a relic of the gods. Even the sacred, once possessed, becomes an idol.

The ethical consequence is drawn by Hans Jonas in his late meditation on the concept of God after Auschwitz (Jonas 1987). A God who has truly given himself to the world in creation, Jonas argued, has renounced the power to intervene in it; responsibility for the world's fate passes to creatures, and the divine, if it is to be helped at all, must be helped by them. The goddesses of Hyrule never intervene. There is no *deus ex machina* in *Ocarina of Time*: the realm is saved, insofar as it is saved, by seven mortal sages and a child, and by the princess's final act of restoration. A world whose providence is a relic rather than a will is a world of delegated responsibility, and its theology, compressed to a formula, is the formula of Axiom III: the divine is honored by keeping its place empty, and evil is the attempt to occupy that place.

2.3 The Weighing of the Heart

Psychostasia, Contrapasso, and the Three-Natured Soul

The operation of the relic is explained late in the game, when the princess, her disguise set aside, recounts what befell when the usurper reached it. The Triforce, she explains, is a balance that weighs three forces in the heart of whoever lays hands on it. Should the three stand in equilibrium, the bearer receives the true force by which all things may be governed; should they not, the relic divides into its components, leaving to the one who touched it the

force he most believes in and passing the other two to bearers chosen by destiny. Ganondorf kept Power; Wisdom passed to the princess and Courage to the child. The explanation is short, but it encodes a complete theory of judgment, and that theory is distinctive among the many in which a cosmic balance weighs a soul.

Psychostasia, the weighing of souls, is among the most widely distributed images of judgment. In the Egyptian Book of the Dead (spell 125), the heart of the deceased is weighed against the feather of Maat, the principle of cosmic order, and a heart heavy with wrongdoing is devoured by Ammit. In the *Iliad*, Zeus lifts golden scales and sets in them the fates of death, first of Achaeans and Trojans (8.69–74), then of Achilles and Hector, whose doom sinks toward Hades (22.209–213). The writing on Belshazzar's wall pronounces that the king has been weighed and found wanting (Dan. 5:27); the Qur'an promises just scales on the Day of Resurrection (21:47); and on the tympanum of Autun, carved by Gislebertus around 1130, an archangel and a devil contend over the pans in which souls are weighed. In all of these the balance decides a fate imposed from outside: the soul is condemned or acquitted, devoured or saved. The Triforce does neither. It does not punish; it divides. Its justice is distributive rather than retributive, and it is self-executing: the unbalanced soul receives exactly the portion it has already made its own, no more and no less.

This form of judgment has its own lineage. In the myth of Er that concludes the *Republic*, the souls choose their next lives from the lots laid before them, and the prophet proclaims: αἰτία ἑλομένου· θεὸς ἀναίτιος—the responsibility belongs to the one who chooses; the god is without blame (*Republic* 617e). Dante's sinners suffer *contrapasso*, the punishment that is the shape of the sin turned back upon the sinner (*Inferno* XXVIII.142); Swedenborg's damned are not cast into hell but go there freely, drawn by the ruling love that hell embodies (Swedenborg 1758). The Triforce is a *contrapasso* machine of exactly this kind. Ganondorf, believing in power alone, receives power alone, and the portion he keeps becomes at the last the form of his ruin: in the collapse of his tower he is transformed into the beast Ganon, the visible shape of the one thing he chose. The goddesses are, in the strict sense of the myth of Er, blameless. The relic merely returns to each the truth of his heart.

What the relic weighs, and why imbalance splits it, Plato had already explained. In the fourth book of the *Republic*, justice in the soul is the condition in which each of its three parts does its own work—reason ruling, spirit allied with reason, appetite governed—so that the person becomes one out of many (443c–e); injustice is *stasis*, civil war among the parts, a faction risen against the whole (444b). A soul in *stasis* cannot receive a whole, because it is not itself one. The division of the Triforce is the projection into the cosmos of the *stasis* within the one who grasps it: the relic splits along the fault lines of the soul that touches it.

Plato's most vivid image of this structure, in the ninth book, maps onto the game with a precision that satisfies all three conditions of the procedural criterion. Socrates asks his interlocutors to model the soul as a composite creature: a many-headed beast, ringed with the heads of tame and savage animals that it can grow and change at will; a lion; and a human

being—the three fused together and wrapped in the outer likeness of a man, so that one who sees only the exterior takes the whole for a single human (588b–589b). The unjust man feeds the beast and the lion and starves the human within, who is then dragged wherever either of the others leads; the just man makes the inner human master, takes the lion as his ally, and tends the beast as a farmer tends his stock, nourishing the gentle heads and checking the savage ones. The correspondence with the game's three bearers is close. The princess, bearer of Wisdom, is the inner human. The hero, bearer of Courage, is the lion, the spirited element whose proper office is alliance with reason. The bearer of Power is the beast. And the narrative enacts Plato's image as a sequence. Ganondorf, human in form throughout the game, wears the outer likeness of a man; in the final confrontation the likeness collapses with his tower, and what emerges is the beast that had been inside it all along, horned and boar-like, wielding two blades. The beast is overcome exactly as Plato prescribes: not by the lion alone but by the coalition of lion and human, the princess holding the creature immobile with her light while the hero strikes. Even the beast's fate follows Plato. The farmer does not exterminate his animals but governs them; the sages do not destroy Ganon but seal him.

The mapping must not be overstated. Plato's lion has corruptions of its own—swollen into a serpentine obstinacy, or degraded in the service of flattery into an ape (590a–b)—and Ganondorf's lust for domination belongs as much to a disordered spirit, the love of victory and honor run wild, as to the appetites. What the Triforce of Power names is precisely this coalition of savage appetite and corrupted spirit against reason, which is what Plato's tyrant is (*Republic* 571a–580a). The tyrant, Plato insists, is in truth the most enslaved of men, ruled by the master passion he mistook for his freedom (579d–e). The final image of Ganon—sealed in the void, still clutching the portion he chose—is the tyrant's slavery made cosmic.

One further implication concerns the unity of the virtues. Plato's *Protagoras* argues that the virtues are not separable parts but aspects of a single knowledge (329c–333b); Aristotle, more cautiously, holds that the moral virtues are reciprocal through practical wisdom, so that none can be fully possessed without the others (*Nicomachean Ethics* VI.13, 1144b30–1145a2). The Triforce's true force requires all three in balance: it is the unity of the virtues raised to a cosmic principle. But the game distributes the three among three persons, and one of them is the tyrant. The unity of the virtues therefore cannot be achieved by assembling the pieces in a single hand. The hand capable of holding all three would have to belong to someone already whole, and the only one who has tried to hold the whole is the one least capable of it. The unity exists, in Hyrule, only as the relation among the three bearers—as the space between them. It is, in the precise sense of Axiom III, the center.

2.4
Three Functions, Three Virtues, and the Missing Humaneness

Plato's tripartition belongs to a family. Georges Dumézil devoted his career to demonstrating that the Indo-European traditions organized their gods, myths, and social orders according to three functions: sovereignty in its magico-religious and juridical aspects (the paired gods Mitra and Varuṇa, Jupiter, Odin and Tyr), physical force (Indra, Mars, Thor), and fecundity, prosperity, and peace (the Nāsatya twins, Quirinus, Freyr and Njörðr) (Dumézil 1958). The Triforce's correlations seem at first straightforward. Wisdom, borne by the royal princess and associated with Nayru's gift of law, is the first function; Courage, borne by the sword-wielding hero, is the second. Where, then, is the third? In the cosmogony it is abundantly present: Din tills the land and Farore brings forth the living, labors of earth and fertility. Yet in the Triforce these same goddesses are assigned Power and Courage, both virtues of the warrior. The relic militarizes the third function. The labors of nourishment and generation become, in the triangle that grounds providence, virtues of force. Hyrule's sacred emblem contains no virtue of care.

Dumézil's later work explains why the warrior function might appear twice. In the *Mahābhārata*, as Stig Wikander first showed and Dumézil developed, the warrior function is doubled in the Pāṇḍava brothers Arjuna, son of Indra, the disciplined and chivalrous warrior, and Bhīma, son of the wind god Vāyu, a warrior of brute strength and monstrous appetite (Wikander 1947; Dumézil 1968). The Triforce's Courage and Power reproduce this doubling: Link and Ganondorf are the two faces of the second function, the chivalrous and the brutal. Dumézil's study of the warrior's fate also identified a recurrent pattern, the three sins of the warrior, in which a hero of force—Starkaðr in Scandinavia, Heracles in Greece, Indra in India—commits one offense against each of the three functions and is punished or diminished in turn (Dumézil 1969). Ganondorf is the sinning warrior on a cosmic scale. Against the first function, he breaks the oath of fealty he swore before the king—the scene the child hero witnesses through a castle window—usurps the throne, and violates the Sacred Realm. Against the second, he kills not in combat but by stealth, laying a parasitic curse within the guardian tree. Against the third, he blights the fecundity of the land: in the seven years of his reign the great lake is drained, the Zora domain frozen, the ranch seized, and the market emptied of the living.

A feminine triad offers a second triangulation. The Tridevī of Purāṇic Hinduism unites three goddesses: Sarasvatī, goddess of knowledge, eloquence, and music; Lakṣmī, goddess of prosperity, fortune, and abundance; and Pārvatī, in her fierce form as Durgā, goddess of power (*śakti*) and its martial exercise. Structurally this is the nearest of all the comparanda to the three golden goddesses: a feminine triad of wisdom, power, and a third term. But where the Tridevī's third term is abundance, the Triforce's is courage. Again the virtue displaced

is the virtue of provision. Sarasvatī, it should be noted, travelled east along the routes of Buddhism to become the Japanese Benzaiten, and §2.8 shows why that fact bears on the genealogy of the Triforce itself.

The East Asian triangulation is the most precise. The *Doctrine of the Mean* (*Zhongyong*) names wisdom, humaneness, and courage (知仁勇, *zhi*, *ren*, *yong*) as the three virtues universally binding under heaven (*Zhongyong* §20), and the *Analects* twice gives the triad its classic form: the wise are free from perplexity, the humane from anxiety, the courageous from fear (*Analects* 9.29; 14.28). In Japanese the triad is read *chi*, *jin*, *yū* it recurs as a school motto and in the modern literature of bushidō (Nitobe 1900). The Japanese names of the three portions of the Triforce are *chikara* (力, power), *chie* (知恵, wisdom), and *yūki* (勇気, courage). Set beside the Confucian triad, the substitution is unmistakable: the Triforce retains wisdom and courage and replaces humaneness—*jin*, *ren*, 仁—with power.

Why should humaneness be precisely the virtue the relic cannot contain? The answer lies in the nature of *ren* itself. The *Doctrine of the Mean* glosses it with a pun that is also a definition: to be humane is to be human (仁者人也, *Zhongyong* §20). The Han commentator Zheng Xuan explained the gloss as persons in mutual regard (相人偶), and the graph itself, a person beside the numeral two, was long read as an image of the relation between two people. Watsuji Tetsurō built a modern ethics upon the same intuition, defining the human being (*ningen* 人間) not as an individual but as a betweenness (*aidagara* 間柄), a being constituted in relations (Watsuji 1937). If *ren* is relational in this strong sense, it cannot be a portion held by a single bearer, for a relation cannot be possessed by one of its terms. In a relic that distributes virtues as possessions, humaneness can appear only as the space between the pieces. This gives Axiom III its ethical content. The vacant center of the Triforce is not an accident of geometry. It is the place of the one virtue that cannot be owned.

The displaced virtue does not vanish from the game; it migrates. The three Spiritual Stones that open the Door of Time—the Kokiri Emerald, the Goron's Ruby, the Zora's Sapphire—are jewels, and in Japanese readings of the imperial regalia it is the jewel that has been associated with the benevolent virtues: Kitabatake Chikafusa's fourteenth-century account made the jewel the source of compassion, and later Confucianizing readings assigned it humaneness itself (Chikafusa 1339). In the game every one of the stones is given as a token of relationship. The dying tree bestows the emerald as a parent's bequest; the Goron chief bestows the ruby upon the hero as his sworn brother; the Zora princess bestows the sapphire as a pledge of betrothal. The keys to the sacred door are, without exception, gifts of kinship, and they are refused to Ganondorf, whom both the guardian tree and the Goron chief deny to his face. Marcel Mauss's distinction between the gift, which binds by creating relation, and the seizure, which takes without binding, here becomes the condition of access to the sacred (Mauss 1925). The tyrant can extort but cannot receive. The tragedy of the game's first act is that the keys forged by relation open the door through which the tyrant then passes: the relational virtue, displaced into the stones, is vulnerable to parasitism precisely

because it cannot defend itself by force. Chapter VI returns to this vulnerability through Michel Serres's figure of the parasite.

It is worth noting, finally, where love appears in the game's sacred vocabulary. Of the three spells named for the goddesses, one is Nayru's Love, and its effect is a crystalline barrier that shields the hero for a time while draining his magic. Love in Hyrule is not a portion of the relic and not the possession of any bearer: it is a borrowed and temporary protection, conferred by a fairy, sustained at a cost, and associated with wisdom rather than with power. The game does not lack a theory of care. It locates care outside the economy of possession.

The table below gathers the triangulations of this section and the last. In each tradition the term in the final column is the one the Triforce cannot hold.

The Kabbalistic row anticipates an argument that must be stated before the chapter moves on, because it concerns the name of the first goddess. In the Kabbalistic system of the *sefirot*, the attribute of divine might and severity, *Gevurah*, is also called *Din*, judgment. The *Zohar* and the Lurianic tradition locate the origin of evil precisely in *Din*: not in a principle external to God but in the attribute of judgment once it is separated from, and no longer tempered by, its counterpart *Ḥesed*, lovingkindness. Severity unbalanced by mercy hypertrophies, detaches itself, and becomes the "other side" (*sitra aḥra*), the domain of the demonic (Scholem 1962). Whether or not the designers knew it, the goddess of power in Hyrule bears the Kabbalistic name of severity, and the game's account of evil coincides with

TABLE 2.1 *Triadic homologies of the Triforce and their vacant or displaced term.*

TRADITION	CORRELATE OF POWER	CORRELATE OF WISDOM	CORRELATE OF COURAGE	VACANT OR DISPLACED TERM
Ocarina of Time, cosmogony	Din, maker of the red earth	Nayru, giver of law	Farore, maker of the living	the goddesses' point of departure; no stated purpose
Ocarina of Time, bearers	Ganondorf	Zelda	Link	the Sacred Realm, which mirrors its entrant
Aristotle's causes, applied to the cosmogony	material cause	formal cause	efficient cause	final cause
Plato, *Republic* 588b–589b	many-headed beast	inner human	lion	justice, the order among the three
Dumézil's three functions	brutal warrior (Vāyu, Bhīma)	sovereign (Mitra–Varuṇa)	chivalrous warrior (Indra, Arjuna)	third function: prosperity and care
Zhongyong §20	—	*zhi* 知	*yong* 勇	*ren* 仁, humaneness
Tridevī	Pārvatī as Durgā	Sarasvatī	—	Lakṣmī, abundance
Kabbalistic *sefirot*	*din* (judgment, severity)	*ḥokhmah*	—	*ḥesed*, lovingkindness

the Kabbalistic one: Ganondorf's corruption is not the intrusion of an alien principle but *Din* without *Ḥesed*, power severed from the virtue of care that the relic cannot hold. Across five unrelated traditions, then, a single result recurs. The term missing from the Triforce is the virtue of benevolent relation—humaneness, mercy, abundance, care—and its absence is what the center of the triangle marks.

2.5 The Fourth That Is Not Filled

Jung, Kawai, and the Geometry of the Void

Geometry first. The Triforce is an equilateral triangle divided by the lines joining the midpoints of its sides into four congruent triangles: three upright and golden, one inverted and empty. The empty triangle is not a remainder or a gap left between the others. It is congruent with them, identical in size and shape, a full member of the figure present only as absence. Considered as a figure, the Triforce is a quaternity that presents itself as a trinity. Its fourth term is not missing; it is there, at the center, holding the three apart and together.

Carl Gustav Jung would have recognized the figure at once. In his essay on the dogma of the Trinity (first delivered at Eranos in 1940, published in 1942, and revised in 1948), Jung argued that the Trinity, considered as a symbol of the self, is incomplete. Wholeness, in the symbolism he traced through alchemy, Gnosticism, and the dreams of his patients, is quaternary, and the fourth that the Trinity excludes is variously evil, matter, and the feminine; he would later welcome the 1950 definition of Mary's Assumption as a partial admission of the fourth into the godhead (Jung 1952). He found the formula of this completion in an alchemical axiom attributed to Maria the Prophetess, which he cited repeatedly: one becomes two, two becomes three, and out of the third comes the one as the fourth (Jung 1944). The Triforce illustrates the axiom with diagrammatic clarity. The fourth triangle arises from the arrangement of the three, and it is the One, since the unity of the figure is its central void. Yet here the game parts from Jung decisively. For Jung the fourth is a content—the repressed shadow, matter, the feminine—awaiting integration, and wholeness is achieved when it is admitted. For the game the fourth is a vacancy, and the integrity of the whole depends on its remaining empty. The only figure in the game who pursues wholeness in Jung's sense, the integration of all three portions into a single possession, is Ganondorf. The Triforce corrects Jung, as it were, by way of Kawai.

Kawai Hayao, the first Japanese analyst trained at the Jung Institute in Zurich, spent a career both applying and revising Jung, and his analysis of the *Kojiki* identified a recurrent structure that the Western master's framework could not accommodate: triads of deities whose middle term is inactive or nearly absent (Kawai 1982). Among the three deities of the opening, the Lord of the August Center of Heaven, named first, does nothing and

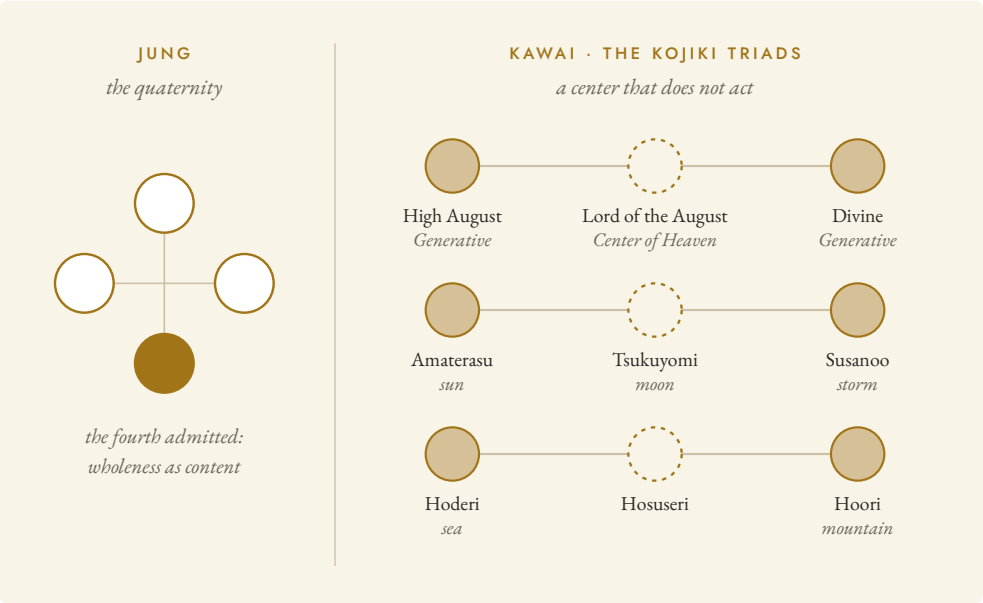


FIGURE 2.1 *The Fourth That Is Not Filled*

Jung completes the three by admitting a fourth content. Kawai finds in the *Kojiki* triads whose middle term does not act, holding opposed terms in balance; the three triads are those named in §2.5 (after Kawai 1982).

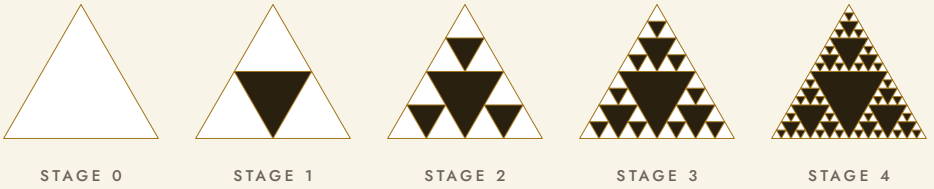
disappears. Among the three noble children born from Izanagi's purification, Tsukuyomi, deity of the moon, set between the sun goddess Amaterasu and the storm god Susanoo, has almost no part in the narrative. Among the three sons born to Konohanasakuya-hime in the burning hut, Hosuseri, between the fisherman Hoderi and the hunter Hoori, does nothing at all. In each case the opposed terms on either side—sun and storm, sea and mountain—are held in balance by a center that does not act. Kawai contrasted this structure with those he took to characterize Western myth and thought, in which a dominant center, whether a single god, a ruling principle, or an integrating ego, unifies the whole by subordinating its parts, and he proposed that the Japanese psyche and Japanese society are organized around a hollow center that balances rather than rules.

Kawai's model is open to the critiques rehearsed in §1.8, and he was himself alert to the structure's characteristic danger. A center kept empty is vulnerable to invasion: any sufficiently forceful principle that enters it may seize the whole, and Kawai read the militarism of the 1930s in this light. Maruyama Masao's postwar analyses of ultranationalism describe the same pathology from the side of political science, as a system in which ultimate authority resides nowhere and responsibility everywhere evaporates (Maruyama 1946). The narrative of *Ocarina of Time* is Kawai's warning dramatized. The Sacred Realm, the hollow center of the world, is entered by the most forceful will in the kingdom, and the whole realm falls under his power. The game thus displays both the virtue and the peril of the hollow center,

and its answer to the peril is the decisive point. It does not propose to fill the center with a better principle—to set the hero, or the princess, or a reformed monarchy where the tyrant stood—which would be the remedy Kawai associated with the West, the replacement of a bad center by a good one. It re-hollows the center. The invader is sealed; the princess returns the hero to his childhood rather than crowning him; and the throne of Hyrule remains, from the first scene to the last, unseen. That the center can be taken is the price of its being a center at all.

Geometry supplies one further figure. If the operation that produces the Triforce—dividing a triangle into four and leaving the central one empty—is applied again to each of the three remaining triangles, and again to each of the nine that result, and so on without end, the limit is the figure Wacław Sierpiński described in 1915 (Sierpiński 1915). The Sierpiński triangle has a curious property: in the limit its area is zero, yet it is not a line. Its Hausdorff dimension is log 3 / log 2, approximately 1.585, strictly between that of a line and that of a plane. The figure is all structure and no surface, a lattice of vacancies held together by edges. I offer this not as a claim about intention but as a heuristic for the series, which repeats the triad and its central void in installment after installment, each a further subdivision of the same figure. Its limit would be neither a story, a figure of dimension one, nor a world, a figure of dimension two, but something between: a self-similar structure of relations whose substance is its emptiness. There is perhaps no better geometric emblem for a franchise that has told what is in effect a single tale through many variations.

Heidegger offers the same thought in the idiom of the thing. In his lecture "The Thing," he argued that the thingness of the jug lies not in its walls or its base but in the void that holds; the potter shapes the clay only in order to shape the void, and the void's holding is gathered in the outpouring, the gift in which, he claimed, earth and sky, divinities and mortals are gathered together (Heidegger 1950). The Triforce's central void is a gathering



area tends to zero · dimension log 3 / log 2 ≈ 1.585 · vacancies shaded

FIGURE 2.2 *The Operation Iterated*

Divide a triangle by joining the midpoints of its sides, leave the central triangle empty, and repeat in each triangle that remains: the limit is the figure Sierpiński described in 1915, all structure and no surface (§2.5).

of this kind. It holds the three apart so that they may be a whole. A triangle whose center was filled would no longer be the Triforce; it would be a single undivided triangle of gold, in which the three virtues had collapsed into one undifferentiated mass—which is to say, into the object of Ganondorf's desire.

2.6
The Sacred Realm as *Chōra*
The Mirror, the Zone, and the Grail

The Triforce rests in the Sacred Realm, and the game's exposition describes that realm in a single, decisive property: it reflects the heart of whoever enters it. A pure heart makes it a paradise; a wicked one makes it a domain of evil, and after the usurper's entry it darkens accordingly. The realm has no character of its own. It is what its entrant is.

No concept in the Western tradition fits this description more exactly than the third kind of Plato's *Timaeus*. Having distinguished the eternal forms from their perishable copies, Timaeus finds himself compelled to posit a third: the receptacle (*hypodochē*), the nurse of all becoming, the *chōra* in which copies come to be (48e–52d). It must be devoid of every form in order to receive all forms, as those who make perfumed ointments begin with a base that has no odor of its own (50e); it is neither earth nor air nor fire nor water but an invisible and formless kind that partakes of the intelligible in a most perplexing way (51a). It is apprehended, Timaeus says, not by sense and not by intellection but by a kind of bastard reasoning, and we look upon it as in a dream (52b). Each property recurs in the Sacred Realm. It is formless in itself and takes the shape of what enters it. It receives everything, paradise or hell. And it is known only by a kind of bastard reasoning and as in a dream. The game never displays the realm to the player as such. The player knows it by report and by its effects; the princess knows it through her prophetic dreams; and the hero's one sojourn there is seven years of sleep, in a chamber said to lie at the realm's very center. The Sacred Realm is apprehended, in the strict Platonic sense, only as in a dream.

The *Timaeus* adds a further property that the Triforce enacts. The receptacle, filled with unlike and unbalanced powers, is shaken by them and in turn shakes them, sorting like from like as a winnowing basket separates the heavy grain from the light chaff (52e–53a). This is precisely what the relic does when an unbalanced heart grasps it. The forces in that heart are sorted into their kinds, and each is sent to its like: Power remains with the one who loves power, Wisdom passes to the wise, Courage to the brave. The *chōra* is a winnower, and so is the Triforce.

The figure has had two important modern afterlives. Jacques Derrida's essay on *khōra* insisted on its strangeness: it is neither sensible nor intelligible, gives place without being a place, and is called mother and nurse only by a catachresis that names what has no proper

name (Derrida 1993). Julia Kristeva, by contrast, gave the term a psychoanalytic content, using *chora* to name the maternal, rhythmic, pre-symbolic space of the drives that precedes and underlies the symbolic order of language and law (Kristeva 1974). Both will matter later. Derrida's insistence that the receptacle cannot be appropriated anticipates the political argument of Chapter VI; Kristeva's rhythmic *chora* anticipates Chapter VII's reading of the ocarina's songs as a mode of signification beneath and before speech.

The Sacred Realm also belongs to a modern family of reflective receptacles: places that return to their entrant the truth of his desire. In Arkady and Boris Strugatsky's *Roadside Picnic* (1972), a golden sphere at the heart of the Zone grants wishes. In Andrei Tarkovsky's adaptation, *Stalker* (1979), the Room at the center of the Zone grants not the wish one declares but the one that is innermost, and the guide's story of his mentor Porcupine—who entered to ask for his brother's life, received a fortune instead, and hanged himself—establishes the Room as a mirror of the heart. Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) imagines an ocean that materializes from the minds of its visitors the figures of their guilt. The ending of *Stalker* illuminates the end of *Ocarina of Time*. The Professor has carried a bomb into the Zone to destroy the Room lest it fall into evil hands; at the threshold he does not detonate it. The sages, likewise, do not destroy the realm or the relic. They seal the usurper and leave the receptacle intact. The receptacle must be preserved even though it can be corrupted, because its corruptibility is the price of its receptivity. A receptacle that could not become hell could not become paradise. W. W. Jacobs's "The Monkey's Paw" (1902) grants wishes with malignant literalness; the Triforce grants them with ethical literalness, and the difference is the whole of its theology.

The oldest member of the family is the Grail, and in the version closest to the Triforce it is a stone. In Wolfram von Eschenbach's *Parzival* (c. 1200–1210), the Grail is a stone of mysterious name that sustains the company of its castle; it cannot be won by force, nor found by those who seek it; and upon it, the hermit Trevrizent explains, there appear in writing the names of those summoned to its service (Book IX). The Triforce chooses its bearers as the Grail does, and in both the seeking hand is the mark of the unworthy. The Grail's wounded king, who sought love outside the order the Grail appoints, lies in agony until a destined fool raised in the forest asks him the question of compassion; the guardian tree of the Kokiri, cursed and dying, has awaited a boy raised in the forest. Chapter III takes up this parallel at length. It suffices here to note that the Grail and the Triforce share the defining property of the *chōra*. They are what they are by receiving, and they cannot be taken.

2.7 Ludic Theodicy

Leibniz's Pyramid, Suits's Obstacles, and the Child's Tears

A theology of the vacated center raises at once the problem of evil in its sharpest form. If the goddesses left behind a relic that grants the wish of whoever touches it, and if the most forceful will in the world was bound sooner or later to reach it, why did they leave it at all? And why should a world so arranged be accounted good? The question is not idle within the fiction. It presses upon every player who notices that Hyrule's providence is a device that can be captured.

The most elaborate answer in the Western tradition is Leibniz's, and its final image is, strikingly, a pyramid. At the close of the *Theodicy* (§§405–417), continuing Lorenzo Valla's dialogue on free will, Leibniz tells of the priest Theodorus, led by Pallas through the Palace of the Fates: a pyramid of apartments, each containing a possible world, in each of which a different Sextus Tarquinius lives a different life. The worlds grow more beautiful as Theodorus ascends; the apartment at the apex holds the best of all possible worlds, which is the actual one, and in it Sextus commits the crime against Lucretia from which the Roman Republic and all its greatness follow. The pyramid, Leibniz specifies, has an apex but no base; it descends without end through ever worse worlds (§416). Two features of the fable bear on Hyrule. The first is its structure: a pyramid of possible worlds whose apex is the actual one, in which a single crime is the condition of the good that follows. Ganondorf is Hyrule's Sextus. His usurpation is the condition of the Hero of Time; without the tyrant there would be no Courage to confer, no sages to awaken, no hero at all. The second is its multiplicity. Leibniz's palace contains the possible worlds that the actual one excludes, and the series' official history, as Chapter IV argues, has done what Leibniz could not: it has built the excluded apartments and given the world in which the hero fails a history of its own.

Leibniz's solution generalizes Augustine's, who held that God judged it better to bring good out of evil than to permit no evil to exist (*melius iudicavit de malis bene facere, quam mala nulla esse permittere Enchiridion* 27), and it echoes the Easter *Exsultet*, which calls Adam's sin a happy fault, *felix culpa*, for having merited so great a redeemer. In Hyrule the happy fault is structural rather than historical. The relic's distribution makes the tyrant one of three necessary bearers, so that evil is not an intruder into the cosmic order but a position within it. A second line of theodicy, which John Hick traced to Irenaeus, justifies evil not as the price of the greatest good in general but as the condition of moral growth in particular: the world is, in the phrase Hick took from a letter of Keats, a vale of soul-making, in which virtues such as courage can develop only in the presence of real danger (Hick 1966). The Triforce makes this structure literal. Courage is constituted relative to Power; the one virtue presupposes, as its occasion, the threat embodied by the other.

The Irenaean theodicy has a ludic counterpart, and here the game's metaphysics folds back upon its medium. Bernard Suits defined playing a game as the voluntary attempt to overcome unnecessary obstacles (Suits 1978). In a game the obstacles are the point: one could reach the finish by cutting across the infield, but one would no longer be running the race. A game's world is justified to its players by the resistance it offers, and its designer's

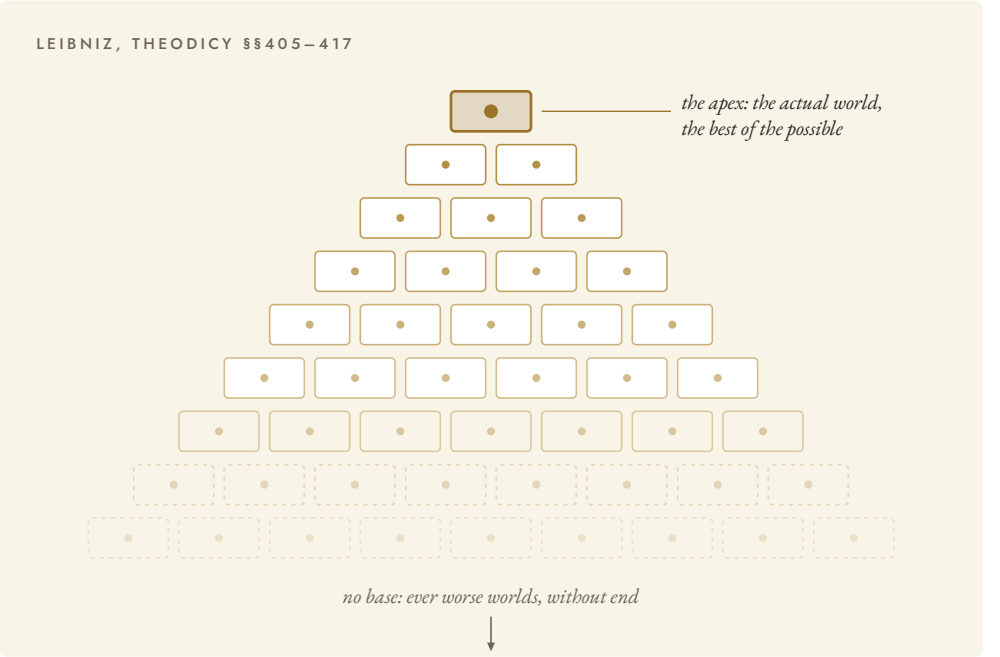


FIGURE 2.3 *The Palace of the Fates*

Leibniz's closing fable: a pyramid of apartments, each a possible world, rising to the actual world at its apex and descending without a base through ever worse worlds. Read in §2.7 as the theodicy of Hyrule.

benevolence consists precisely in the placement of difficulty. Hyrule is a world built according to this theodicy. Its makers withdraw like designers leaving a game to its players; its relic is a rule set that responds to whoever engages it; its tyrant is the necessary opposition without which no play could occur. The theodicy of Hyrule is the theodicy of play, and its cosmogony is, among other things, an allegory of its own design.

A theodicy of play, however, is an aesthetic justification, and aesthetic justifications of suffering have a famous adversary. In the chapter of *The Brothers Karamazov* titled "Rebellion," Ivan Karamazov tells his brother that if the eternal harmony must be purchased with the tears of a single tortured child, he respectfully returns his ticket (Dostoevsky 1880, Book V, ch. 4). Ivan's objection applies to Hyrule with uncomfortable force. The obstacles the goddesses permit are not borne only by those who chose to play. They are borne by the townspeople hollowed into ReDeads, by the Gorons imprisoned to feed a dragon, by the Zora frozen in their domain, and above all by a child whose youth is confiscated so that he may serve as the hero the theodicy requires. The game does not refute Ivan; its achievement is to register him. The ending, in which the princess returns the hero to the childhood the war had taken, is a partial refusal of the theodicy the cosmos enacts: an acknowledgment that the happy fault, however happy for the realm, was not happy for the one who paid

for it, and that the debt must be repaid. The ending is, in this precise sense, anti-theodical. Chapter III reads it as an act of reparation.

Two perspectives complete the picture. Empedocles' double tale, quoted at the head of this chapter, describes a cosmos that alternates without end between the dominion of Love, which gathers all things into a single sphere, and that of Strife, which divides them (DK B17). The Triforce united would be the Empedoclean sphere; the Triforce divided is the work of Strife; and the world in which we live and play is, for Empedocles as for Hyrule, the interval between, in which neither principle concludes. The series' history, in which the sealed tyrant returns in age after age, is Empedoclean rather than eschatological: it has no last judgment, only a rhythm. And Jonas's argument, already noted, supplies the ethics proper to such a rhythm. In a cosmos whose gods have withdrawn, the only theodicy available is responsibility, and creatures answer for the world in Hyrule not by justifying its evils but by sealing them.

2.8
The Scales of Enoshima and the Unseen Regalia

The comparisons of this chapter have been structural, but the Triforce also has a probable genealogy, at the second tier of evidence, in Japanese heraldry and legend, and the legend is so congruent with the Hylian cosmogony that it must be set out in full. The emblem of the Hōjō, the family of regents who governed from Kamakura through most of the thirteenth and early fourteenth centuries, is the *mitsu-uroko*, the three scales: three triangles arranged in a triangle. Its resemblance to the Triforce has often been remarked. Less often remarked is the story the emblem tells. The fourteenth-century chronicle *Taiheiki* relates that Hōjō Tokimasa, founder of the regency, withdrew in seclusion to the island shrine of Enoshima to pray for the prosperity of his descendants. A beautiful woman appeared and declared that, by the merit of a former life, his house would come to rule the land; then she became a great serpent and vanished into the sea, leaving behind three great scales, which Tokimasa took as his family's crest. The deity of Enoshima is Benzaiten, the Japanese form of Sarasvatī: goddess of music, eloquence, learning, and flowing water.

The structure is unmistakable. A goddess of wisdom and music appears, foretells sovereignty, departs, and at the point of her departure leaves a triangular trace that becomes the emblem of a ruling house. This is the Hylian cosmogony in miniature—shaping, in the prophecy of rule; withdrawal, in the departure into the sea; trace, in the three scales. And the goddess's attributes distribute themselves across the game's royal house with remarkable fidelity: the princess bears Wisdom and keeps the instrument whose music opens time, and the realm's sovereignty is grounded in a triangular relic left by departed goddesses. Nothing in the evidence requires that the designers had the *Taiheiki* in mind. But the emblem they

gave Hyrule carries within it a legend of departing divinity and triangular trace that the game's own cosmogony retells.

The emblem's political history is equally suggestive. The Hōjō did not rule as sovereigns. They ruled as regents (*shikken*) on behalf of shoguns who were, after the founding generation, children or figureheads chosen for their pedigree, and who in turn ruled in the name of emperors in distant Kyoto. Power was exercised from behind a nested series of vacant or nominal thrones. The clan whose crest is the Triforce's likeliest ancestor is the classic historical instance of a hollow center occupied from behind: a vacancy at the summit kept carefully in place so that a power not identical with it could govern through it. The *Taiheiki* was written in the aftermath of the clan's annihilation in 1333, when the last regent and his followers took their own lives amid the burning of Kamakura, and the legend of the scales is told under the shadow of that fall. Chapter VI returns to this double valence of the empty center—as a space kept open for others, and as a throne occupied from behind.

The triangle-scale carries a second meaning in Japanese iconography. In the Noh theater, a robe patterned with gold or silver triangles, the *uroko-haku*, is worn by women transformed by passion into serpents or demons—most famously in *Dōjōji*, in which a woman spurned by a monk becomes a serpent that coils around the temple bell in which he hides and consumes him in its heat. The pattern thus signifies, in one register, divine election, and in another, monstrous metamorphosis through desire. The Triforce does both. It elects the hero and the princess, and it transforms the man who desired it most into a beast.

The Triforce invites a final comparison with the three sacred treasures (*sanshu no jingi*) of the Japanese imperial house: the mirror and the jewel, made to lure Amaterasu from the cave in which she had hidden the sun, and the sword Kusanagi, drawn by Susanoo from the tail of the eight-headed serpent he had slain. Their possession has been the material sign of legitimate succession; when two imperial courts contended for legitimacy in the fourteenth century, Kitabatake Chikafusa argued the southern court's case in part from its possession of the regalia, which he read as emblems of honesty, compassion, and decisive wisdom (Chikafusa 1339). The regalia illuminate the Triforce by contrast and by likeness. By contrast, the regalian logic holds that possession of the sacred objects confers legitimacy, whereas in Hyrule the relic judges the one who possesses it; legitimacy flows not from the object to the holder but from the holder's heart to the object's response. The game inverts the regalian theory of sovereignty and replaces it with an ethical one. By likeness, the regalia are never seen. They are kept enshrined and wrapped; even at an emperor's accession the sword and jewel are presented enclosed in their containers; the sacred center of the Japanese polity is a triad of objects that no one looks upon. So too the Triforce, sealed beyond the Door of Time, is never seen whole within *Ocarina of Time*. Its presence is its concealment.

One episode in the regalia's history serves as a bridge to the next chapter. At the naval battle of Dan-no-ura in 1185, as *The Tale of the Heike* recounts, the child emperor Antoku, a boy of six, was carried into the sea by his grandmother, who comforted him with the promise

of a capital beneath the waves; with them sank the sword. The *Heike* opens with the bell of the Gion monastery, whose tolling sounds the impermanence of all things—*Gion shōja no kane no koe, shogyō mujō no hibiki ari*. A child sovereign, a sword lost beneath the water, a bell that rings the transience of all things: that constellation is the subject of the chapters that follow.

2.9 Coda

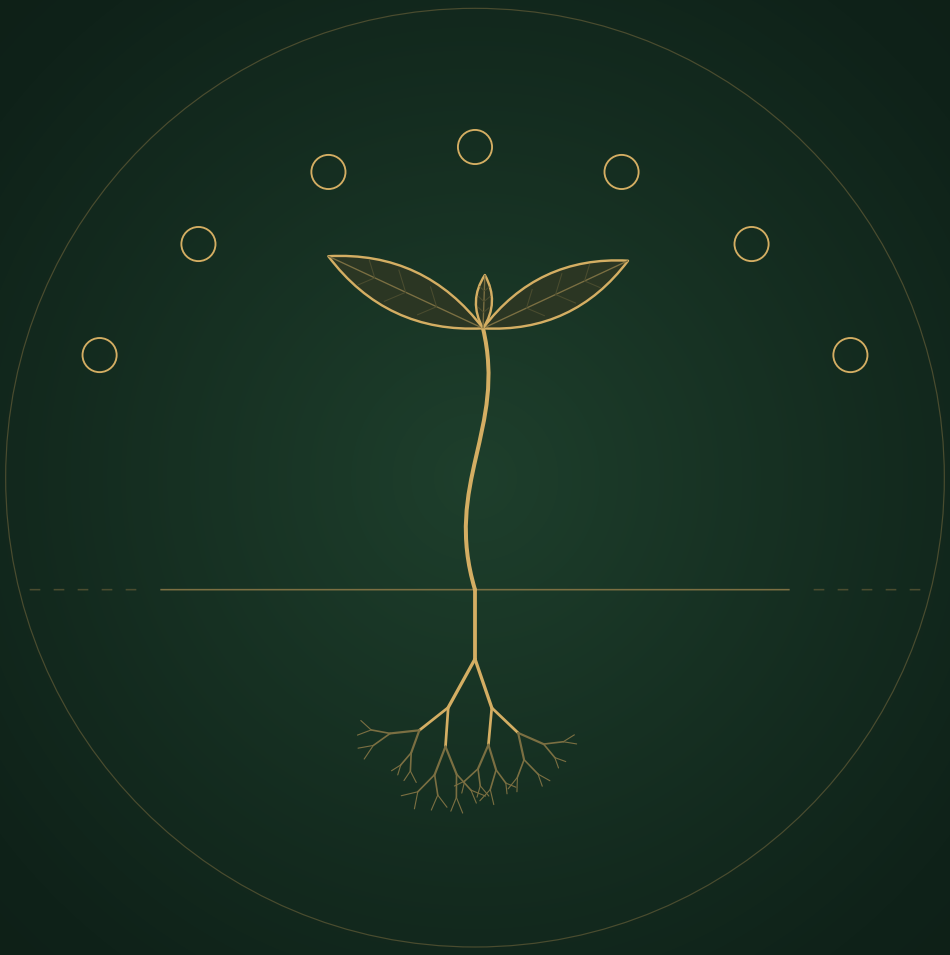
Power Is a Relation

The Triforce is a diagram of a cosmos in which the whole exists only as relation. Its three portions can be possessed, and are; its center cannot be, and is not. The center is where wisdom, courage, and power would cohere into the true force that governs all, and that coherence is not a fourth thing alongside the other three. It is a relation among them: justice in Plato's sense, the unity of the virtues in Aristotle's, humaneness in the Confucian, mercy in the Kabbalistic. A relation can be enacted; it cannot be held. The empty triangle at the heart of the golden one is therefore not a lack in the cosmos of Hyrule but its truest image.

Ganondorf's error, from this perspective, is a category mistake: he treats a relation as a thing. Marx supplied the vocabulary for the mistake when he described commodity fetishism as the appearance of social relations between people in the fantastic form of relations between things (Marx 1867), and Georg Lukács generalized the description as reification (Lukács 1923). Against Ganondorf the game takes, in effect, the side of Michel Foucault, for whom power is not something acquired, seized, or held but something exercised, from innumerable points, in the play of mobile and unequal relations (Foucault 1976). Ganondorf believes that power is a thing one can hold in one's hand, and the game gives him exactly that: a golden fragment fixed upon the back of his hand. It is the most terrible gift in Hyrule. The thing he grasped grasps him in turn, swells him into a beast, and binds him in a void where his single possession can never again be a relation to anyone. The tyrant who sought to fill the center ends sealed inside an emptiness.

Chapter III turns from the triangle to the one who bears its mediating term: the lion of Plato's image, the silent figure set between the princess and the beast, whose youth the cosmos requires and the ending restores.

CHAPTER



III

Songs of Innocence and of Experience

The Hidden Child, the Excised Adolescence, and the Aborted Rite of Passage

Shewing the Two Contrary States of the Human Soul.

— William Blake, title page of *Songs of Innocence and of Experience* (1794)

宋人有閔其苗之不長而揠之者，芒芒然歸，謂其人曰：「今日病矣！予助苗長矣！」其子趨而往視之，苗則槁矣。

A man of Song, grieved that his sprouts were not growing, pulled at them. He went home weary and told his household: "I am worn out today; I have been helping the sprouts to grow." His son ran out to look, and the sprouts had withered.

— *Mencius* 2A2 (trans. mine)

3.1
The Two Contrary States

Blake's *Songs of Innocence* appeared in 1789; five years later he issued them together with the *Songs of Experience*, under a title page announcing that the combined work showed the two contrary states of the human soul. The arrangement is not a narrative of development in which experience supersedes innocence. It is a structure of contraries: paired poems—"The Lamb" and "The Tyger," "Infant Joy" and "Infant Sorrow," two "Chimney Sweepers," two "Holy Thursdays," two "Nurse's Songs"—in which the same situation is sung twice, from either side of a threshold. Blake's aphorism in *The Marriage of Heaven and Hell* states the principle: without contraries is no progression.

Ocarina of Time is built upon the same principle with a literalness no poem could achieve. Its world exists in two states, seven years apart, and once the sword's pedestal has been found the player moves between them at will. The same places are sung twice. Kokiri Forest, the castle market, Kakariko, the Zora domain, Lake Hylia, and Lon Lon Ranch each appear in a state of innocence and a state of experience, and many of the game's most affecting effects consist in nothing more than the juxtaposition of the two: the bustling market and its haunted ruins, the lake full and drained, the ranch girl singing and the ranch girl in servitude. The songs of the ocarina are themselves redistributed, the same melody doing different work in the two eras. And the hero is doubled—not as a character, for he remains one person, but as a body. As a child he passes through narrow openings and wields a wooden sword and shield, a slingshot, a boomerang; as an adult he wields the Master Sword, the bow, the hookshot, the hammer, and can no longer use the instruments of childhood. James Gibson's concept of the *affordance*—what an environment offers an organism, relative to that organism's body and capacities (Gibson 1979)—describes this exactly. Each age is a different affordance-world, and travel in time is the passage between them. The game's developmental psychology is procedural: to grow up is to undergo a change in what the world affords.

The relation between the two states is not symmetrical. Causation runs from childhood to adulthood. Magic beans planted by the child in soft soil grow, over seven years, into the leaf-platforms the adult rides. The child's song in the windmill drains the village well, and the Lens of Truth he recovers from its depths is the instrument the adult needs to cross the invisible floors of the Shadow Temple. The desert temple must be entered by the child through a passage too narrow for the man, and completed by the man where the child could not go. "The Child is father of the Man," Wordsworth wrote in 1802; in Hyrule the line is a law of causality. The beans have a folk genealogy as well. In "Jack and the Beanstalk," as Joseph Jacobs's 1890 collection preserved it, a boy's magic beans grow overnight into a ladder to the giant's castle in the sky; in Hyrule the child's beans grow across seven years into stairways for the man. The seed planted in innocence becomes the ladder of experience.

Wordsworth's other figure for the threshold, from the ode on intimations of immortality —the shades of the prison-house that begin to close upon the growing boy—describes the darkened Hyrule of the adult era with equal fidelity. The game's distinctive contribution is to refuse the ode's elegiac finality. In Hyrule the prison-house can be left, and the boy can be returned.

3.2
The Hidden Child

Theogony, Messiah, and the Foundling of the Forest

Late in the game, after the Forest Temple has been cleared, a sprout appears where the Great Deku Tree once stood—the new guardian, successor to the old—and tells the adult hero what the old tree never told the child. He is not Kokiri but Hylian. During a war that ravaged the kingdom, his mother, mortally wounded, carried him as an infant into the forest and entrusted him to the guardian tree before she died, and the tree raised him among the forest children in the knowledge that his destiny lay beyond the forest. The hero is a foundling, and his story belongs to one of the most persistent patterns in world mythology: the pattern of the hidden child.

Otto Rank's *The Myth of the Birth of the Hero* (1909), the volume in which Freud's essay on the "family romance" first appeared, and Lord Raglan's *The Hero* (1936) codified the pattern. A child of distinguished parentage, born amid danger or under prophecy, is exposed or hidden, rescued and raised by humble foster-parents or by animals, and, grown, returns to claim his inheritance and overthrow the tyrant who sought his death. Freud's family romance—the child's fantasy that his true parents are nobler than those who raise him—names the psychological content Rank found in the myth (Freud 1909). Link's version of the pattern is notable for what it lacks. There is no father, named or unnamed, no lineage, no inheritance to reclaim. The family romance is emptied: the foundling discovers not a noble origin but a dead mother and a war.

Hesiod's *Theogony* gives the pattern its cosmic form. Kronos, warned that a son will overthrow him, swallows his children as each is born; Rhea, pregnant with Zeus, goes to Crete, where the infant is hidden in a cave and a stone in swaddling clothes is given to Kronos in his place (*Th.* 453–506). Later mythographers add the nymphs who nursed him, the goat Amalthea, and the Kouretes, who clashed their shields to drown the infant's cries (Apollodorus 1.1.6–7; Callimachus, *Hymn to Zeus*). The child raised in hiding by spirits of the wild grows up to overthrow the devouring tyrant. That Kronos was early identified with Chronos, Time—Plutarch reports the allegory as a commonplace (*On Isis and Osiris* 32)—gives the pattern a special relevance to a game about time: the hidden child is the one who escapes being devoured by time and returns to depose it. Chapter IV develops the temporal

implication. Here it suffices to note that the Hesiodic pattern ends in a theogony. Zeus, having overthrown Kronos, becomes king of gods and men. The Olympian conclusion is precisely the one *Ocarina of Time* refuses.

The Hebrew Bible's version—the decree to drown the Hebrew boys, the basket among the reeds, the fostering in Pharaoh's house (Exod. 1:22–2:10)—shares with the legend of Sargon of Akkad and with Herodotus's account of the infancy of Cyrus (1.107–122) the elements of a tyrant's decree, a mother's concealment, and a fostering among strangers. In each, the tyrant's attempt to forestall his overthrow becomes the instrument that brings it about.

The most complete analogue, however, is Krishna in the tenth book of the *Bhāgavata Purāṇa*. Kamsa, having imprisoned his own father, King Ugrasena, and usurped the throne of Mathurā, learns that the eighth child of his kinswoman Devakī will kill him, and slays her children as they are born. The eighth, Krishna, is carried by night across the Yamunā to Vraja and raised among cowherds by Nanda and Yaśodā. There the child performs prodigies against the demons Kamsa sends to destroy him—the demoness Pūtanā with her poisoned breasts, the serpent Kāliya in the river—lifts the mountain Govardhana to shelter the herders from Indra's storms, and plays upon a flute whose music draws all creatures, and above all the cowherd girls, to him. Then he leaves Vraja for the city, never to return; the girls' grief of separation (*viraha*) becomes one of the great themes of Indian devotional poetry; and in the city he kills the usurper and restores the old king. Nearly every element has its Hylian counterpart: the usurper whose seizure of the throne the hidden child must undo; the infant spirited away in a time of violence; the pastoral fostering, in a forest world, among a people not his own; the demonic agents sent against the guardians of that world; the flute; and the companion of childhood who stays behind when the hero departs—Saria, who gives Link her ocarina on the bridge out of the forest, and whose song, played upon it, lets him hear her voice from afar. What Hyrule omits is the restoration of the king. The usurper is overthrown, but no Ugrasena returns; the throne of Hyrule remains, to the end, unseen.

The medieval West supplies the version closest in texture. In Wolfram's *Parzival*, Herzeloyde, widowed when her husband Gahmuret falls in knightly combat, withdraws with her infant son into the forest of Soltane to raise him in ignorance of chivalry and of his lineage (Book III). The boy meets knights riding through the woods, takes them for gods, and resolves to follow them; his mother dies of grief as he departs; and he does not know his own name until his cousin Sigune tells it to him. Chrétien's earlier Perceval is raised by his widowed mother in the Waste Forest. Wagner condensed the figure into a formula in *Parsifal* (1882): made wise through compassion, the pure fool—*durch Mitleid wissend, der reine Tor*. Link, raised by a guardian who knows his origin and does not tell it, ignorant of his race and of the war that orphaned him, leaves his forest as Parzival leaves his. In Hyrule the order is reversed: the guardian dies first, and the death sends the boy out.

The Grail romances return us to the guardian tree. At the heart of the Grail castle lies a wounded king—Chrétien's Fisher King, Wolfram's Anfortas—whose wound is mirrored in the sterility of his land, and who can be healed only when a destined youth asks him the question of compassion; in Wolfram, simply, what ails you? Jessie Weston read the wounded king and the waste land as survivals of vegetation ritual (Weston 1920), following James Frazer's dying-and-rising gods (Frazer 1890), a category Jonathan Z. Smith would later dismantle as a scholarly construction (Smith 1987); T. S. Eliot built *The Waste Land* (1922) upon her reading. The Great Deku Tree is a Fisher King: a sacred guardian wounded by a curse, whose sickness is the sickness of his land, awaiting a boy from the forest. The adult-era Hyrule is a waste land. But the game alters the romance at two points. The first is the hero's silence. Perceval fails on his first visit because he does not ask the question, having been taught that a knight should not ask too many; his silence is a failure of compassion. Link never speaks at all, yet no one reproaches him, for his compassion is enacted rather than asked, in the act of entering the tree's body to purge the parasite. The second is the outcome. In Wolfram, the question, once asked, heals the king. In Hyrule the curse is lifted but the tree dies all the same: the hero arrives too late for healing, and the land is renewed not by cure but by succession, in the sprout that grows where the old tree stood. The game is a Grail romance without a healing, and its consolation is vegetal rather than miraculous —not the restoration of the old king, but the growth of the new.

3.3
The Children of the Tree

Neverland, the Wooden Boys, and the Gods' Own

The people among whom the hero is raised are among the strangest in the game. The Kokiri are children who never grow up. Each is accompanied by a guardian fairy; all live under the protection of the Great Deku Tree, whose creatures they are; and all believe that to leave the forest is to die. Their village is a nursery without adults: no parents, no elders save the tree, no labor beyond play and the tending of small gardens, no history. Into this order the hero fits as an anomaly. Alone among the Kokiri he has no fairy, and the opening of the game makes much of the lack. Mido, the self-appointed leader of the children, taunts him as the boy without a fairy and bars his way to the guardian tree until he has found a sword and shield. Mary Douglas defined pollution as matter out of place, the anomaly that a classificatory order cannot accommodate (Douglas 1966); Claude Lévi-Strauss showed how myths install such anomalies as mediators between oppositions a culture cannot otherwise reconcile (Lévi-Strauss 1955). The boy without a fairy, a Hylian among the forest's children, is the anomaly who becomes the mediator—between forest and castle, nature and culture, childhood and the adult world, the timeless and the historical.

J. M. Barrie opened *Peter and Wendy* (1911) with a sentence the Kokiri invert: "All children, except one, grow up." In the forest, all children except one never grow up, and Link is the exception in the opposite direction. The resemblance between the two worlds goes beyond inversion. Barrie's island is a nursery without adults, a dominion of eternal boyhood peopled by Lost Boys and fairies; the Kokiri, each with a fairy, beneath a tree, inhabit its Hylian counterpart. Barrie did not disguise the cruelty at the heart of Neverland's law. The Lost Boys, he observed with deceptive lightness, vary in number according to how many are killed, and when they seem to be growing up, which is against the rules, Peter thins them out. Growth, in Neverland, is a capital offense. The Kokiri belief that leaving the forest means death is the Hylian form of the same law, and the Lost Woods, where children who stray become Skull Kids, are its enforcement. Barrie's ending has its Hylian echo too. Peter returns, generation after generation, for the daughters of the girl who left him—the eternal child recurring through time, "so long as children are gay and innocent and heartless"—as the hero of Hyrule will recur in age after age of the series.

The guardian's name adds a further layer. *Deku*, as noted in Chapter I, is heard by a Japanese ear as 木偶, a carved wooden figure or puppet, and, in the idiom *deku no bō*, a useless blockhead. The Kokiri are in this sense the children of a puppet tree. The resonance with Carlo Collodi's *Pinocchio* (1883) is irresistible: a wooden puppet who longs to become a real boy and who is swallowed by a monstrous fish before his wish is granted. The Kokiri never become real; they do not age, and they cannot leave. Link is the real boy who was always real, and who, like Pinocchio, will be swallowed by a great fish (Chapter V). Barrie and Collodi between them describe the two exits from the nursery that the Kokiri are denied: growing up, which Neverland forbids, and becoming real, which only the puppet who suffers can achieve.

Japanese folk belief supplies a third frame, and it explains why the forest's children seem at once privileged and uncanny. A saying much discussed by Japanese folklorists, whatever its antiquity, holds that a child belongs to the gods until the age of seven (*nanatsu made wa kami no uchi*): not yet fully of the human world, held in a liminal and sacred status that the rites of *shichi-go-san*, at three, five, and seven, gradually bring to an end. The Kokiri are children who remain permanently among the gods—creatures of a guardian deity, untouched by time, never entering the human community. The same folklore knows the dark side of this status. *Kamikakushi*, being hidden by the gods, is the name for the disappearance of children into mountains and forests, taken by spirits; Yanagita Kunio's *Tōno Monogatari* (1910) records the tale of a girl who vanished beneath a pear tree and returned, some thirty years later, as an old woman on a day of wind, only to vanish again. The Skull Kids of the Lost Woods are *kamikakushi* made visible: children taken by the forest and emptied by it. The Kokiri forest is a sacred nursery and also the threshold of the gods' abduction, and the game, like the folklore, holds both truths together.

Against this background the hero's departure acquires its weight. The Kokiri cannot follow him; to leave is, for them, to die. Saria, the friend of his childhood, comes to the bridge at the forest's edge to see him go and gives him her ocarina. The farewell is the first moment in the game at which time begins: the hero crosses from the timeless world of the forest children into the historical world of Hylians, wars, and kings. Saria will remain a child forever. When Link meets her again, seven years later, it is at the end of the Forest Temple, where she awakens as the Sage of Forest—still a child, in a world that has aged around her, and already, in her own way, beyond his reach.

3.4
The Transitional Instrument
Winnicott, Fort-Da, *and the Two Tool-Kits*

The ocarina Saria gives at the bridge is, in the precise sense of D. W. Winnicott's theory, a transitional object (Winnicott 1953; Winnicott 1971). Winnicott used the term for the infant's first "not-me" possession—the edge of a blanket, a soft toy—which stands in for the mother and allows the child to tolerate her absence. It belongs neither wholly to inner fantasy nor wholly to external reality but to an intermediate area of experience, the potential space in which, Winnicott argued, play, art, and culture will later unfold. The Fairy Ocarina is given at the moment of separation by the companion of the hero's childhood; it allows him to tolerate her absence; and it does so, quite literally, by preserving a channel to her. Once Link has learned the song Saria teaches him in the forest meadow, playing it anywhere in the world brings her voice, speaking to him from afar. The transitional object here is not a substitute for the absent friend but a medium of her presence: music as the intermediate area in which the separated remain together.

Winnicott was exact about the fate of the transitional object. It is not lost, he wrote, and it is not mourned; it is gradually decathected, relegated to limbo, because the transitional phenomena it carried have become diffused over the whole cultural field. The game enacts this fate with almost clinical fidelity. When Zelda, fleeing the castle, flings the Ocarina of Time into the moat and the hero retrieves it, the royal instrument takes the place of the Fairy Ocarina in his inventory. The wooden ocarina is not broken, stolen, or wept over. It simply ceases to be there, its function absorbed into a larger instrument belonging to a larger order: the instrument of the royal family, of the Temple of Time, of history itself. The passage from Saria's ocarina to Zelda's is the passage from the transitional object to the cultural field, from the music that keeps a friend near to the music that opens time. In Julia Kristeva's terms, which Chapter VII develops, it is the passage from the semiotic *chora* of the forest, rhythmic and pre-symbolic, to the symbolic order of the castle—of law, lineage, and sequence (Kristeva 1974).

A second psychoanalytic scene illuminates the hero's tools. In *Beyond the Pleasure Principle*, Freud described his grandson's game with a wooden reel on a string. The child would throw the reel out of sight with a long "o-o-o-o," which Freud and the child's mother took for *fort*, gone, and pull it back with a joyful *da*, there (Freud 1920). The game, Freud argued, was the child's mastery of his mother's departures: what he suffered passively he reproduced actively, staging disappearance and return under his own control. The child hero's signature instrument is the boomerang, a weapon that goes out and comes back—*fort-da* made into an item. The adult's corresponding tool is the hookshot, a chain launched toward a distant target that draws not the object to the self but the self to the object. The two tools describe two relations to distance. The child masters absence by recalling the absent thing to himself; the adult masters it by projecting himself across the gap. The boomerang and the hookshot are the reel-game and its adult transformation: the one summons the world back, the other throws the self into the world.

The game's division of tools by age thus carries a developmental argument. The child's instruments are small and light, many of them made of wood: the Kokiri sword, the Deku shield, Deku sticks and nuts, the slingshot, the boomerang. The adult's are heavy and of steel, and they are wielded, fired, or swung: the Master Sword, the bow, the hookshot and its longer successor, the Megaton Hammer, the iron boots. The child's tools work by return and by small force; the adult's by penetration, weight, and reach. The game forbids each age the other's tools: the adult cannot use the slingshot or the boomerang, and the child cannot draw the bow or swing the hammer. Development, so encoded, is not a matter of acquiring more but of exchanging one repertoire for another, with the loss that every such exchange entails. The temple of the desert, which can be completed only by both ages working in sequence, states the conclusion that Blake's contraries require: the hero's progression is possible only through the conjunction of the states between which he must pass.

3.5 The Seven Years

Moratorium, Foreclosure, and the Sleeper's Return

When the child draws the Master Sword from its pedestal, he is not, as Arthur was, proclaimed king. He loses consciousness, and he awakens seven years later in a chamber said to lie at the center of the Sacred Realm, where the Sage of Light explains what has happened. The boy was too young to bear the sword as the Hero of Time, and his spirit was therefore sealed in the chamber until he had grown old enough to wield it. During those seven years the usurper entered the Sacred Realm, seized his portion of the relic, and conquered the kingdom.

The sword's judgment is Aristotle's. In the *Nicomachean Ethics* the young are declared unsuited to the study of politics, because they lack experience of the actions of life and are led by their passions (I.3, 1095a2–6); a child cannot be called happy in the full sense, because happiness requires complete virtue and a complete life (I.9, 1100a1–4); and the moral virtues are formed by habituation, through repeated action over time (II.1). The game seems at first to contradict this. It has already called the child courageous; the guardian tree chose him for his courage; and when the relic divides, the Triforce of Courage passes to him as he sleeps. The contradiction resolves itself in the distinction the Master Sword enforces: between courage as a disposition—something like what Mencius called a sprout—and courage as a capacity fit for its office. The child has the first; the sword demands the second; and the seven years are the interval in which the one is supposed to become the other.

Except that they are not lived. Erik Erikson identified adolescence as the stage at which identity is consolidated against the threat of role confusion, and he described the psychosocial moratorium that societies grant the young: a sanctioned delay of adult commitments, during which the young person experiments with roles before choosing among them (Erikson 1950; Erikson 1968). The seven-year sleep is the moratorium made literal—a delay of adult commitment enforced by the gods—and emptied, for the hero spends it unconscious. He awakens with an adult body, an adult destiny, and a title, but without having lived the years in which an identity is formed. James Marcia's typology of identity statuses, built upon Erikson's account, distinguished identity achievement, reached through exploration followed by commitment, from foreclosure, in which commitment is adopted without exploration—an identity assigned rather than chosen (Marcia 1966). The adult Link is the paradigm of foreclosure. His identity is conferred by a sword and a sage; he has never had the chance to be anyone else. The game's adolescence is a hollow, an excised center in the hero's life, and it has the shape of the Triforce itself: two ages, childhood and adulthood, framing a vacancy.

The awakening belongs to a large family of tales about sleepers who wake into a changed world. Epimenides of Crete slept in a cave for fifty-seven years (Diogenes Laërtius 1.109). The Seven Sleepers of Ephesus, in Christian and Qur'anic tradition, slept for centuries in a cave while the persecution that drove them there passed away (Qur'an 18:9–26). Frederick Barbarossa beneath the Kyffhäuser and Arthur in Avalon are sleeping kings awaiting the hour of their return. Washington Irving's Rip Van Winkle (1819) sleeps twenty years and wakes to find a king replaced by a republic. Among these the closest to the game, and the one every Japanese player would recognize, is Urashima Tarō. In its early forms in the *Nihon Shoki*, the *Man'yōshū*, and the gazetteer of Tango province, and in the storybook version of the Muromachi period that fixed it in popular memory, the tale tells of a young fisherman taken to the palace of the sea god by the god's daughter, Otohime, with whom he lives for what seems a few years. Longing for home, he returns bearing a jeweled box she has given him with the warning never to open it. He finds that centuries have passed and no one

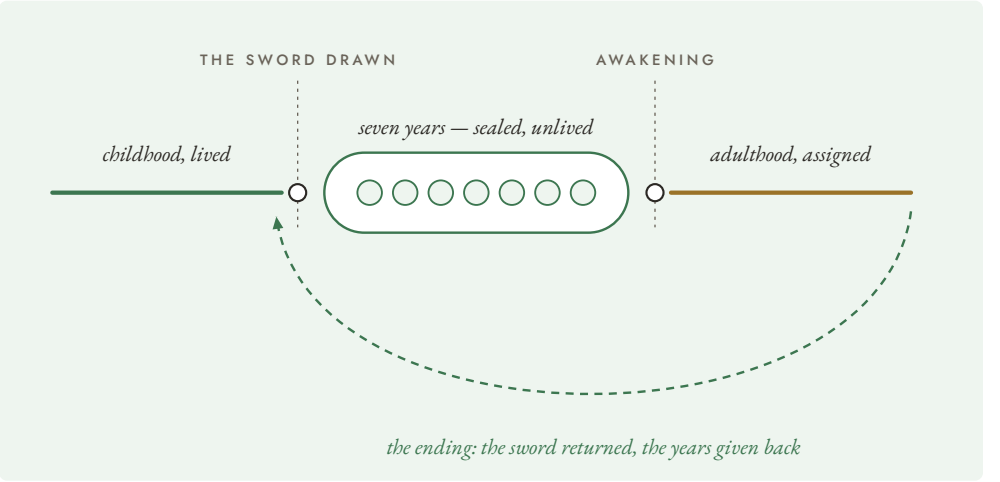


FIGURE 3.1 *The Excised Adolescence*

Childhood lived; seven years sealed and unlived; an adulthood assigned rather than chosen; and the ending, which returns the years the sword had taken (§3.5).

remembers him; he opens the box, a white smoke rises from it, and he becomes in an instant an old man.

The Hylian version inverts and redistributes the tale's elements with remarkable thoroughness. Urashima loses time outside while living briefly within; Link loses time within, in sleep, and returns to an outside that has aged. Urashima's catastrophe comes from opening a forbidden box; Link's from opening a forbidden door, the Door of Time, whose opening costs its opener his years—the jeweled box made into architecture. And the tale's princess has her Hylian double in Ruto, princess of the Zora, daughter of the king of the waters, who claims the hero as her betrothed and gives him a jewel from the depths as the token of their engagement. When the adult Link returns to her domain, the waters are frozen and her people locked in ice; when he finds her at last, by the lake's sunken temple, she holds him to the betrothal still. The Urashima pattern is present in the game not as an allusion but as a structure distributed across its episodes, and it supplies the affective key to the adult era: the melancholy of one who comes back to find his world aged without him and himself a stranger in it.

3.6 The Princess's Error

Prophecy, Hamartia, *and Reparation*

The seven years are not the work of the gods alone. They are the consequence of a plan, and the plan was the princess's. When the child first reaches her in the castle courtyard, she

tells him of a dream: dark clouds massing over the land, and then a light from the forest that parts them and becomes a boy in green, a fairy at his side, holding a green and shining stone. She has recognized the clouds in the man from the desert who has come to swear allegiance to her father, and her father, she says, does not share her suspicion. She has formed a plan. If the hero gathers the three Spiritual Stones while she keeps the Ocarina of Time from the usurper's hands, they can open the Door of Time and secure the Triforce before he reaches it.

The plan brings about precisely what it was meant to prevent. The hero opens the door; the usurper, who has been waiting for someone to open it, follows him into the Sacred Realm and thanks him for showing the way. The structure is the oldest in tragedy. Oedipus, fleeing Corinth to escape the oracle that he will kill his father and marry his mother, flees directly into its fulfillment, and the intelligence that solved the Sphinx's riddle is the instrument of his ruin. Robert Merton gave the modern name of self-fulfilling prophecy to the social form of the pattern, in which a false definition of a situation evokes behavior that makes it come true (Merton 1948). Zelda's case is subtler, for her prophecy is not false: the clouds are real, and the boy from the forest is the light that will part them. What is false is her interpretation of her own place in the prophecy—her belief that the wise act would be to seize the relic first. The bearer of Wisdom errs through wisdom's overreach.

Aristotle located the most affecting tragic plots in the misfortune of a person neither preeminent in virtue nor wicked, who falls not through vice but through some error, *hamartia* (*Poetics* 13, 1453a7–17). The term has been endlessly debated, but on any reading Zelda's act qualifies: a mistake of judgment made with good intention by one too young to comprehend the forces she sought to command. Her error is also, in the precise terms of this dissertation, a structural transgression. To secure the Triforce pre-emptively, even to keep it from evil, is to attempt to occupy the center—the good will's version of the tyrant's aim. Tolkien's Gandalf refused the Ring for exactly this reason; the princess did not refuse the Triforce, and the game makes her learn the lesson through its consequences. Her error has a further dimension that a feminist reading cannot ignore. Like Cassandra, daughter of Priam, whose true prophecies no one in her father's house would heed, Zelda is a prophetess whose warning the patriarch of her own court sets aside (Aeschylus, *Agamemnon* Wolf 1983). Denied the authority to act openly, she acts in secret and through a child, and her secrecy is a condition of her plan's failure. The princess's knowledge is pushed into covert channels—as it will be again during the seven years she spends disguised as Sheik—and the covert channel is the one the usurper can follow.

At the game's end, after the usurper has been sealed, the princess names her error. It was her own childish attempt to control the Sacred Realm, she tells the hero, that brought ruin upon Hyrule, and it was she who drew him into it. She asks him for the ocarina. As a sage she can return him to his own time, and she does so: he must go home, she tells him, to the

place where he belongs, and regain the time that was taken from him. The scene is brief, but its psychological structure is precise, and the theorist who described it best is Melanie Klein.

In Klein's account, development passes from the paranoid-schizoid position, in which the infant splits its world into idealized and persecuting objects, to the depressive position, in which it recognizes that the object it loves and the object it has attacked in fantasy are one and the same, and that it has harmed what it loves. The depressive position brings guilt, and guilt brings the impulse to reparation, the wish to restore the damaged object (Klein 1935; Klein 1937). Klein distinguished genuine reparation, which acknowledges the damage, accepts dependence, and accepts the limits of what can be restored, from manic reparation, which denies damage and loss through fantasies of omnipotent repair (Klein 1940). Zelda's act belongs to the first kind. She does not restore the hero's lost years as years lived; she cannot give back the adolescence he slept through, and she does not crown him, marry him, or make him master of the realm he saved. She returns him, rather, to the threshold of the years he lost, so that he may live them himself. Her reparation is a gift of unfilled time—kenochronic in the sense of Axiom V—and it costs her the hero, for the ending is also, as she says, their parting. The depressive position includes loss in its repair.

The ethical tradition that best names what she repairs is Mencius's. The second book of the *Mencius* opens with a disciple's questions about courage: about the bravos who cultivate fearlessness by refusing to flinch, and about the greater courage of one who, examining himself and finding himself upright, would go forward against thousands (2A2). Mencius's answer turns to the cultivation of what he calls the flood-like *qi* (*haoran zhi qi*), a vital energy that, nourished by rightness and never injured, fills the space between heaven and earth. It must be tended gradually and constantly: one must not forget it, but one must not help it grow. And he tells the parable of the man of Song who pulled at his sprouts to hasten them and killed them. The passage is, strikingly, a treatise on courage that culminates in a warning against forced growth. The hero of *Ocarina of Time* is the bearer of the Triforce of Courage, and his growth is forced: the Master Sword takes a child and pulls him, in a single stroke, into a man. The princess's restoration undoes the sprout-puller's error. Rousseau, two millennia later and at the other end of Eurasia, said the same in the second book of *Émile*: nature wants children to be children before they are men (*la nature veut que les enfants soient enfants avant que d'être hommes*), and to invert that order is to produce precocious fruits, without ripeness or savor, that soon rot (Rousseau 1762). Aristotle, Mencius, and Rousseau triangulate the ending's ethic. Virtue grows; it cannot be pulled.

The game supplies its own image of the principle in the sprout that grows where the Great Deku Tree once stood. The new guardian is not forced. It grows in its season, and it is from the sprout, not from the old tree, that the hero learns the truth of his origin. Mencius called the beginnings of virtue in the heart its four sprouts (*duan*), and he insisted that they grow if nourished and wither if neglected or forced (2A6). The Deku Sprout is the game's

emblem of growth rightly undergone, and the ending gives the hero back the condition of a sprout.

3.7
The Guardian's Departure
The Daimonion, the End of Minority, and the Rite Run Backward

Arnold van Gennep showed that rites of passage everywhere share a tripartite structure: separation from a prior status, a marginal or liminal phase, and incorporation into a new one (van Gennep 1909). Victor Turner, elaborating the liminal phase, described its subjects as betwixt and between the positions of the social order—structurally invisible, often secluded, stripped of name and property, treated as dead to their former state, and associated with darkness, the womb, and the tomb (Turner 1967; Turner 1969). Mircea Eliade read initiation in archaic societies as ritual death and rebirth, in which the novice dies to childhood in the initiatory hut, sometimes figured as the belly of a monster, and is reborn into adulthood (Eliade 1958). Through its first two acts *Ocarina of Time* follows this structure to the letter. Separation: the hero leaves the forest and, in the Temple of Time, draws the sword. Liminality: he spends seven years secluded in a chamber at the center of the Sacred Realm, unconscious, invisible to the world, dead to his childhood. Incorporation: he awakens as the Hero of Time, receives his title and his charge from the Sage of Light, and goes out into the world in the body, and with the weapons, of a man.

Then the ending runs the rite backward. Having sealed the usurper, the hero is not incorporated into the adult order he has saved. He is not crowned, not married, not acclaimed. He is returned, by the princess's act, to the status from which he was separated: a child at the threshold of the Temple of Time, the sword laid back in its pedestal. The rite is not completed but reversed—a de-initiation, in which the initiate is restored to his prior state, carrying the knowledge the rite conferred but none of its standing. Why does the game abort its own rite of passage? The answer lies in what incorporation would require. To incorporate the hero would be to give him a place: the throne, the princess's hand, the mastery of the realm—to set him at the center. That is the Olympian conclusion the theogonic pattern demands, and it is the conclusion the Ocarina Principle forbids. The hero who saved the vacant center cannot occupy it without becoming what he defeated, and the game prefers to undo his ascent.

The guardian's departure seals the reversal. Every Kokiri has a fairy; the hero, the boy without one, receives Navi at the game's opening, sent by the Great Deku Tree to wake and guide him. Through the whole game she accompanies him, flying to whatever demands his attention and calling out at moments of danger; her cry of "Hey! Listen!" became, for a generation of players, perhaps the most familiar utterance in the medium. Navi resembles

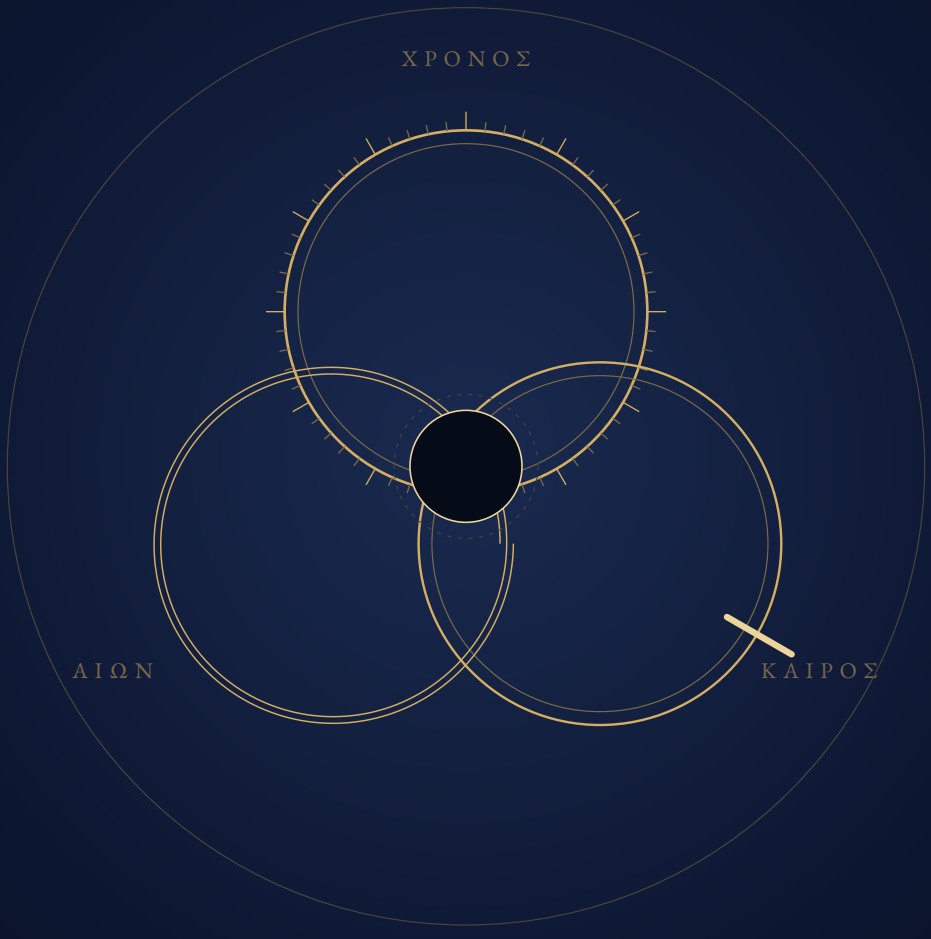
nothing so much as the *daimonion* of Socrates, the divine sign that, as Socrates told his judges, had come to him since childhood as a voice, and which always turned him back from what he was about to do and never urged him on (*Apology* 31c–d). She is the mute hero's externalized *daimonion*: the voice of the boy who has none, warning, directing, interrupting. At the game's end, once the sword has been returned to its pedestal, she rises and flies out through a window of the Temple of Time, and she does not come back.

Kant defined enlightenment as humanity's exit from its self-incurred minority (*Unmündigkeit*), the inability to use one's own understanding without the guidance of another, and gave it a motto: *sapere aude*, dare to know (Kant 1784). The German word is instructive. *Unmündigkeit* is formed not, as the ear suggests, from *Mund*, the mouth, but from the old Germanic *munt*, the protection or guardianship under which a ward stands; the minor is one who is in another's keeping, though the folk ear hears in the word an inability to speak for oneself. Link is *unmündig* in both senses: a ward in a fairy's keeping and a boy without speech. Navi's departure releases him from the first at the very moment the ending returns him to literal minority. The game's final image is thus a paradox Kant did not anticipate: an enlightened child, restored to childhood but released from tutelage, carrying in memory a future that has not yet happened.

The series' later history registered the cost of the paradox. *Majora's Mask* (2000) opens with the hero on a private journey in search of a beloved friend—the fairy who left him—and the whole of that game can be read as a work of mourning for a loss *Ocarina of Time* does not permit itself to mourn. *Twilight Princess* (2006), as later glossed in *Hyrule Historia*, introduces the Hero's Shade, a spectral swordsman who teaches his descendant the arts of combat and who is identified as the Hero of Time: unrecognized in the history to which he returned, he died, the gloss explains, regretting that he had never passed on his skills. The unincorporated initiate becomes a ghost who must complete the transmission the aborted rite withheld—a figure out of the phantasmal Noh of Zeami, whose protagonist is a spirit bound to the world by an unresolved attachment, returning to tell its story and seek release. These are paratexts, and Chapter VIII treats them as afterlives rather than glosses. But they confirm that the series understood its founding ending as a wound as well as a gift.

The gift, nonetheless, is the point. The game ends where the rite began, with a child in a castle courtyard approaching a princess, the whole adventure at once before and behind him. Heraclitus's fragment, set at the head of Chapter I, proposed that the kingship belongs to a child at play. The only sovereignty *Ocarina of Time* grants its hero is the child's: not the throne, but the open future. Chapter IV turns to the time in which that future opens.

CHAPTER



IV

The Triforce of Time

Chronos, Kairos, Aion, and the Kenochronic Structure of the Song

εἰκὼ δ' ἐπενόει κινητόν τινα αἰῶνος ποιῆσαι.

He resolved to make a kind of moving image of eternity.

— Plato, *Timaeus* 37d (trans. mine)

Quid est ergo tempus? Si nemo ex me quaerat, scio; si quaerenti explicare velim, nescio.

What, then, is time? If no one asks me, I know; if I wish to explain it to one who asks, I do not know.

— Augustine, *Confessions* XI.14.17 (trans. mine)

4.1 Three Words for Time

Greek had three words for time where most modern European languages make do with one, and the distinctions among them organize this chapter. *Chronos* is time as succession and measure: the time of clocks and calendars, of before and after, of duration counted in units. *Kairos* is time as opportunity: the decisive moment, the right time to act, the instant that must be seized because it will not return—the time of the physician who intervenes at the crisis of a fever, of the orator who speaks when the assembly is ready, of the archer who looses at the instant of aim. *Aiōn* is the hardest to translate. In Homer it is the life-force, the vital substance whose departure is death, and by extension a lifetime (Onians 1951); in Heraclitus it is a child at play; in Plato it becomes eternity, the timeless whole of which the cosmos is the image, and the *Timaeus* defines chronos itself as the moving image of *aiōn*, unfolding according to number (37d). *Aiōn* is time as a whole: a life seen entire, an age, the totality of which successive time is the unrolling.

Modern philosophy has repeatedly rediscovered these distinctions. Heidegger's critique of the "vulgar" conception of time as a sequence of nows is a critique of *chronos* isolated from the other two, and his moment of vision (*Augenblick*) is a *kairos* (Heidegger 1927, §§68, 81). Giorgio Agamben's reading of Paul finds in the apostle's *kairos* a contracted time, the time that remains, which interrupts the *chronos* of the world (Agamben 2000). Gilles Deleuze, in *The Logic of Sense*, opposed Chronos, the time of the living present in which bodies act and suffer, to Aion, the infinitely divisible time of the pure event, which eludes the present by being always at once just past and about to come; and he assigned to Aion the "ideal game" in which every throw affirms the whole of chance (Deleuze 1969, series 10 and 23).

The central claim of this chapter is that *Ocarina of Time* distributes these three times among the three portions of the Triforce and their bearers, and arranges them around a receptacle that belongs to none. I call this structure the *Triforce of Time*. *Chronos*, the time of succession, measure, and possession, belongs to Power and to Ganondorf, whose reign is a regime of devoured and arrested time. *Kairos*, the time of the decisive act, belongs to Courage and to Link, whose deeds are the hinges between ages. *Aion*, the time of the whole, belongs to Wisdom and to Zelda, whose prophetic dream sees a history she cannot yet alter and whose final act gives a life back to itself. At the center lies the Sacred Realm, in which the hero sleeps seven years that do not pass for him: a time outside time, the receptacle in which the three are held apart.

The correspondence is not a decorative allegory; it satisfies the procedural criterion, because each time is the mode in which its bearer acts within the game's rules. Ganondorf's power is exercised as duration: it accumulates across seven years and is measured by what it has consumed. Link's courage is exercised as *kairos*: the player's agency consists overwhelmingly of acts of timing—the moment to strike, to block, to release an arrow, to play a song,

TABLE 4.1 *The Triforce of Time.*

TIME	GREEK SENSE	PORTION AND BEARER	MYTHIC FIGURE	IN THE GAME
Chronos	succession, measure, duration	Power — Ganondorf	Kronos devouring his children	the seven-year reign; the drained, frozen, emptied kingdom
Kairos	the decisive moment	Courage — Link	Lysippos's Kairos, forelock in front and bald behind	the Door of Time; the sword drawn and returned
Aion	lifetime, age, the whole	Wisdom — Zelda	Heraclitus's child at play	the prophetic dream; the return of the hero's time
center	the receptacle outside time	none	Plato's *chōra*	the Sacred Realm; the seven years that do not pass

to draw or return the sword. And Zelda's wisdom is exercised as *aion*: she alone in the game perceives history as a whole before it unfolds, and she alone can dispose of a life entire. The sections that follow take each time in turn.

4.2
The Devourer
Chronophagy and the Tyranny of Sequence

The figure in whom the Greeks saw time's violence is Kronos, who swallowed his children as they were born lest one of them overthrow him (Hesiod, *Th.* 453–467). That the Titan was early identified with Chronos, Time—an identification Plutarch reports as conventional (*On Isis and Osiris* 32)—made his crime an image of time itself: the father who devours his offspring, the succession that consumes what it produces. Ovid gave the image its proverbial form in the apostrophe to time, the devourer of things, *tempus edax rerum* (*Metamorphoses* XV.234), and Goya painted it on the wall of his house as the old god tearing at the body of his son (1819–23), the modern emblem of time as appetite.

Ganondorf is Hyrule's Kronos, and his crime is what I call *chronophagy*, the consumption of others' time. The seven years of his reign are not merely years in which he rules; they are years he takes. He takes the hero's adolescence, which passes in a sealed sleep. He takes the future of the Gorons, whom he imprisons to be fed to the dragon Volvagia—chronophagy made literal, the devouring of a people. He stops the time of the Zora, whose domain is locked in ice and whose king stands frozen in it. He hollows the townspeople of the market into ReDeads, figures of death-in-life whose time has neither ended nor continued. He drains the great lake. His reign is characterized not by activity but by arrest: the kingdom under his rule is a place in which nothing happens and nothing grows, the

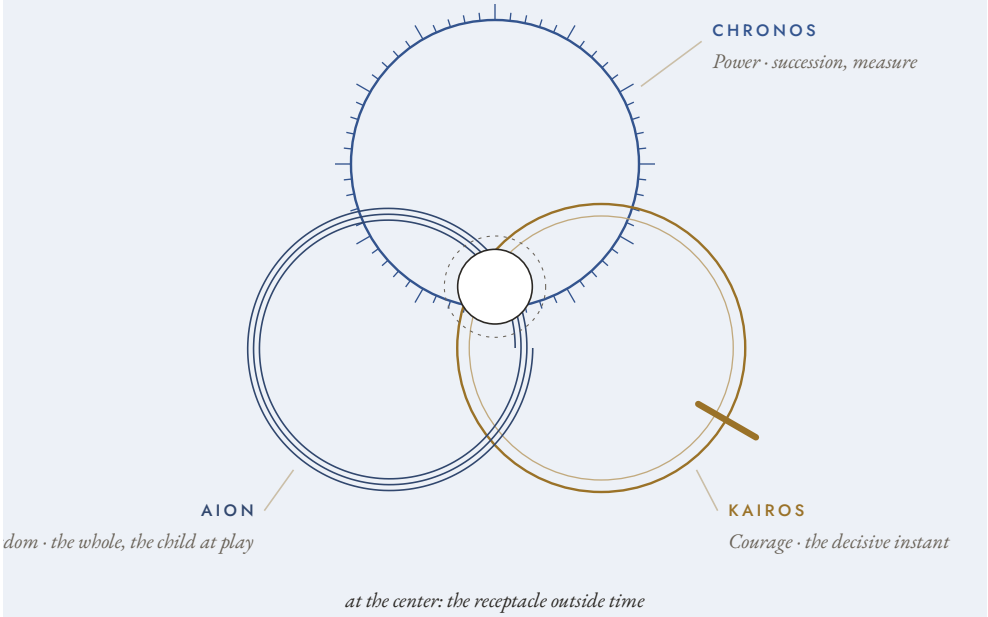


FIGURE 4.1 *The Triforce of Time*

Chronos, the time of succession and measure, belongs to Power; *Kairos*, the decisive instant, to Courage; *Aion*, the time of the whole, to Wisdom. They are arranged around a receptacle that belongs to none of them (§4.1; Table 4.1).

time of a world stopped and fed upon. The plenary sovereign of Chapter I is necessarily a chronophage, because to occupy the center permanently is to arrest the motion of the whole. The Parmenidean plenum, having no void, has no time.

A distinction must be drawn here to forestall a confusion. Walter Benjamin's critique of historicism attacked the conception of history as a progression through homogeneous, empty time, the time of clocks and of the bourgeois idea of progress, against which he set a now-time (*Jetztzeit*) shot through with messianic interruption (Benjamin 1940, theses XIII–XIV). Benjamin's empty time might seem to be the kenochrony this dissertation praises. It is its opposite. What Benjamin calls empty is homogeneous: every unit identical to every other, a featureless series that can be extended indefinitely and filled with anything because it is shaped for nothing. Such time is not a vessel but a conveyor; its emptiness is that of the warehouse, not of the bowl. In the terms of §1.7, homogeneous time is a hollow through which no breath passes—*kyomu*, not *kū*. The receptive emptiness of kenochrony is, by contrast, heterogeneous: a vessel shaped to receive a particular content, a life, a growth, a return. The tyrant's time is homogeneous in Benjamin's sense—the eternal reign is the same day forever—and it is in this sense that homogeneity is the true plenum.

The deepest form of chronophagy is the desire to possess time entire. Boethius defined eternity, in a formula that governed all subsequent scholastic thought, as the complete, simultaneous, and perfect possession of unending life (*interminabilis vitae tota simul et perfecta possessio Consolation of Philosophy* V.6). The definition was meant for God, who alone can hold all time at once without consuming it. In a creature it becomes the tyrant's dream: to hold the whole of time as a possession, to make every moment his own. Ganondorf's seizure of the Sacred Realm is the attempt to occupy the receptacle outside time and thereby to possess time from outside—to become the Boethian eternal by theft. What the receptacle gives him is what the Triforce gives him: only what he already is. His eternity is a stoppage.

4.3
The Decisive Moment
Kairos, the Door, and the Sword

The Hippocratic *Precepts* open with a definition that is also a riddle: time is that in which there is opportunity, and opportunity is that in which there is not much time (Χρόνος ἐστὶν ἐν ᾧ καιρός, καὶ καιρὸς ἐν ᾧ χρόνος οὐ πολύς; *Precepts* 1). The sculptor Lysippos made a bronze of Kairos for Sicyon, which the epigrammatist Posidippus described: a youth poised on tiptoe on winged feet, holding a razor because he is keener than any edge, his hair falling forward over his face so that whoever meets him may seize him, but bald behind, so that once he has passed no one can take hold of him (*Greek Anthology* 16.275). Later reliefs show him balancing a pair of scales on the edge of the razor: the decisive moment as a weighing, recalling the psychostasia of Chapter II and Homer's idiom for a crisis, that a thing stands upon a razor's edge (*Iliad* 10.173).

Aristotle's definition of virtue as a mean contains a temporal clause: the virtuous person feels and acts at the right times, about the right things, toward the right people, for the right end, and in the right way (*Nicomachean Ethics* II.6, 1106b21–23). Courage is the virtue for which the right time matters most, and in the game courage is enacted as timing. The player's competence in combat consists in knowing the moment to raise the shield, to strike as an enemy's guard opens, to loose the arrow at the instant a target exposes its weak point, to return a sphere of energy to its sender in a volley that quickens until one side misses. The lock-on system analyzed in Chapter VII organizes combat as a sequence of *kairoi*: enemies, in the *chanbara* convention the system borrowed, engage one at a time, and each engagement is a duel won by whoever seizes the opening.

At the level of the narrative, the hero's courage is concentrated in two gestures that are the game's great *kairoi*: the opening of the Door of Time and the drawing of the sword. Both are decisive moments in the strict sense, hinges on which history turns, and both are seized by a child. The child grasps Kairos by the forelock before he is ripe to hold it, and the

consequence is the seven years. Lysippos's statue and Mencius's sprout-puller meet in this scene: the moment is seized, but too early.

The Door of Time has distinguished philosophical cousins. Nietzsche's Zarathustra, climbing with a dwarf who weighs him down, comes to a gateway inscribed with the name *Augenblick*, the Moment, at which two long lanes meet. One runs back for an eternity, the other forward for an eternity; they contradict each other, and at the gateway they converge. The dwarf mutters that all truth is crooked and time itself a circle; Zarathustra rebukes him and unfolds the thought of eternal recurrence (*Thus Spoke Zarathustra* III, "On the Vision and the Riddle"). Benjamin closed his theses on history by recalling that for the Jews every second of time was the strait gate through which the Messiah might enter (Benjamin 1940, appendix B). The Door of Time is such a gateway: two paths meet at it, one leading back seven years and one forward, and the hero, once he has learned its trick, can pass in either direction. It is also a strait gate—through which, however, it is not the messiah who first enters, but the usurper.

The game makes one decisive modification to the concept of *kairos*, and it is profound. *Kairos* is by definition unrepeatable; Lysippos's youth is bald behind. In the game the decisive gesture becomes reversible and iterable. The sword can be returned to its pedestal and drawn again; the door can be passed in both directions; the hero's age becomes a switch. One might see in this the trivialization of the decisive moment that critics of games have often alleged. Kierkegaard offers a better reading. In *Repetition* (1843), the pseudonymous Constantin Constantius attempts to repeat a happy journey to Berlin and fails, discovering that the past cannot be reproduced; but the young man whose letters fill the book finds repetition in another sense, in Job, who after losing everything receives everything back, and himself with it. Repetition and recollection, Constantius observes, are the same movement in opposite directions: what is recollected has been and is repeated backward, whereas genuine repetition is recollected forward (Kierkegaard 1843). The game's reversible *kairos* is an apparatus of repetition in this sense. It never permits the reproduction of the past —the child-world to which the hero returns is altered by what he knows—but it permits a receiving-back of oneself. The ending is its consummation. The hero is given back to himself, as Job was, and the decisive moment is not abolished but returned.

4.4
The Child at Play
Aion, Recurrence, and the Remembering Child

Heraclitus's fragment, which has stood at the head of this dissertation, says that *aiōn* is a child at play, moving pieces on a board, and that the kingship belongs to a child. Nietzsche made the fragment the key to Heraclitus's cosmology: the world as the play of fire with itself,

building and destroying in innocence as a child builds sand-castles by the sea and knocks them down, without guilt and without purpose beyond the play (*Philosophy in the Tragic Age of the Greeks* §7). Eugen Fink founded his philosophy of play as world-symbol upon the same fragment, and the seminar he and Heidegger held on Heraclitus returned to it repeatedly (Fink 1960; Heidegger and Fink 1970).

Thus Spoke Zarathustra opens with a parable of three metamorphoses of the spirit. The camel kneels to be loaded with the heaviest burdens and carries them into the desert; the lion, in the desert, seizes freedom and fights the great dragon whose name is "Thou shalt"; and the child follows, because innocence is the child, and forgetting, a new beginning, a game, a wheel rolling of itself, a first movement, a sacred Yes (*Unschuld ist das Kind und Vergessen, ein Neubeginnen, ein Spiel, ein aus sich rollendes Rad, eine erste Bewegung, ein heiliges Ja-sagen*). The hero's arc follows the parable closely once one sees that its first figure, though a child, is a camel: the boy who kneels to receive tasks from the dying tree, the princess, and the chiefs of every people, and bears them across the world. The adult is the lion who fights the dragon—literally, in Volvagia, and in Ganondorf the "Thou shalt" of a sovereign will imposed upon all. The ending gives the third figure, the child as new beginning. But at this point the game departs from Nietzsche in a way that is the key to its temporal ethics. Nietzsche's child is innocence and forgetting. Link returns to childhood remembering. He carries into the beginning the memory of the end, and the final scene, in which he walks into the castle courtyard toward the princess, is a new beginning that knows what it is beginning.

The philosopher who best grasped what such a remembering recurrence might mean was Kuki Shūzō. In August 1928, at the *décades* of Pontigny, Kuki—who had studied with Rickert, Husserl, and Heidegger and had known Bergson in Paris—lectured in French on the notion of time and its taking-back (*reprise*) in the East (Kuki 1928). Eastern time, he argued, is transmigratory, a recurrence of lives without beginning or end, and to this recurrence two responses are possible. The Buddhist response seeks deliverance from the cycle through the extinction of desire. The response Kuki found in *bushidō*, the warrior's ethic, is the opposite: not to escape the cycle but to will within it, to take up the good again and again with undiminished resolve, for its own sake and without hope of an end. Kuki illustrated this attitude with the figure of Sisyphus, whom he imagined content in his endless labor, an image Camus would make famous fourteen years later. The series of which *Ocarina of Time* is the hinge has precisely this structure. The hero is reborn age after age to fight the same battle against the same enemy, whose last words in this game are a vow to return when the seal is broken and to destroy the descendants of those who sealed him. From the enemy's side the cycle is a curse; from the hero's it is a vocation to be taken up again. The series' later mythology, in *Skyward Sword* (2011), would make the curse explicit as the origin of the cycle. Kuki's lecture had already supplied the ethic with which the hero answers it.

Aion belongs, in the Triforce of Time, to Wisdom, and the princess's relation to time is distinctive. She alone perceives the whole of history before it unfolds: her dream shows her

the dark clouds and the boy from the forest before either has appeared. In the *Timaeus*'s terms, she glimpses the *aiōn* of which history is the moving image. And she alone can dispose of a life entire. Her final act is aionic in the fullest sense: she takes the hero's life as a whole into her hands and returns it to him from its beginning. The prophetess's error, in Chapter III, was to act upon the whole from within the sequence—to secure the relic before the usurper reached it, as a move within *chronos*. Her redemption is to act upon the sequence from the standpoint of the whole: to give back time rather than to win it.

Mary Stuart embroidered on her cloth of state the motto *En ma fin gît mon commencement*: in my end lies my beginning. The game's structure is circular in this sense. It begins with a dream—the child's nightmare of a stormy night, a princess fleeing on horseback with her guardian, a dark rider in pursuit—that proves to be a memory of the future, a scene he will witness later in the same game. It ends with a return to the courtyard in which he first met the princess. In the same chapter of the *Zhuangzi* that contains the piping of earth, Zhuang Zhou dreams that he is a butterfly and wakes uncertain whether he is Zhou who dreamed of being a butterfly or a butterfly dreaming that he is Zhou (*Zhuangzi*, ch. 2). Was the adult hero the dream of the child, or the child the dream of the man? The game declines to say, and the title of the chapter in which Zhuangzi placed his parable, the equality of things, names the refusal. Neither age is the real one. Each is the other's dream.

4.5
The Song as Temporal Object
Augustine, Husserl, Bergson

Augustine's meditation on time in the eleventh book of the *Confessions* arrives at its most famous image through a song. Before I begin a psalm I know by heart, he writes, my expectation extends over the whole of it; as I recite, what I have said passes into memory, and the life of my action is stretched between the memory of what I have said and the expectation of what I am about to say, while my attention is present, through which the future passes into the past. What holds for the psalm holds for each of its syllables, for the longer action of which it is a part, for the whole life of a human being, and for the whole age of the children of men (XI.28.38). Time, for Augustine, is a distension of the soul (*distentio animi*, XI.26.33), and the present a threefold present: of things past in memory, of things present in attention, of things future in expectation (XI.20.26). The song is not one example of time among others. It is time's paradigm, the form in which the soul's stretching becomes audible.

Husserl's lectures on the phenomenology of internal time-consciousness, delivered in 1905 and edited by Heidegger in 1928, took up the same paradigm in a new idiom. A heard melody, Husserl argued, cannot be a mere series of tone-perceptions, for at each instant only one tone sounds; yet we hear the melody. We hear it because each tone, as it passes, is held

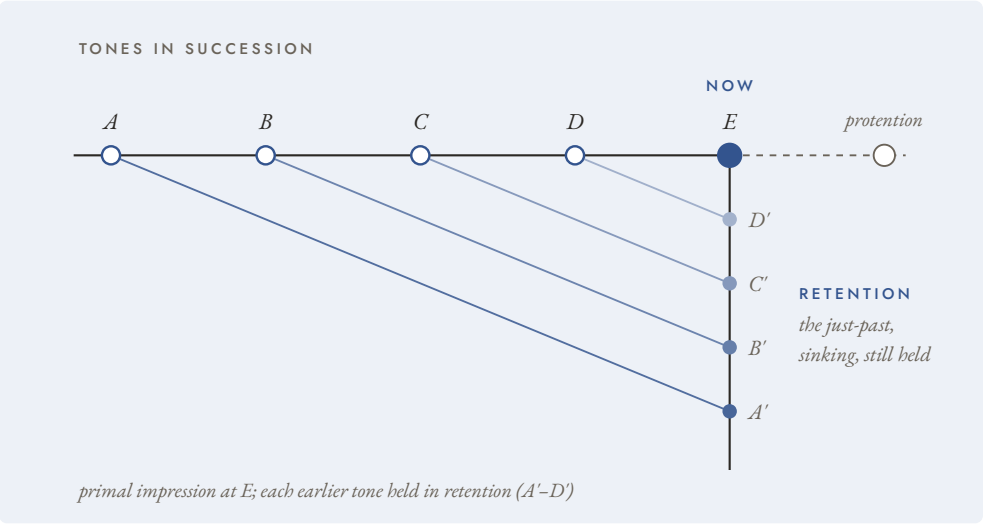


FIGURE 4.2 *The Heard Melody*

After Husserl's lectures on internal time-consciousness: as each tone gives way to the next it is held in retention, sinking but still present, while the coming tone is anticipated in protention. The ocarina, which recognizes a song only when its figure is complete, performs the same structure (§4.5).

in a *retention*—not a memory but the just-past still present to consciousness—while the coming tone is anticipated in a *protention*. The melody is a temporal object constituted by the interplay of retention, primal impression, and protention (Husserl 1928). The ocarina implements a procedural analogue of this structure. As the player plays, the game holds the most recent notes in suspension and compares them against the songs the hero has learned; a song is recognized only when its figure is complete, at which point the game sounds it back in full and its effect follows. The program constitutes the song as a temporal object: it retains the just-played, waits upon the completion of a figure, and recognizes a melody only as a whole. The player's experience of the ocarina is Husserl's melody performed rather than heard.

Bergson distinguished two forms of memory (Bergson 1896, ch. 2). One is habit-memory, a motor mechanism acquired by repetition and lodged in the body—the memory of a lesson learned by heart, which can be recited without recalling any particular occasion of its learning. The other is pure memory, the memory-image: the spontaneous recollection of a unique past event, such as a particular reading of the lesson, dated and unrepeatable. The ocarina binds these two memories together with unusual intimacy. Each song is learned as habit-memory, in the hands: players can still perform, years after their last session, fingerings they acquired as children. But each song is also tied to an image-memory of the person and place from which it was learned—Saria in the forest meadow, Malon in the ranch paddock, the princess in the castle courtyard and beside the moat, the inscription on the wall of a royal tomb, the masked Sheikah at the threshold of each temple. In Bergson's figure of the

cone, the whole of the past is gathered above an apex that touches the plane of present action (ch. 3); the songs are such apexes, points at which the hand's habit touches the whole of a remembered world. Proust's madeleine is the proverbial instance of involuntary memory; for a generation of players, the first bars of the melody of the Lost Woods have become something like a cultural madeleine, a matter Chapter VIII takes up under the heading of nostalgia.

The songs are, without exception, received. The hero learns them from friends and from a princess, from a ranch girl and a man in a windmill, from a masked stranger and from the dead, for the song that turns the sun is inscribed in a tomb. Music in Hyrule is inheritance: a past received into the hands and carried forward into acts. Chapter V argues that a hero who can only repeat what others teach him is Ovid's Echo; Chapter VII considers the one song in the game that the player composes.

The six songs the hero learns from the masked Sheik in order to travel between the temples are named for musical genres, and their names compose a temporal semantics of the kind Leonard Ratner's theory of musical topics describes—the signification of music through conventional associations of genre (Ratner 1980; Agawu 1991). The minuet of forest is a courtly dance of measured steps, decorum and childhood's play. The bolero of fire is the dance that since Ravel's of 1928 has been heard as a single relentless crescendo. The serenade of water is the evening song of a lover beneath a window, apt to the domain of the princess who claims the hero as her betrothed. The nocturne of shadow is the night piece. The requiem of spirit, the mass for the dead, belongs to the colossus of the desert. And the prelude of light, the piece that opens, belongs to the Temple of Time, where every journey in the game begins. Read in sequence, the six names describe a day and a life: a beginning, a youth of courtly measure, an evening of love, a night, a rising fire, and an ending. The warp songs map not only the space of Hyrule but the shape of time.

4.6
The Instrument of Time
Bellows, Pipings, and the Absent Moon

Chapter I argued that the ocarina, as a Helmholtz resonator, models time not as a line but as a volume: what sounds is a function of how much of the vessel stands open. The *Daodejing* supplies the instrument's cosmological counterpart. Is not the space between heaven and earth, it asks, like a bellows? Empty yet not exhausted; the more it is worked, the more comes forth (*Daodejing* §5). The ocarina is a microcosmic bellows, a hollow that yields sound in proportion to the breath that moves through it. That the hero's ocarina can turn day into night, the effect of the Sun's Song, is the bellows of heaven and earth worked by a child's breath.

The *Zhuangzi*'s chapter on the equality of things opens with a teacher who, asked why he seems like withered wood and dead ashes, speaks of three pipings. The piping of humans is the music of flutes and reeds. The piping of earth is the wind's music in the hollows of the great trees—hollows like nostrils, mouths, and ears, like cups, mortars, and pools—each sounding its own note as the wind passes. The piping of heaven is that by which the ten thousand hollows are made to sound each in its own way, so that each takes what it is from itself; and who, the teacher asks, is it that blows them? (*Zhuangzi*, ch. 2). The ocarina unites the three pipings. It is an instrument of humans; it is made of earth, of fired clay, and is itself a hollow; and its music governs heaven, turning the sun, calling the storm, opening time.

Boethius divided music into three kinds: *musica mundana*, the harmony of the cosmos, of spheres, elements, and seasons; *musica humana*, the harmony that binds body and soul; and *musica instrumentalis*, the audible music of voices and instruments, lowest of the three (*De institutione musica* I.2). The ocarina's songs act at every level. The Sun's Song and the Song of Time act upon the cosmos. Saria's Song brings the stern Goron chief to dance, and Epona's Song calms a frightened horse and summons her across the plain: music acting upon the harmony of body and soul. And all are played upon an instrument. But Hyrule inverts Boethius's hierarchy. The humblest level, a clay instrument in a child's hands, commands the highest, the motion of the sun. The microcosm governs the macrocosm.

Two of the songs echo the *Kojiki*'s sun and storm. The Sun's Song, inscribed in a royal tomb, turns night to day; in the *Kojiki* the sun goddess Amaterasu, having hidden herself in the Rock Cave of Heaven and plunged the world into darkness, is drawn out by the gods' festival of noise and dance, so that music returns the sun. The Song of Storms calls rain; the storm god Susanoo is Amaterasu's turbulent brother. Here the hollow-center analysis of Chapter II yields a remarkable observation. In the *Kojiki*, between sun and storm stands their nearly absent sibling Tsukuyomi, deity of the moon, Kawai's paradigm of the inactive center. *Ocarina of Time* has a song for the sun and a song for the storm. It has no song for the moon. The moon is the absent middle of Hyrule's weather music. In the sequel, *Majora's Mask* (2000), the moon returns—bearing a carved and grimacing face, falling from the sky toward the town at the center of its world, the catastrophe the hero averts only by playing the Song of Time again and again. What *Ocarina of Time* left as the empty center of its music becomes, in its successor, a plenum descending from heaven.

The ocarina's powers also set the hero in the line of Orpheus, whose song moved stones and trees, tamed beasts, and opened the way to the underworld. The hero's music opens a royal tomb, calls rain, turns the sun, summons a horse, stills the undead, and opens the Door of Time: it is music with power over nature, over death, and over time. Orpheus failed at the threshold of return, turning to look at Eurydice before they reached the light. The hero's music succeeds at a threshold of return, but the return it accomplishes, at the game's end, is his own.

4.7
The Loop Without Origin
The Song of Storms

In the adult era, a man sits in the windmill of Kakariko turning the crank of a hand organ and nursing a grievance. Seven years ago, he says, a boy came in and played a song that set the mill spinning wildly and dried up the village well. He plays the song himself, and the hero learns it. Returned to the past, the child hero enters the windmill and plays the song to the man—who learns it from him—and the mill spins and the well runs dry. The song the hero learns from the man is the song the man learned from the hero. Within the game's history it has no origin.

Such a structure is what philosophers of time travel call a causal loop and what popular usage, after Robert Heinlein's story "By His Bootstraps" (1941), calls a bootstrap paradox. David Lewis's classic paper argued that time travel involves no contradiction and that such loops, though strange, are not impossible: each event in the loop is explained by its predecessor, but the loop as a whole is not explained, and the question of where its information first came from has no answer (Lewis 1976). Physicists entertaining closed timelike curves, from Kurt Gödel's rotating universe (1949) to the self-consistency principle associated with Igor Novikov, have treated such loops as admissible so long as they are globally consistent, as the game's is: the song, once learned, guarantees its own teaching. Fiction has explored the form repeatedly—most vertiginously in Heinlein's "—All You Zombies—" (1959), whose

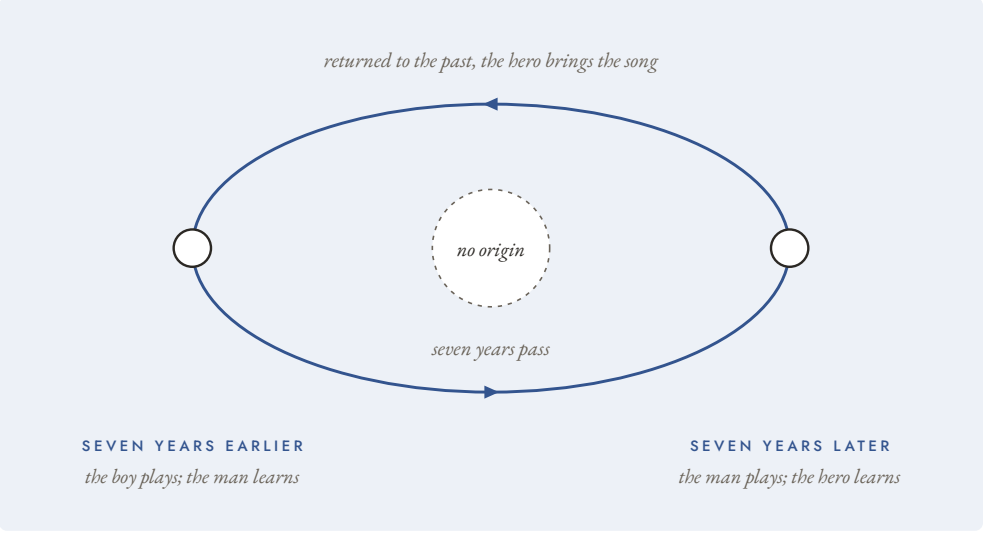


FIGURE 4.3 *The Loop Without Origin*

The Song of Storms: the hero learns the song from the man who learned it from the hero. Each event in the loop is explained by its predecessor; the loop as a whole, by nothing (§4.7; after Lewis 1976).

time traveler proves to be his own mother and father, and in Chris Marker's *La Jetée* (1962), whose protagonist, haunted by a childhood memory of a man's death on an airport pier, discovers at the end that the death was his own.

Two features make the Song of Storms more than a curiosity. First, it is the only song in Hyrule's history that the hero originates, and he originates it only by repeating his own future. Elsewhere the hero is a pure receiver of music; here, once, he is a source, but a source that is also a recipient—Echo answering herself. The song has no composer. It is music without an author, Barthes's death of the author made into a law of time. Second, the loop is a gift without a first giver. Derrida argued that a gift, if there is one, must not return to the giver as a debt, must not even appear as a gift, lest it be annulled in the economy of exchange (Derrida 1991). The Song of Storms circulates between the man and the boy as a gift that neither first gave: an economy in which nothing is owed because no one began it. And the song's content befits its form. A song of storms, it belongs to the trickster weather of Susanoo, and its first effect in the game is to empty a vessel, draining the village well to open the dungeon at its bottom. The uncaused song produces a hollow.

Beside the Song of Storms stands the game's only melody with a true origin, and that origin lies outside the world. At Lake Hylia a scarecrow invites the child hero to play any melody of eight notes he likes; years later, in the adult era, the same melody summons a scarecrow companion who serves as an anchor for the hookshot. The player is the only composer in Hyrule. Chapter VII returns to this fact. Here it suffices to note that the game's two exceptions to the hero's receptivity frame the problem of origin from either side. In the loop, the music comes from nowhere within the world; in the scarecrow's song, it comes from beyond the world altogether, from the breath that animates the vessel.

4.8 Three Histories and the Canonized Defeat

Ludic Modal Realism

Hyrule Historia, as Chapter I noted, divided the history of the series into three branches at the end of *Ocarina of Time*. In the first, the hero, returned to childhood, warns the princess and the king, and the usurper is apprehended before his rise; the histories of *Majora's Mask* and *Twilight Princess* follow. In the second, the world from which the hero departed continues without him; the usurper eventually returns, and the gods drown the kingdom beneath the sea, the history of *The Wind Waker*. In the third, the hero is defeated in the final battle; the usurper seizes the whole of the Triforce, and the sages seal him in the Sacred Realm, which becomes a dark world. From this branch descend *A Link to the Past* and the original *Legend of Zelda* of 1986.

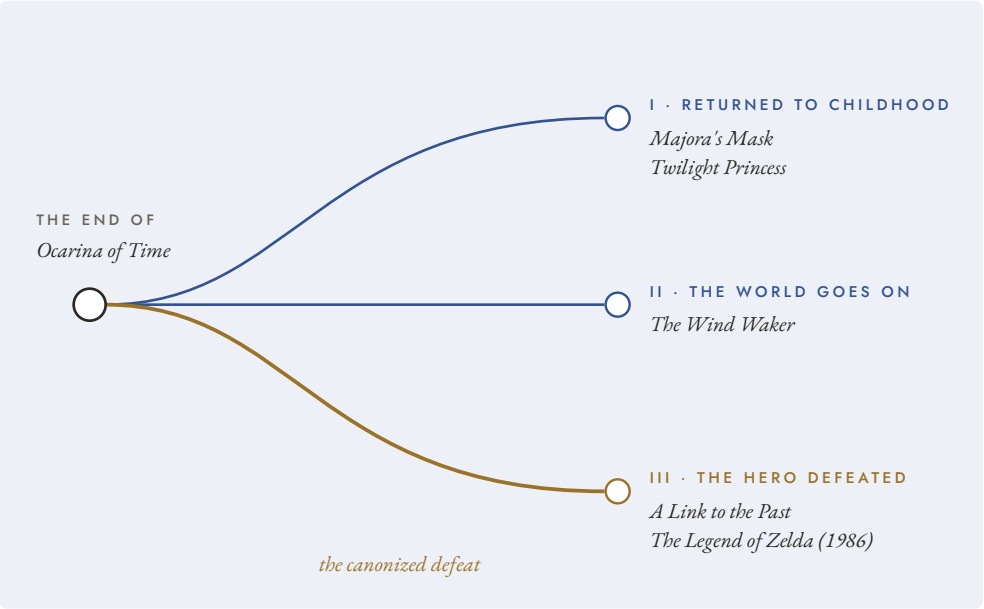


FIGURE 4.4 *Three Histories*

The division of the chronology at the end of *Ocarina of Time* in *Hyrule Historia* (2011), with the installments named in §4.8 on each branch. The third branch gives the player's defeat a history: ludic modal realism.

Borges imagined, in "The Garden of Forking Paths" (1941), the novel of Ts'ui Pên, in which at every juncture the narrative takes all the paths open to it, so that time becomes a growing network of divergent, convergent, and parallel times. Hugh Everett's relative-state formulation of quantum mechanics (1957), popularized as the many-worlds interpretation, gave the image a physical reading. Leibniz, as Chapter II recalled, kept the alternatives unactual: the apartments of the Palace of the Fates contain worlds God did not create. David Lewis's modal realism went further than any of these. Every possible world is as real as ours, and "actual" is merely an indexical, naming whichever world the speaker happens to inhabit (Lewis 1986).

Of the three branches the third is the most extraordinary, for it canonizes the outcome that occurs whenever a player fails: the hero's death in the final battle. In the ordinary ontology of games, defeat is non-historical. The game-over marks a failed performance that the reload unmakes; it is an event that does not count. *Hyrule Historia* gives the failed performance a history of its own, with subsequent ages, heroes, and games. I call this doctrine *ludic modal realism*: the treatment of the possible outcomes of play not as counterfactuals but as actual worlds, each as real as the canonical one. Jesper Juul has shown how central failure is to the experience of games—how players seek out activities that make them feel inadequate in order to overcome the inadequacy (Juul 2013). The official chronology goes

further than any theory of failure. It makes failure into history. Every player's defeat at the hands of the beast in the ruined tower now has a world in which it is true.

Three implications follow. For the theodicy of Chapter II, ludic modal realism builds the lower apartments of Leibniz's palace: the worse worlds exist, and the series has lived in them. For the ethics of play, it confers weight upon defeat; the game-over is no longer nothing. And for the argument of this dissertation, it confirms the generative power of the void, for the node from which the three histories diverge is the ending of *Ocarina of Time*—the moment at which the princess returns the hero's time empty. The gift of unfilled time is the branching point of a plurality of worlds. A critical note is nonetheless required. The official chronology was a retroactive construction by the corporation that owns the series, codifying a shared history its games had not been designed to share. For more than a decade before 2011, players had debated the chronology in a folk historiography of rival timelines that kept the question open. The publication of an official answer was, in the terms of Chapter I, a plenary gesture—the filling of an interpretive hollow by institutional authority—even as the answer's content multiplied the world. The paratext canonized plurality and closed the debate in a single stroke.

4.9
Chronophagy and Kenochrony
The Hero's Sabbath

Derrida's book on the gift, *Given Time*, opens with a sentence from a letter of Madame de Maintenon: *Le Roi prend tout mon temps; je donne le reste à Saint-Cyr, à qui je voudrais tout donner*—the King takes all my time; I give the rest to Saint-Cyr, to whom I would like to give it all (Derrida 1991). The sentence contains this chapter's argument in miniature. The sovereign takes all one's time: chronophagy. What remains is given away: the gift of time. And the wish is to give all of it—a wish that, as Derrida observes, cannot be fulfilled, for time is not a thing one has and can hand over. Yet this impossible gift is precisely the one the princess gives the hero. She gives him back his time, which she never possessed and he never lived.

The Hebrew Bible supplies the institutional form of kenochrony. On the seventh day God ceased from the work of creation and rested, and blessed the seventh day and made it holy (Gen. 2:2–3)—a cosmogony that, like Hyrule's, ends in a divine withdrawal. Abraham Joshua Heschel described the Sabbath as a palace in time, a sanctuary built not of stone but of hours, and observed that the Bible sanctifies time before it sanctifies space (Heschel 1951). The Sabbath is kenochronic: time made holy by being emptied of labor. Leviticus extends the principle to the land and to history. Every seventh year the land shall keep a sabbath of rest (Lev. 25:4); and after seven sevens of years a jubilee shall be proclaimed, in

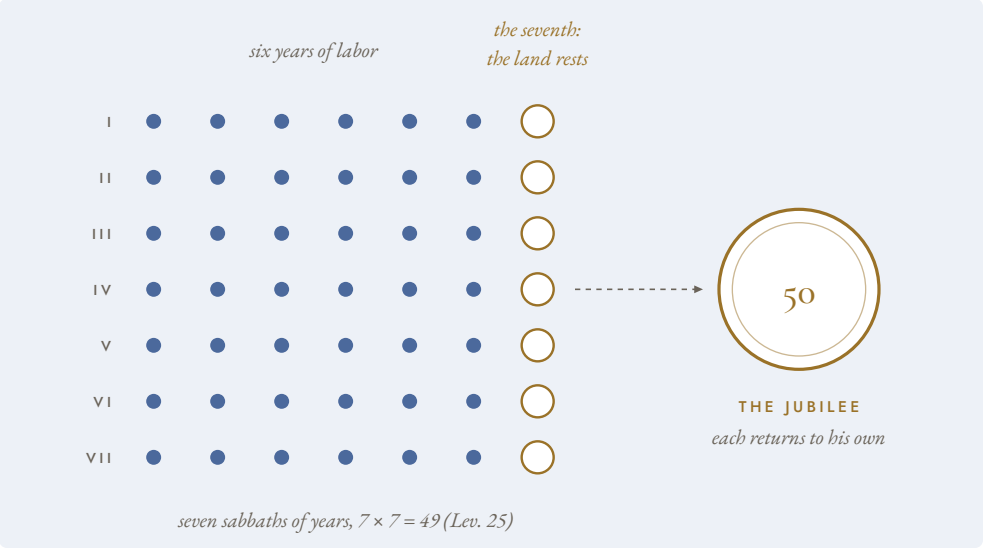


FIGURE 4.5 *A Palace in Time*

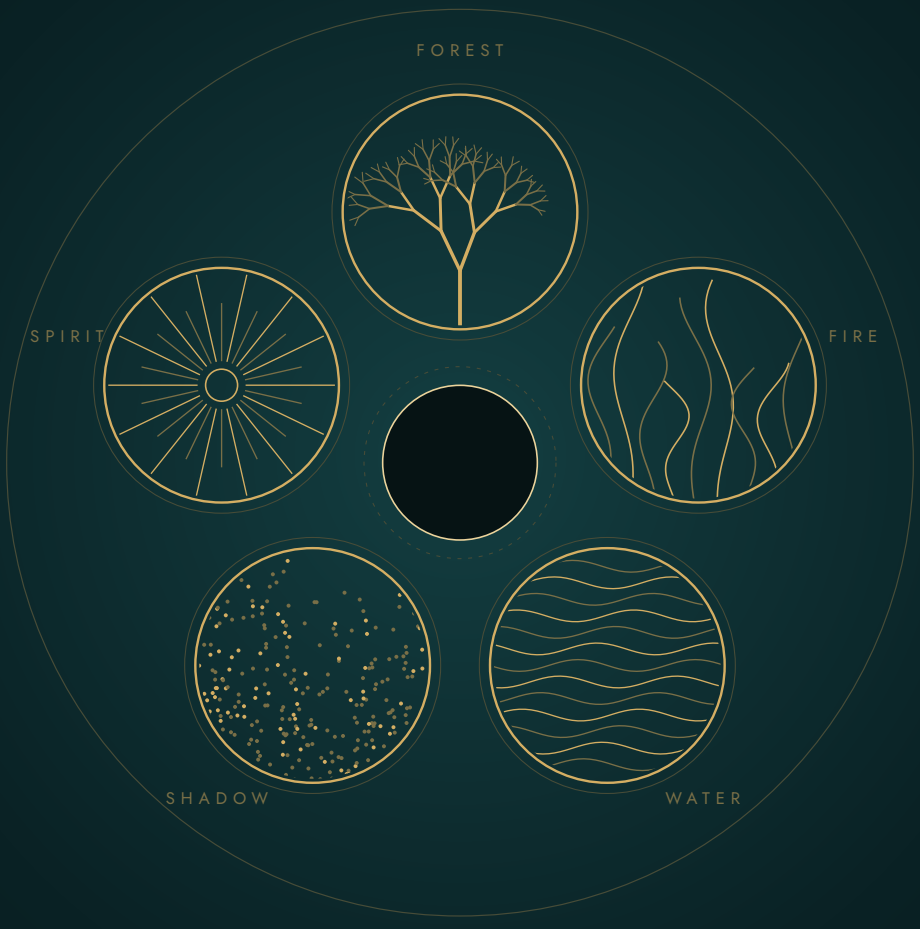
Kenochrony institutionalized: six years of labor and a seventh in which the land keeps a sabbath (Lev. 25:4), seven times over, then the fiftieth year of jubilee, in which each returns to his own (Lev. 25:10). Filled years are drawn as points, emptied years as vessels (§4.9).

which liberty is declared throughout the land and every one returns to his own possession and to his family (Lev. 25:10).

Ocarina of Time follows this structure with remarkable fidelity. Its seven years are a sabbatical inverted: not a rest granted to the land but a desolation imposed upon it, a seventh year of the tyrant's making in which the lake is drained and the fields lie under his shadow. Its ending is a jubilee. The princess proclaims release; the hero is returned to his own place and the time that was his restored to him; the tyrant's possession is undone. Kenochrony is therefore not a modern coinage for an alien idea but a name for an ethic of time shared by the Sabbath and the jubilee, by Daoist emptiness, by Mencius's patience with sprouts, and by Klein's reparation: time is holy when it is kept open, and justice in time is the return of each to his own.

Chronophagy is the tyrant's anti-sabbath, the eternal working day of domination, a time that never rests and never returns anything. Kenochrony is the hero's sabbath, a time emptied so that it may be lived. The Triforce of Time thus has the same structure as the golden triangle of Chapter II. Its three terms—the devouring sequence, the decisive moment, the whole—surround a receptacle outside time, and its integrity depends upon the receptacle's remaining open. When the tyrant occupies the receptacle, time stops; when the princess empties it, time begins again. Chapter V descends from time into the spaces in which it is spent: the hollow interiors of Hyrule.

CHAPTER



V

The Architecture of Interiority

Dungeons, Elements, and the Material Imagination of the Hollow

ἰδὲ γὰρ ἀνθρώπους οἷον ἐν καταγείῳ οἰκήσει σπηλαιώδει.

Picture human beings living as though in an underground, cave-like dwelling.

— Plato, *Republic* VII 514a (trans. mine)

vocalis nymphe, quae nec reticere loquenti / nec prior ipsa loqui didicit, resonabilis Echo.

The vocal nymph, who has learned neither to keep silent when another speaks nor to speak first herself: resounding Echo.

— Ovid, *Metamorphoses* III.357–358 (trans. mine)

5.1
From Plan to Interior
The Dungeon as Hollow

The dungeon is the adventure game's native form, and it was born underground in more than one sense. *Dungeons & Dragons*, published by Gary Gygax and Dave Arneson in 1974, gave the form its name and its grammar of rooms, corridors, doors, and guardians. *Colossal Cave Adventure*, the first text adventure, was written in the mid-1970s by Will Crowther, a programmer and caver who modeled its passages on the Bedquilt section of Kentucky's Mammoth Cave, which he had helped to survey, and expanded by Don Woods in 1977. And Miyamoto has repeatedly traced *The Legend of Zelda* to his childhood explorations of the countryside around Sonobe, outside Kyoto: the lake he came upon unexpectedly while hiking, the cave he found and returned to with a lantern (Sheff 1993). The adventure game has a speleological origin, and its philosophical original is older still: the cave of the seventh book of the *Republic*, in which prisoners watch shadows cast upon a wall by firelight and take them for the real (514a–517a). The screen on which a game appears is a cave wall in exactly Plato's sense, and the dungeons of *Ocarina of Time*, as §5.6 argues, are caves of a curious kind: places one enters in order to learn to see.

Ocarina of Time transformed the dungeon in one decisive respect. In the overhead games that preceded it, a dungeon was a plan: a grid of rooms seen from above, legible as a map even while it was traversed. In de Certeau's terms, the player held the map and the tour at once (de Certeau 1980). In three dimensions the dungeon becomes an interior, experienced from inside at the height of the body, with verticality, enclosure, darkness, and echo. The game preserves the older mode in a pair of items found in every dungeon, a map and a compass, which give the player back the view from above; but the primary experience is now Bachelardian. The dungeon is felt as a hollow before it is known as a plan. The passage from map to interior is the spatial form of the conversion this dissertation has traced from surface to vessel.

Each dungeon has the structure of a vessel within a vessel. Its rooms are sealed by doors that open only to small keys found within, and its innermost chamber by a great key. Within it lies a single tool—slingshot, boomerang, bow, hammer, the extended hookshot, boots, gauntlets, a mirror-shield—that is required both to complete the dungeon and to open spaces beyond it. The tool is the content the hollow yields, and that content is itself an enlarged capacity. Nintendo's designers have described their practice of level design in terms of the four-part structure of classical Sino-Japanese poetics, *kishōtenketsu*—an element introduced, developed, turned by a twist, and brought to a conclusion—as Koichi Hayashida explained in a widely cited interview about *Super Mario 3D Land*. The dungeons of *Ocarina of Time* follow this shape around their tools: the tool is found, its uses are developed, a twist reveals an unexpected application, and the guardian at the center requires it for victory.

Notably, *kishōtenketsu* has no place for conflict as Western dramatic theory understands it; its third movement is not a clash but a turn. The dungeon so conceived is not primarily an obstacle course but a lesson in an object.

At the center of each dungeon waits a guardian, and the guardians share a family resemblance that the elemental analysis below makes explicit: each is a corruption of the element its temple houses. And at the end of each of the adult temples waits not a treasure but a person, a sage awakened. The final content of the hollow is a relation.

5.2
The Material Imagination
Bachelard's Elements and the Five Temples

Gaston Bachelard, the philosopher of science who became in mid-career the century's great theorist of the poetic image, argued that the imagination is not only formal, a play of shapes, but material: images are rooted in the substances of the world, and above all in the four elements of ancient physics, each of which elicits its own register of reverie. He devoted a book to each—to fire (1938), to water (1942), to air (1943), and to earth (two volumes, 1948)—and crowned the series with *The Poetics of Space* (1958), a phenomenology of the house, of cellar and attic, of drawers and chests, nests and shells, corners and miniatures, and of the dialectic of inside and outside. In each book he identified complexes, clusters of image and desire named after the myths and poets in which he found them. The five adult temples of *Ocarina of Time* are organized by element, and they read, with remarkable precision, as a Bachelardian sequence.

The Forest Temple is a manor in the woods, reached by hookshot from the branch of a tree in the forest meadow; inside, the house is haunted. Four ghost sisters have stolen the flames of its four torches, and the English localization named them for the March sisters of *Little Women*—Meg, Jo (here Joelle), Beth, and Amy—so that the novel of girls growing up in a household becomes, in Hyrule, a household of girls who have become ghosts. A corridor twists upon its own axis when the hero strikes a target; the walls of the basement rotate. The guardian is a phantom of Ganondorf, who rides out of paintings on the walls: an image become a double, the *eidōlon* that Plato placed at a third remove from the real (*Republic* X 597e), turned predator. This is Bachelard's house made uncanny. Freud's essay on the uncanny turned on the German word *unheimlich*, the un-homely, and showed how the most familiar becomes the most frightening when it returns estranged (Freud 1919). The Forest Temple is the hero's home—the forest—returned to him as a haunted house.

The Fire Temple lies within the crater of Death Mountain. The Gorons have been imprisoned in its cells to be fed to the dragon Volvagia, whom a Goron hero of legend once slew with a great hammer; the hero recovers that hammer within the temple and uses it to

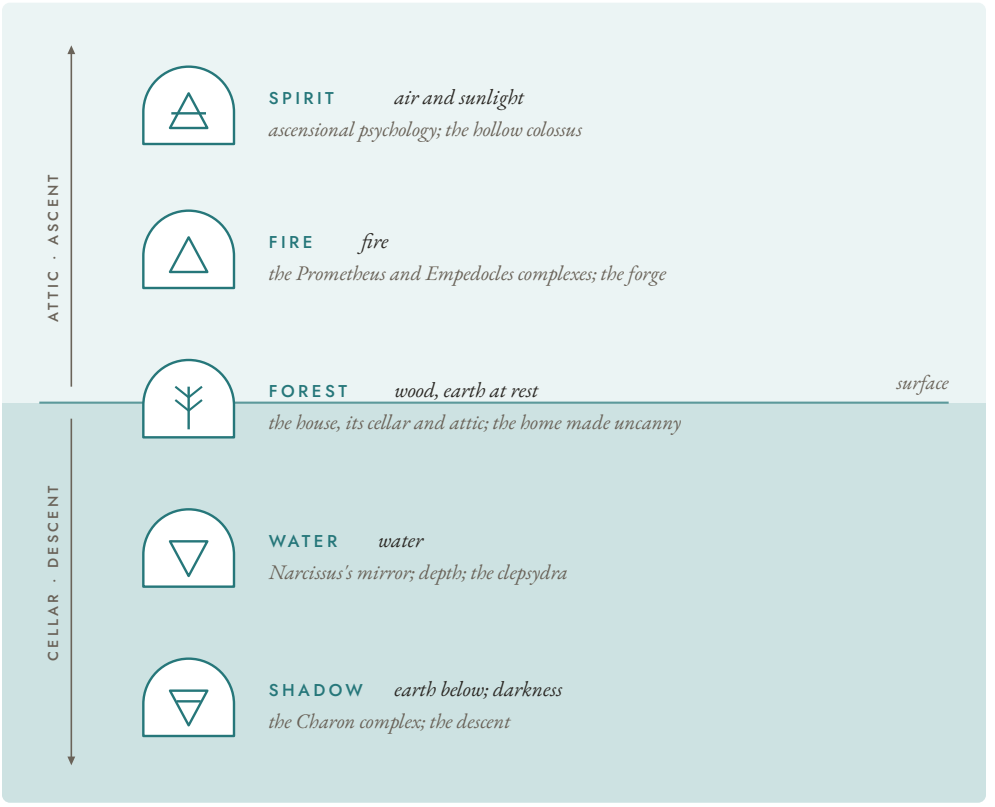


FIGURE 5.1 *The Vertical House*

The five adult temples set at their elevations, from the colossus in the desert to the crypt beneath the graveyard, read through Bachelard's polarity of attic and cellar. Elements and images follow Table 5.1 (§5.2).

strike the dragon's head as it surfaces from holes in the floor—a gesture at once Thor's blow against the world-serpent and the arcade game of striking moles as they pop up. Bachelard's *Psychoanalysis of Fire* identified a Prometheus complex, the will to know as much as one's fathers and more than they, the child's appropriation of the forbidden flame; and an Empedocles complex, the fascination in which the love of fire unites the instinct for life and the instinct for death, named for the philosopher said to have leapt into the crater of Etna (Diogenes Laërtius 8.69; Bachelard 1938). The hero who descends into a burning mountain protected only by a tunic of fire-resistant cloth, recovers the ancestral hammer, and slays the dragon to whom a people was being sacrificed—as Susanoo, Theseus, and Perseus slew theirs—enacts both complexes. And his tool belongs to the forge. Bachelard's later book on earth and the will praised the hammer as the instrument of a will that works resistant matter (Bachelard 1948a).

The Water Temple lies beneath Lake Hylia. Its organizing principle, noted in §1.6, is the level of the water within it, which the hero changes by playing the princess's lullaby before

emblems of the Triforce; he wears iron boots to sink and fires a lengthened hookshot to rise. Bachelard's *Water and Dreams* distinguished clear and deep waters, dormant and dead waters, named the Charon and Ophelia complexes, and opened with the cosmic narcissism by which the world contemplates itself in water (Bachelard 1942). The temple's guardian, Morpha, is an amoeboid creature of water with a single visible nucleus: form emerging from formlessness, the *archē* of Thales, for whom all things were water. And at the temple's heart lies the mirror-room in which the hero meets his reflection, read in §5.5.

The Shadow Temple lies beneath the graveyard of Kakariko and is entered by lighting torches with the fire of a goddess. Its passages are crossed by invisible floors and false walls, visible only through the Lens of Truth; its rooms contain instruments of torture; and at one point the hero must cross a dark chasm on a ferry-like boat while skeletal warriors drop onto its deck. Bachelard named the Charon complex for exactly this image: death imagined as a voyage, the boat of the dead crossing dark water (Bachelard 1942). The guardian, Bongo Bongo, is a phantom whose two severed hands beat upon a vast drum, recalling the shaman's drum that Eliade identified as the vehicle of ecstatic descent to the underworld (Eliade 1951). The temple is the game's *katabasis*, its descent among the dead, cognate with Odysseus's Nekyia, Aeneas's descent in the sixth book of the *Aeneid*, Izanagi's journey to Yomi, and Inanna's passage through the seven gates of the netherworld, at each of which she is stripped of one of her powers. That the hero's descents accumulate tools while Inanna's divest her of hers is a contrast to which Chapter VIII returns, for the game's ending is the hero's passage through the gates in reverse.

The Spirit Temple lies in the desert, inside a colossal statue of a seated goddess whom the desert people venerate as the Goddess of the Sand. Its puzzles turn on sunlight: the hero redirects beams with a polished shield to strike emblems of the sun. Its guardians are twin witches of fire and ice who fuse into one, and whom the hero defeats by catching their magic in his mirror-shield and turning it back upon them. Bachelard's *Air and Dreams* developed an ascensional psychology, the will to rise, the vertical reverie of flight and light (Bachelard 1943); Plato's sun, in the sixth book of the *Republic*, is the image of the Good that makes all things visible (507b–509c). The Spirit Temple is the temple of reflected light and of the hollow statue, a figure §5.6 develops through Alcibiades's comparison of Socrates to the hollow Silenus figures that open to reveal gods within (*Symposium* 215a–b). Twice in the temple the hero emerges onto the colossus's outstretched palms, and one recalls the monkey king of *Journey to the West*, who boasts that he can leap beyond the Buddha's hand, flies to the end of the world, and learns that the five pillars at which he arrived were the Buddha's fingers (*Journey to the West*, ch. 7).

The table makes two things visible. First, every guardian is a perversion of its element's imaginative power: the house's intimacy perverted into haunting and its images into a phantom double; fire into a devouring dragon; water's formlessness into an amoeba and its reflection into a hostile twin; the descent among the dead into a phantom drumming with

TABLE 5.1 *The five temples as a Bachelardian sequence.*

TEMPLE	ELEMENT	BACHELARD'S IMAGE OR COMPLEX	GUARDIAN	TOOL ACQUIRED	SAGE AWAKENED
Forest	wood, earth at rest	the house, its cellar and attic; the home made uncanny	Phantom Ganon	Fairy Bow	Saria
Fire	fire	the Prometheus and Empedocles complexes; the forge	Volvagia	Megaton Hammer	Darunia
Water	water	Narcissus's mirror; depth; the clepsydra	Morpha	Longshot	Ruto
Shadow	earth below; darkness	the Charon complex; the descent	Bongo Bongo	Hover Boots	Impa
Spirit	air and sunlight	ascensional psychology; the hollow colossus	Twinrova	Silver Gauntlets, Mirror Shield	Nabooru

severed hands; air and light into witches who can only destroy, by heat and by cold. Second, every temple ends in a person. The final content of each hollow is a sage, freed from captivity or revealed in a true identity, who takes a place in the seal. Bachelard's poetics of the interior culminates in intimacy. The game's culminates in relation.

5.3
The Dying Tree
The Two Trees, the World-Ash, and the Parasite in the Sacred Body

The first dungeon of the game is the body of a god. The hero enters the Great Deku Tree through its mouth and descends through its hollow trunk, past webs and the larvae of the parasite, to a chamber at the root where the parasite itself waits: Gohma, an armored arachnid with a single great eye, whom the game's own title card names a parasite, set within the tree by the curse of the man from the desert. The hero kills it. The curse is lifted. The tree dies anyway.

Tolkien's *The Silmarillion* (1977) begins the history of its world's sorrows with the murder of two trees. Telperion and Laurelin, the Two Trees of Valinor, silver and gold, filled the Blessed Realm with their light. The dark lord Melkor, allied with Ungoliant, a vast spider out of the void who hungers for light, comes upon them in darkness; Ungoliant drinks their sap and light while Melkor wounds them, and they wither and die. Their light survives only in the three jewels called Silmarils, which the elf Fëanor had made to hold it, and Melkor, having killed the trees, steals the jewels—a theft from which the wars of the First Age descend. The structural homology with the opening of *Ocarina of Time* holds in every

element: a sacred tree that is the source of life and light to an ageless forest people; a dark lord who does not strike it himself but sets a spider-parasite upon it; the death of the tree by an interior draining; a jewel, given by the tree before its death, that holds what remains of its virtue; and the dark lord's desire for that jewel, and for its two companions, which drives the history that follows. Tolkien's jewels are three, as Hyrule's Spiritual Stones are three. The Kokiri Emerald is a Silmaril. Tolkien's account of the aftermath has its echo too: from the dying trees the gods coaxed a last flower and a last fruit, which became the Moon and the Sun, the lights of a new age. From the dead guardian of Hyrule grows a sprout.

The Norse world-tree offers a second triangulation. The Eddic poem *Grímnismál* tells that the ash Yggdrasil suffers more than men know: a hart bites it above, its side rots, and the dragon Níðhöggr gnaws it from below (st. 35); Snorri's *Gylfaginning* adds that the Norns, the women of fate who dwell by Urðr's well at its root, water it every day so that its branches will not wither or rot (ch. 16). The world-tree is perpetually consumed and perpetually tended. The Great Deku Tree is Hyrule's world-tree, guardian of a whole region of life; its parasite is its Níðhöggr; and the forest after its death is tended into renewal not by the old guardian but by its successor.

A third comparison is chronologically the closest. *Princess Mononoke*, Hayao Miyazaki's epic of the war between an ironworking town and the gods of the forest, was released in Japan in July 1997, some sixteen months before *Ocarina of Time*. At its climax the Forest Spirit, the deer-god of life and death, is beheaded by the lady of the ironworks; its headless body spreads death across the land; and when its head is returned it dies, and the land turns green again, the small tree-spirits returning among the new shoots. Two of the most important Japanese works of 1997–98 thus stage the death of a forest god at the hands of an agent of power, a devastation, and a regreening after the god is gone. I claim no influence. The resonance concerns a cultural moment in which the old Shinto imagination of the sacred tree and the forest *kami* was being reworked into what Timothy Morton would call a dark ecology, an ecological thought without consolation that refuses the pastoral fantasy of nature as a harmonious home (Morton 2007). Alenda Chang has urged critics to attend to the ways games simulate environments as systems rather than backdrops (Chang 2019); the forest of *Ocarina of Time* is such a system, in which the guardian is not restored but succeeded.

A last observation returns to the name. *Deku* is the useless blockhead, and the *Zhuangzi* contains a celebrated parable about a useless tree. A master carpenter passes a vast oak standing at an earth-altar and does not deign to look at it, for its wood is good for nothing; that night the tree appears to him in a dream and explains that its uselessness is precisely what has allowed it to grow so old and great, since useful trees are cut down (*Zhuangzi*, ch. 4). The Great Deku Tree dies because it is not useless. It holds something coveted, a Spiritual Stone, and the guardian is destroyed for what it guards. In Zhuangzi's terms it is a tree that

failed to be a *deku*. Its death is the first lesson of the Ocarina Principle in negative form: whatever holds a coveted content draws the hand that would possess it.

5.4
The Belly of the God

Jonah, Pinocchio, and the Night-Sea Journey

The third dungeon of the childhood era is again a body. The Zora worship Lord Jabu-Jabu, a vast fish deity who dwells in the fountain at the source of their river. Their princess has vanished into the god, and the god harbors a parasite. The hero offers Jabu-Jabu a fish from a bottle, and the god swallows him. Inside, the walls are flesh and jellyfish crackle with current; the princess, Ruto, is found and must be carried—she insists upon it—through the god's organs. At the center, fastened to the roof of the god's interior, waits another parasite, Barinade, a bio-electric anemone, whose destruction cures the god. The hero emerges with the princess and the jewel she offers as a pledge of betrothal.

The Book of Jonah supplies the archetype—and, as it happens, more than one. Jonah, fleeing his commission to preach to Nineveh, is thrown overboard and swallowed by a great fish appointed by God, in whose belly he remains three days and three nights, praying from what he calls the belly of Sheol, until the fish casts him out upon dry land (Jonah 1:17–2:10). The Gospel of Matthew made the episode a sign of death and resurrection, the Son of Man three days in the heart of the earth (Matt. 12:40), and medieval typology read it accordingly. But the book contains a second episode that bears directly on this chapter. After Nineveh has repented and been spared, Jonah sits sulking east of the city, and God appoints a plant to grow up over him for shade; then, at dawn, God appoints a worm that attacks the plant, so that it withers (Jonah 4:6–7). The little book thus contains both of the sacred bodies of the game's childhood: the great fish that swallows the reluctant hero, and the plant killed by a worm. Through the procedural criterion this is a coincidence of motifs; through Warburg it is the survival of a pair of pathos formulas, the swallowing and the withering, which the game, like the Hebrew book, uses to frame a hero's passage through death to his mission.

Collodi's Pinocchio, near the end of his adventures, is swallowed by the Terrible Dogfish, a monster more than a kilometer long, and in its belly finds Geppetto, who has been living there for two years by the light of a candle. He carries his father out on his back, swimming through the night to shore; shortly afterward, having learned to labor and care for others, he wakes to find that he has become a real boy (Collodi 1883, chs. 34–36). The hero of Hyrule, too, carries another person through the belly of a great fish, and the comparison clarifies the episode's moral structure. The trial in the belly is not combat alone but care: the princess must be carried, set down, lifted again, and shielded from the god's defenses. The real boy

among the wooden children of Chapter III proves himself in the fish as Pinocchio did, by bearing another.

Leo Frobenius gathered the myths of a solar hero swallowed by a sea monster in the west, journeying through the night within its body, and cutting his way free at dawn in the east (Frobenius 1904); Jung made this night-sea journey, the *Nachtmeerfahrt*, a figure for the regressive descent into the unconscious that precedes psychic rebirth (Jung 1912); and Campbell placed the belly of the whale among the first stages of the hero's departure (Campbell 1949). The satirist Lucian had long before turned the motif into a world. In his *True History*, travelers swallowed with their ship by a whale fifteen hundred stades long find inside it a land with hills and forests, a temple, and inhabitants, among whom they live for more than a year before escaping (*True History* I.30–II.2). Lucian's whale is the first dungeon in Western literature: an inhabited interior larger than any exterior should allow. The dungeons of *Ocarina of Time* share this property. The interiors of the tree and of the fish are larger and more intricate than the bodies that contain them; as Bachelard said of the house's intimate immensity, the inside exceeds the outside (Bachelard 1958, ch. 8). Capacity exceeds its container: the Ocarina Principle in spatial form.

Taken together, the dungeons of the childhood era share a structure that distinguishes them from those of the adult era. The child's dungeons are bodies: the trunk of a tree, a cavern in a mountain whose inner sanctum opens through the jaws of a giant skull, the belly of a fish. Each body is sacred, each is infested, and the child's task is to enter it and purge the infestation—an immune function, the heroism of the physician who intervenes at the crisis of a disease, the *kairos* of the Hippocratic tradition. The adult's dungeons are buildings: a manor, a temple in a volcano, a temple beneath a lake, a crypt, a statue. As he grows, the hero passes from the interiors of nature to the interiors of culture, from the bodies of gods to the architecture of their worship. Lévi-Strauss's opposition of nature and culture becomes, here, a developmental sequence: the child heals bodies; the man frees persons from buildings.

5.5
The Mirror on the Water
Echo, Narcissus, and the Shadow That Strikes Back

In the third book of the *Metamorphoses* Ovid joins two stories. The nymph Echo, who had kept Juno talking while Jupiter's lovers slipped away, is punished by the goddess: she will have the use of her voice only to repeat the last words spoken to her. She falls in love with the beautiful youth Narcissus, who spurns her, and she wastes away until only her voice and her bones remain, and the bones are turned to stone. Narcissus, who has scorned every lover, is cursed in his turn. He sees his reflection in a pool, falls in love with it, cannot possess it, and pines beside the water until he becomes the flower that bears his name (*Metamorphoses*

III.339–510). Ovid's description of Echo, set at the head of this chapter, is the most exact description in literature of Link's relation to speech: she has learned neither to keep silent when another speaks nor to speak first.

The hero of *Ocarina of Time* does not speak at all; but he answers. When others address him, the game offers him assents and refusals; above all, when others sing to him, he sings back. Every song he plays is the repetition of a song someone else has played to him first: the princess, the friend of his childhood, the ranch girl, the masked Sheikah, the inscription in the tomb. He never speaks first. His music is an echo, and his instrument is Echo's voice transposed into clay. Echo's body wasted until only her voice remained; the hero has a body and no voice, but his music, like hers, returns only what it receives. The two exceptions noted in Chapter IV—the Song of Storms, which he originates only by repeating his own future, and the scarecrow's song, which the player composes—are the limits that define the rule. Even when this Echo originates, she repeats herself.

Within the Water Temple there is a room unlike any other in the game. Its door opens upon what seems an infinite expanse of shallow water under a white mist, with no visible walls; in the middle stands a small island bearing a single dead tree. As the hero crosses, his reflection is visible in the water beneath him. Then the reflection is gone, and a figure stands with him on the water: his exact double, dark, with red eyes. Dark Link mirrors every action. He blocks when the hero attacks, strikes when the hero lowers his guard, and leaps up to stand upon the hero's blade. When he is at last defeated, the mist and the water vanish, and the room is revealed as an ordinary chamber of modest size. The infinity was an illusion; the immensity was interior.

This is Narcissus's pool, but the myth is inverted. Narcissus loves his reflection; the hero must fight his. Narcissus cannot reach the image because it withdraws as he reaches; the hero cannot defeat his image because it advances as he does. Lacan's paper on the mirror stage described the infant's jubilant identification with its specular image, which gives it a unified form that its own uncoordinated body does not yet possess, at the price of an alienation: the self is constituted as an image, outside itself (Lacan 1949). In a companion paper on aggressivity, Lacan argued that this imaginary identification is inseparable from rivalry, for the other who is my image is also the one who would take my place (Lacan 1948). Dark Link is the Lacanian imaginary made antagonist: the specular double whose identity with the hero is the very source of its aggression. René Girard, from a different direction, described the monstrous double that emerges in a mimetic crisis, when rivals who desire the same object imitate one another so completely that their differences dissolve and each sees in the other a monster (Girard 1972). The mirror-room's mist, its featureless water, and its absence of walls are the visual form of what Girard called the crisis of distinctions: a space in which nothing differs from anything else.

The literature of the double supplies the rest of the pedigree. Otto Rank traced the *Doppelgänger* through Hoffmann, Poe, and Dostoevsky and argued that the double begins

as an assurance against death and becomes its harbinger (Rank 1914); Freud took up the argument in his essay on the uncanny (Freud 1919). In Poe's "William Wilson" (1839) the narrator is pursued by a namesake who is his conscience, and when he kills him he kills himself. In Hans Christian Andersen's "The Shadow" (1847), a scholar's shadow detaches itself, prospers in the world, makes its former master its servant, and finally has him put to death. In Barrie's *Peter and Wendy*, Peter's shadow comes loose and must be sewn back on by Wendy. Ursula K. Le Guin wrote both the most important modern fantasy of the shadow and its theory. In *A Wizard of Earthsea* (1968) the young mage Ged, through pride, releases a shadow-creature that pursues him across the world; he flees it, then turns and hunts it, and at last meets it and names it with his own name, whereupon the two become one and Ged is made whole. In her essay "The Child and the Shadow" (1975), Le Guin argued, drawing on Jung, that the shadow is the dark side of the self that the growing child must learn to recognize as its own, and that fantasy is the natural language of that recognition.

Against this background, the manner in which *Ocarina of Time* resolves the encounter is significant. Dark Link is not integrated, as Ged's shadow is; nor does he destroy his original, as Andersen's does. He is defeated—but by what means? A duel of sword against sword is nearly unwinnable, since the double copies every move. Players learned quickly that the reliable means of defeating him are those that break the symmetry: the Megaton Hammer, a weapon too heavy for the double to parry, or the fire of the goddess Din, a magic the reflection cannot reflect. In either case the self defeats its mirror-image by drawing on what is not itself: a tool inherited from the Goron hero of legend, or a power lent by a goddess through a fairy. The narcissistic closure of the self upon its image is broken by the gifts of others. The resolution is not Jungian integration but relation: the self that is only its own reflection is overcome by the self that carries what others have given it. In the terms of Chapter II, the shadow is defeated by *ren*, the relational virtue that the relic cannot hold.

One detail of the mirror-room remains: the single dead tree upon its island. The game offers no explanation. A reader may see in it the Great Deku Tree, the first loss of the hero's life, standing at the center of his interior landscape—the guardian whose death sent him out of the forest, returning in the place where he meets himself. The procedural criterion does not license the reading, and I offer it only as an image. But the room is the most dreamlike space in the game, and its tree the most solitary image in it: the inner landscape of a boy who has lost his home, encountered at the moment he must face his own reflection in the element of mirrors.

5.6
Labyrinth, Cave, Clepsydra, Silenus
The Dungeon as Machine and Sanctuary

The dungeon is a labyrinth, and its oldest myth is Cretan: the house Daedalus built for Minos to imprison the Minotaur, into which Athenian youths and maidens were sent as tribute, and from which Theseus escaped by following the thread Ariadne gave him. Umberto Eco distinguished three kinds of labyrinth (Eco 1983). The classical labyrinth is unicursal: a single path leads inevitably to the center and out again, so that one cannot get lost in it, but only meet the monster at its heart. The mannerist maze is a tree of branching paths with dead ends and a single exit, in which one can err. The net, or rhizome, connects every point to every other, without center or periphery. The dungeons of *Ocarina of Time* are mannerist mazes disciplined by keys: one can err, but the locks constrain the order in which errors are possible, and the map and compass are Ariadne's thread, given in pieces. The overworld, crossed on horseback, approaches the net. The Lost Woods are a maze of a fourth kind, navigable by ear, in which the thread is a melody.

Borges's "The House of Asterion" (1947) is narrated by the Minotaur himself, who describes his house as the world—infinite, its corridors and courtyards repeating without end—and who awaits the redeemer a dying victim had foretold. In the final lines the redeemer is revealed as Theseus, against whom the Minotaur scarcely defended himself. The guardians of the dungeons are Asterions in this sense: monsters at the hearts of houses that are the whole of their world, waiting. In the fiction, each temple's guardian has held its house through the seven years of the usurper's reign—or, in the case of the dragon of the Fire Temple, has been raised again from an ancient death. The hero is their Theseus.

The Platonic cave returns here in a pedagogical register. Plato's prisoner, freed and turned around, must be led up into the light and trained by stages to look first at shadows and reflections, then at things, then at the sun itself (*Republic* 515c–516b). The dungeons train the eye in a sequence that recalls and revises Plato's. They teach the hero first to see in darkness, by torches lit with burning sticks and arrows of fire; then to see through illusion, with the Lens of Truth that reveals the false walls and invisible floors of the well and the Shadow Temple; then to handle light by reflection, with the mirror-shield of the Spirit Temple; and finally to wield light itself, in the arrows the princess gives him, the only weapon to which the usurper is vulnerable. The ascent from the cave is, in Hyrule, an ascent toward the arrows of light: a pedagogy of seeing that culminates in the power to strike with it. Heidegger read the allegory of the cave as recording a shift in the essence of truth, from *alētheia*, unconcealment, to the correctness of vision (Heidegger 1940); the Lens of Truth is *alētheia* made into an instrument, a glass through which the concealed comes out of concealment.

Foucault called heterotopias those "other spaces" in which the sites of a culture are represented, contested, and inverted, and linked them to slices of time he called heterochronies (Foucault 1967): the cemetery, the museum and library that accumulate time, the fairground and festival that consume it, the ship. Hyrule's interiors are heterotopias in this sense and heterochronies quite literally, for the cycle of day and night that governs the overworld halts within them; time does not pass inside a dungeon. The graveyard of

Kakariko, Foucault's paradigmatic heterotopia, opens onto both the Shadow Temple and the royal tomb in which the song of the sun is inscribed. The fortress of the desert people, where captured carpenters are held, is a heterotopia of deviation. And the Temple of Time is a heterochrony par excellence: a place in which times accumulate and from which they can be entered.

In a game about time it is fitting that one dungeon should be a clock. The clepsydra, the water-clock, measured time by the steady passage of water from one vessel to another; Ctesibius of Alexandria refined it in the third century BCE with a regulated inflow and a float, and the courts of Athens used simpler water-clocks to limit the length of speeches. The Water Temple is a clepsydra the hero must set. Its three levels, raised and lowered at the emblems of the Triforce, are the marks of a clock whose hand is a lullaby—and the lullaby is the princess's, the song of Wisdom and of *aion*. The royal song of the whole governs the water-clock of succession.

The Spirit Temple's colossus offers a figure for the dungeon as such. In the *Symposium*, the drunken Alcibiades compares Socrates to the Silenus statues sold in the sculptors' shops: grotesque figures of the satyr, made to open down the middle, revealing images of the gods within (215a–b). Socrates, ugly and comic without, is within full of divine images. Erasmus made the figure into an adage, *Sileni Alcibiadis* (1515), applying it to Christ, to the apostles, and to all things whose true worth lies hidden beneath an unprepossessing exterior, and Rabelais opened *Gargantua* (1534) by likening his book to such a box. Every dungeon in *Ocarina of Time* is a Silenus: a tree, a mountain, a fish, a manor, a statue, which opens to reveal a sacred content—a tool, a guardian, a sage. The cartridge is a Silenus too, a small gray box that opens onto a world. Shelley's "Ozymandias" (1818) gave the European imagination its emblem of a colossus in the desert as the ruin of tyranny, its inscription mocking the king who raised it. The desert colossus of Hyrule inverts Ozymandias. It is not a tyrant's monument but a goddess's hollow sanctuary, inside which the usurper's own surrogate mothers, the twin witches, have made their lair—and from which the desert's sage, once freed, turns against him.

A final distinction concerns the relation between the dungeons and the world outside them. Deleuze and Guattari distinguished striated space—gridded, measured, organized by points and the paths between them, the space of the city and the state—from smooth space—heterogeneous, directional, occupied without being counted, the space of the sea, the steppe, the desert, and the nomad (Deleuze and Guattari 1980, plateau 14). The world of *Ocarina of Time* alternates between them. Hyrule Field, crossed on horseback, is smooth space: open, undivided, traversed by vectors rather than routes. The Haunted Wasteland beyond the desert fortress is smooth space in extremity, a sandstorm in which the only guide is a line of flags and then a lantern-bearing ghost visible only through the Lens of Truth. The dungeons are striated: rooms, doors, locks, keys, maps. The hero's existence oscillates between the horse and the key. Chapter VI shows that the oscillation is also political, for

the desert people are nomads in Deleuze and Guattari's sense, and their king a nomadic war machine that seizes a state.

5.7 Coda

The Interior as Relation

The dungeons of *Ocarina of Time* are not obstacles placed between the hero and his goal; they are vessels. Each is the interior of a body or a building; each yields a tool that enlarges the hero's capacity; each is guarded by a corruption of its element; and each of the adult temples ends in a person. The sages—Saria, Darunia, Ruto, Impa, Nabooru—are the final content of the hollows. The temples are inverted reliquaries: what they hold at the last is not a relic but a relation, a person freed into the alliance that will seal the usurper.

The hero's descents also pattern the game's ending. Inanna, descending to the netherworld, was stripped at each of its seven gates of a garment or an emblem of power, until she stood bare before its queen. The hero, descending into the temples, gains at each a tool, a capacity, and a medallion bearing a sage's power. The game's structure of accumulation is the inverse of Inanna's divestiture—until the end, when he lays down the sword, loses the fairy, gives back the instrument, and returns to the body of a child. The ending is Inanna's descent performed at last: a passage back through the gates in which everything accumulated is laid down. Chapter VI turns from the interiors to the polity they sustain, and to the sages who constitute the government of the void.

CHAPTER



VI

The Part with No Part

Sovereignty, Shadow, and the Political Theology of Hyrule

τὸ γὰρ μυστήριον ἤδη ἐνεργεῖται τῆς ἀνομίας· μόνον ὁ κατέχων ἄρτι ἕως ἐκ μέσου γένηται.

For the mystery of lawlessness is already at work; only there is one who restrains it now, until he is taken out of the way.

— 2 Thessalonians 2:7 (trans. mine)

Es ist niemals ein Dokument der Kultur, ohne zugleich ein solches der Barbarei zu sein.

There is no document of culture that is not at the same time a document of barbarism.

— Walter Benjamin, "On the Concept of History," thesis VII (1940; trans. mine)

6·1
The Window and the Throne

The child's first sight of sovereignty in *Ocarina of Time* is framed by a window. In the castle courtyard the princess, having told the hero her dream, asks him to look through a window into the hall beyond. There a tall man in dark armor kneels in fealty—the man from the desert, come to swear allegiance to the king—before a throne whose occupant the game does not show. As the children watch, the kneeling man raises his eyes and looks back at the window. The scene lasts only seconds, but it contains the game's political theology in miniature. The sovereign is invisible. The usurper is visible, caught in the act of perjury, swearing an oath he means to break. And the children's secret seeing is answered by a gaze: the object of their spying looks back.

Lacan illustrated his concept of the gaze, in his eleventh seminar, with an anecdote from his youth: a fisherman pointing to a sardine can glinting on the water and remarking that Lacan could see the can but the can could not see him—to which Lacan replied, in effect, that it was looking at him all the same, from the point of light at which he did not see himself being seen (Lacan 1964). The gaze, for Lacan, is not the subject's look but the point from which the object regards the subject, the uncanny moment in which seeing discovers itself seen. Freud's most famous dream analysis also turned upon a window: the Wolf Man's childhood dream in which a window opened by itself onto a tree where white wolves sat motionless, staring at him, a dream Freud traced to a scene the child had witnessed and could not understand (Freud 1918). The window of Hyrule Castle frames the child hero's primal scene of power: the false oath, the hidden sovereign, the gaze returned. The rest of the game unfolds from what was seen through it.

The scene establishes the poles between which this chapter moves. At one stands an unseen sovereign, present only as a throne glimpsed past a kneeling man. At the other stands a visible usurper who will make the realm his body. Between these poles *Ocarina of Time* constructs a political theology in Carl Schmitt's sense—a correspondence between the concepts of the theory of the state and the theological concepts of which they are the secularization (Schmitt 1922)—in which the cosmological doctrine of Chapter II, the vacant center, has its political counterpart in a vacant throne; in which evil, defined as the occupation of the center, appears politically as tyranny; and in which the restoration of the center's vacancy is the work not of a king but of a council.

6·2
The Empty Place of Power
Chōric Sovereignty and the Unseen King

The King of Hyrule never appears in *Ocarina of Time*. He is mentioned by his daughter, who says that he does not share her suspicion of the man from the desert; his hall is glimpsed through a window; and after the usurper's coup his fate goes unrecorded. No scene shows his throne room entered, his body, his death, or his burial. Hyrule is a monarchy whose monarch is a vacancy. In Roland Barthes's account of Tokyo, the city's center is the imperial palace, walled and screened by trees, around which the city's traffic perpetually turns: a center that is empty and around which the whole circulates (Barthes 1970). Until the New Year's rescript of 1946, in which the emperor renounced the claim to divinity, the Japanese sovereign was himself such a center, a living god seldom seen. The unseen king of Hyrule belongs to the same structure.

Ernst Kantorowicz's study of medieval political theology described the doctrine of the king's two bodies: the natural body, mortal and fallible, and the body politic, the dignity of kingship, immortal and incapable of error, which passes at death to the successor—hence the maxim that the king never dies (Kantorowicz 1957). Claude Lefort built upon Kantorowicz an account of modern democracy that bears directly upon Hyrule. Under the old monarchy, Lefort argued, power was incorporated in the person of the prince, whose body gave the kingdom its unity and linked it to a transcendent source. The democratic revolution disincorporated power. The place of power became an empty place, which no individual or group can occupy or embody, which those who exercise authority hold only provisionally, and whose emptiness is the condition of a society that accepts its own division (Lefort 1986). Totalitarianism, in Lefort's analysis, is the attempt to fill the empty place again—to reincorporate society as a single body, the People-as-One, in the figure Lefort, borrowing from Solzhenitsyn, called the Egocrat (Lefort 1981).

Lefort's two figures are the political forms of the two sovereignties this dissertation has called chōric and plenary. Chōric sovereignty is sovereignty as an empty place: the throne kept vacant, unoccupied by anyone who would embody the realm. Plenary sovereignty is the Egocrat's: the realm reincorporated in one body, the center filled. Ganondorf is an Egocrat in the most literal sense. When the hero awakens into the adult era, Hyrule Castle is gone. In its place, suspended above a pit of molten rock, stands a fortress that the game names for the usurper himself: Ganon's Castle. The seat of the polity now bears the name of the man, and the realm has become his body. His ambition, in the theology of Chapter II, is to hold the whole Triforce in one hand, which is to say to incorporate in his own person the three virtues the cosmos keeps distributed.

Schmitt's famous definition—sovereign is he who decides on the exception (Schmitt 1922)—describes the usurper's act exactly. The coup is the exception decided: the suspension of the order of oath and fealty by a will that places itself above it. Giorgio Agamben extended Schmitt's analysis to the conditions under which the exception becomes the rule and to the figure of bare life (*zoē*), life exposed to sovereign power without the protection of political existence (Agamben 1995; Agamben 2003). The adult-era Hyrule offers disqui-

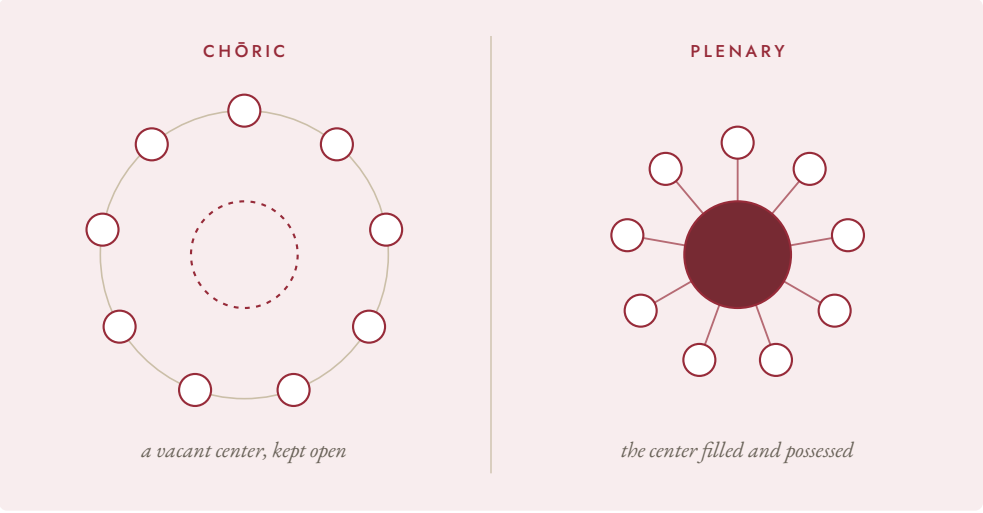


FIGURE 6.1 *Two Sovereignties*

Chōric sovereignty preserves a center that no one may occupy; plenary sovereignty seeks to fill and possess it. The unseen king belongs to the first, the usurper to the second (§§6.2–6.3).

eting images of this condition. The townspeople of the market have become ReDeads, neither alive nor dead, frozen figures whose shriek paralyzes all who approach; the Gorons are imprisoned to be eaten; the Zora are locked in ice. Life under the usurper is life reduced to something less than political existence—life held, as the ReDeads are held, in suspension.

Even the pastoral is not spared. At Lon Lon Ranch the farmhand Ingo, long resentful of the idle owner whose work he did, has seized the ranch under the new regime, driven the owner away, set the owner's daughter to labor, and proposes to present the finest horse to the usurper. Hegel's dialectic of master and servant, in which the servant's labor forms the world and gives him the self-consciousness the idle master lacks (Hegel 1807, B.IV.A), is played here as a small political comedy of collaboration: the servant who has made the ranch his own through work takes it when the political order collapses, and becomes the tyrant's client. The hero's recovery of the mare Epona—won in a race and carried over the locked gate in a single leap—is the game's most joyous image of liberation, and it is achieved by a song: the ranch girl's melody, which the horse remembers.

The empty center, however, is not innocent, as Chapter I insisted. Barthes's empty center was an emperor's palace; Kawai acknowledged that his hollow center could be invaded; Maruyama Masao described the wartime state as a system of irresponsibility in which authority resided nowhere and was exercised everywhere; and the Hōjō regents of Chapter II governed from behind a nested series of vacant thrones. An empty place of power can be Lefort's democratic vacancy, kept open so that no one may occupy it; or it can be a mystified throne behind which a hidden possessor rules. The unseen king of Hyrule is ambiguous between the two. The game's ending, which crowns no one and closes upon two children

meeting in a garden, tilts toward the first. But the kingdom has a cellar, and §6.5 descends into it.

6.3
The Plenary Sovereign
Tyrant, War Machine, and the King of Instruments

The preceding chapters have assembled Ganondorf's lineage piece by piece: the Platonic tyrant in whom the beast has devoured the human (Chapter II); Dumézil's warrior who sins against every function (Chapter II); Kronos, devourer of time (Chapter IV); Melkor, who killed the sacred trees and stole the jewels (Chapter V); Kamsa, the usurper of Mathurā, who slew infants to forestall the prophecy of his fall (Chapter III). To these one may add Macbeth, whose ambition is kindled by witches—as Ganondorf was raised by twin sorceresses who call themselves his mothers—and whose Japanese avatar in Kurosawa's *Throne of Blood* (1957) receives his prophecy from a spirit spinning thread in a forest; and Milton's Satan, whose grandeur led Blake to remark that Milton was of the Devil's party without knowing it (*The Marriage of Heaven and Hell*, plate 6). The usurper's enduring fascination for players belongs to this Romantic tradition. The plenary sovereign is magnificent, and the game does not pretend otherwise.

Plato's account of the tyrant's origin adds a political dimension to the psychological one of Chapter II. In the eighth book of the *Republic*, tyranny arises from the excess of freedom in democracy: a champion of the people appears who, having once tasted kindred blood, is transformed from a man into a wolf (565d–566a). Aristotle's *Politics* catalogues the tyrant's techniques of preservation: to humble his subjects, to sow mistrust among them, to render them powerless, and to keep them occupied with labor (V.11, 1313a34–1314a29). Ganondorf's methods in the adult era are Aristotle's. The peoples of the realm are divided, imprisoned, frozen, set to work, or hollowed out; none can trust another; each is isolated within its own catastrophe. The coalition of the sages is the undoing of precisely this isolation.

Deleuze and Guattari's treatise on nomadology supplies a more structural account. The war machine, they argued, is exterior to the state apparatus: it belongs to nomads, to smooth space, to bands and packs, and states seek to capture it by converting it into an army. But when a war machine seizes a state and takes war itself as its object, the result is a monstrous hybrid, which they identified with fascism—a state that has become nothing but a war machine and is driven at last toward its own destruction (Deleuze and Guattari 1980, plateau 12). Ganondorf is king of a nomadic people of the desert, which Chapter V characterized as smooth space in extremity; his coup is the capture of a state by a war machine; and the castle he raises in place of the old one, a fortress suspended over magma, is a state that has

become a weapon. Its end is suicidal in the literal sense. When the hero defeats him at the summit of his tower, Ganondorf spends his last strength bringing the tower down, that it may crush the hero and the princess along with him.

When the hero reaches that summit, he finds the usurper seated at a pipe organ, playing. The image draws upon a long tradition of the villain at the organ—Verne's Captain Nemo playing in the depths of the *Nautilus* (1870), the masked Erik of Gaston Leroux's *The Phantom of the Opera* (1910), and the horror cinema's long association of the instrument with the sinister—but within the argument of this dissertation it has a more exact meaning. Mozart, in a letter to his father, called the organ the king of all instruments (17 October 1777). It is the instrument of the cathedral and the court, of liturgy and spectacle, capable of filling a vast interior with sound. And it is, acoustically, the antithesis of the ocarina. The organ is the tube instrument par excellence: each of its pitches is a pipe of measured length, so that its sound is a function of position along a line, and its wind is supplied not by human breath but by bellows and, in modern instruments, by machinery. The ocarina is a vessel whose pitch is a function of how much of it stands open, animated by the player's breath. The final confrontation of the game is therefore a duel of instruments as well as of persons: the vessel against the pipe, breath against bellows, the child's song against the king's, an instrument of apertures against an instrument that fills space.

Jacques Attali argued that music is prophetic of social orders and that it functions as the ritual channelling of violence, the simulacrum of a sacrifice, drawing explicitly upon René Girard (Attali 1977). The usurper's organ is the music of an order that fills; the hero's ocarina, the music of an order that opens. That the usurper ceases playing when the hero arrives, and that the battle begins in the silence after his music, is not incidental. In Hyrule the music of the plenum must fall silent before the vessel can sound.

6.4
The Part with No Part
The Desert People, the Miscount, and the Orientalist Code

The usurper comes from a people that the game treats with more complexity than its plot requires. The Gerudo are a nation of women living in the desert of the west. By their law a single male is born among them once in a hundred years, and he becomes their king; Ganondorf is that male. They live by theft, keep a fortress and a training ground, worship a deity of their own, the Goddess of the Sand, and in the adult era hold captive a crew of carpenters from the hero's kingdom. Their second-in-command, Nabooru, despises the cruelty of their king and plots to steal from him a treasure hidden in the desert temple; she is captured by the twin witches, bewitched into his service, freed by the hero, and revealed

as the Sage of Spirit. The hero, having freed the carpenters, is given a membership card that admits him to the fortress as one of the desert people's own.

Jacques Rancière distinguished between the police—the order that distributes bodies, places, and functions, deciding who is counted and what is visible and sayable—and politics, which is the disruption of that order by the part of those who have no part: the uncounted who claim, in the name of equality, to be the whole (Rancière 1995). The sacred order of Hyrule, as Chapter II showed, is counted in threes: three goddesses, three virtues, three Spiritual Stones held by three peoples allied with the royal house, the Kokiri, the Gorons, and the Zora. The Gerudo have no Spiritual Stone. In the compact by which the Door of Time is opened, the desert people have no part. Their king is the one who demands the stones and is refused. His villainy is, structurally, the irruption of the uncounted part—but in counterfeit form. Rancière's uncounted claim the whole in the name of equality; Ganondorf claims the whole in the name of power. The game stages the miscount and resolves it in two opposed ways. Through the tyrant, the uncounted part is converted into domination. Through Nabooru, it becomes a sage. The desert's sage, the last of the five adult sages to be awakened, takes her place in the seal: the part that had no part is counted at last, not in the triad of the stones but in the council of seven.

Michel Serres's figure of the parasite completes the picture (Serres 1980). The parasite, for Serres, is the third that intercepts a relation—the noise in the channel, the guest who eats without giving, the excluded third who turns out to be included in every relation it disturbs. Refused a share in the gift economy of the stones, Ganondorf operates parasitically. He cannot open the Door of Time, but he can follow the one who does; he cannot receive the stones, but he can infest the bodies of the gods who hold them, setting parasites in the guardian tree and the fish god. Chapter II noted that the relational virtue, displaced into the stones, is vulnerable to parasitism because it cannot defend itself by force. The usurper is the parasite of a relational order from which he was excluded.

The game's representation of the desert people must also be read critically, for it draws upon a repertory of images that Edward Said identified as Orientalism: the West's construction of the East as exotic, sensual, despotic, and irrational (Said 1978). The Gerudo are coded through that repertory: a desert fortress of thieves recalling the tale of Ali Baba, which entered Europe through Antoine Galland's eighteenth-century translation of the *Thousand and One Nights* veils and loose trousers; curved swords; a female population presented to the eye and ruled by a despotic male, the figure Montesquieu had made the type of Oriental government, whose principle is fear (Montesquieu 1748). The only man of the desert is marked by darker skin and stylized features, so that the villain is racialized as well as gendered. Two details of the original release make the coding explicit. The emblem of the desert people, borne upon the Mirror Shield and set into the walls of the Spirit Temple, was originally a crescent moon and star; and the music of the Fire Temple included a sampled vocal chant that listeners identified as Islamic prayer. Both were replaced in later revisions of

the cartridge and in subsequent re-releases, changes widely understood as responses to the use of religious material. The revisions are a material record of the Orientalist code and of its partial correction, and they belong, as Chapter I argued, to the dispersed object that the work is.

The Japanese position in this repertory is double. Japan has been an object of Western Orientalism and, as Stefan Tanaka showed, the producer of its own Orient, constructing through the discipline of *tōyōshi* an Asia against which Japanese modernity defined itself (Tanaka 1993). The desert of Hyrule belongs directly to neither tradition. It is a second-hand Orientalism, Western images of the Middle East—Hollywood's Arabian Nights and, six years before the game, Disney's *Aladdin* (1992), whose usurping sorcerer-vizier covets a magic lamp and a throne—recirculated through Japanese fantasy. A Japanese philosophical source sharpens the critique. Watsuji Tetsurō's *Fūdo* (1935) proposed a typology of human climates: the monsoon, which produces a receptive and resigned humanity; the meadow of Europe, which produces rational order; and the desert, which produces a combative humanity organized around obedience to a single will and a personal god (Watsuji 1935). Augustin Berque has drawn from Watsuji a more generous philosophy of milieu (Berque 2000), but the typology's essentialism is undeniable, and the game's desert people seem almost to illustrate it: combative, and organized around a single male will. *Ocarina of Time* does not escape these codings. Its structure, however, complicates them. The desert's sage is the one who rebels against the single will, and the desert people admit the hero to their fortress before the realm admits them to its sacred compact.

The series later registered the grievance its first desert king had left unspoken. In *The Wind Waker* (2002), Ganondorf recalls a homeland in which the desert winds brought only scorching heat by day and bitter cold by night, and confesses that he coveted the winds that blew across the green fields of Hyrule. The uncounted king acquires, in the sequel, a motive rooted in geography and inequality. The later game does not excuse him, but it concedes what the structure of *Ocarina of Time* had already implied: the plenary sovereign is the counterfeit of a claim that the order of three never allowed to be made.

6.5
The Archive of Barbarism
The Shadow Temple and the Kingdom's Cellar

Kakariko, the village at the foot of Death Mountain, was once, the game tells us, a village of the Sheikah, the shadow people who served the royal family, until Impa, the princess's guardian, opened it to ordinary folk. Beneath its graveyard lies the Shadow Temple; beneath its well, a chamber of torments. By the game's own account the temple is the resting place of the kingdom's history of greed and blood. Its rooms are furnished with falling blades and

walls of spikes; its paths, invisible to ordinary sight, can be crossed only by means of the Lens of Truth; its floors fall away; its ferry carries the hero over an abyss. The well beneath the village houses at its bottom a creature made of grasping arms. Impa, guardian of the princess, is the Sage of Shadow and the custodian of this archive.

Benjamin's seventh thesis on history, quoted at the head of this chapter, observed that the cultural treasures the victors carry in their triumphal procession owe their existence not only to the genius of their makers but to the anonymous toil of their contemporaries, so that there is no document of culture that is not at the same time a document of barbarism (Benjamin 1940). Hyrule's monument of culture is the Temple of Time, raised by the ancient sages over the entrance to the Sacred Realm, its sword in the stone the image of a sacred order. The Shadow Temple is the same kingdom's document of barbarism, its underside: the place where the violence on which the order rested was carried out and concealed. The game does not say who was tormented there, or by whom, or why; it says only that the history gathered there is one of greed and blood, and that the shadow people who served the crown were its keepers. The silence is eloquent. The kingdom's archive of its own violence is a sealed crypt, legible only through a lens.

Benjamin's earlier "Critique of Violence" (1921) distinguished law-making violence, which founds a legal order, from law-preserving violence, which maintains it—the violence of the police, which Benjamin found more spectral and more corrupting than the founding kind, because it acts wherever law has no fixed shape (Benjamin 1921). The Sheikah are the law-preserving violence of the Hylian crown. Their figure belongs to a long Japanese imagination of the state's covert arm: the *shinobi* of the warring-states period and the *oniwaban*, the agents nominally employed as keepers of the gardens whom the eighth Tokugawa shogun, Yoshimune, established on his accession in 1716 to serve as the shogunate's eyes. Their emblem, which Sheik wears upon his chest, is an eye from which a tear falls: a seeing that weeps for what it sees. Fredric Jameson argued that narrative bears within it a political unconscious, the repressed history of social contradiction that its forms both manage and betray (Jameson 1981). The Shadow Temple is Hyrule's political unconscious made into a level: a place the hero must descend into, see through, and pass beyond, without being permitted to redeem it.

The consequence for the game's politics is considerable. A reading of *Ocarina of Time* as a Manichaean struggle between a just kingdom and an alien usurper cannot survive the Shadow Temple. The order Ganondorf overthrows was already founded upon violence and maintained by it; the war that orphaned the hero, mentioned only by the sprout that tells him of his mother, was fought within the kingdom; and the realm's sacred compact excluded the desert people. The usurper's crime is not the introduction of violence into an innocent realm but its unconcealment and universalization: the conversion of a hidden law-preserving violence into an open regime of terror, the exception made the rule. Benjamin's eighth thesis—that the tradition of the oppressed teaches that the state of emergency in which we

live is not the exception but the rule (Benjamin 1940)—reads in Hyrule as a judgment upon both the tyrant and the kingdom he overthrew. The princess's ending, which crowns no one and returns the realm to the moment before the tyrant's rise, does not undo the Shadow Temple. The cellar remains beneath the empty throne.

6.6
The Princess's Two Bodies
Sheik, Disguise, and the Sovereign Decision

During the seven years of the usurper's reign, the body politic of Hyrule—the dignity of rule, borne in the Triforce of Wisdom—survives in hiding. The princess, who escaped the castle on the night of the coup, conceals herself in the guise of Sheik, a warrior of the Sheikah whose body and bearing the game codes as male, face masked, only the eyes visible. Sheik appears at the threshold of each temple, teaches the hero the song that will carry him back there, offers counsel in riddling speech, and vanishes in a flash of light. Only after the fifth temple has been cleared does Sheik reveal, in the Temple of Time, that he is the princess—and almost at once the usurper, who has been waiting for her to appear, seizes her and imprisons her in a crystal.

The episode is a drama of Kantorowicz's two bodies. The king's natural body may be exiled, imprisoned, or killed; the body politic survives, for the king never dies. In Hyrule the body politic survives the usurpation not in an heir but in disguise: the dignity of the realm is hidden within a natural body that is not recognizably its own. History offers analogues—Charles II, after the defeat at Worcester in 1651, hiding from his pursuers in the branches of an oak at Boscobel, sovereignty concealed in a tree—but the closest analogues are literary, and they belong to a long tradition of the princess or heroine disguised as a man.

In the Chinese *Ballad of Mulan*, composed in the period of the Northern Dynasties, a daughter takes her aged father's place in the army in man's guise, serves twelve years, and returns home to put on her own clothes again, to the astonishment of her comrades. Shakespeare's comedies made the disguised heroine a recurrent device—Rosalind in the forest of Arden, Viola in Illyria, Portia in the court of Venice—and in each case the disguise grants the heroine a voice and an agency that her own name denied her. In Japan the tradition acquired a theatrical institution in the Takarazuka Revue, founded in 1913, whose all-female company plays male roles as *otokoyaku*. Osamu Tezuka, who grew up in Takarazuka, drew upon it for *Princess Knight* (*Ribon no Kishi*, 1953), whose heroine, Princess Sapphire, is raised as a prince so that the throne will not pass to a usurper; and Riyoko Ikeda's *The Rose of Versailles* (1972–73), whose Oscar is raised as a man to command the queen's guard, made the figure central to modern girls' comics. Sheik descends from this lineage: female sovereignty that survives and acts in male guise. Judith Butler's account of gender as

performance, a repeated stylization of the body that produces the appearance of a substance (Butler 1990), finds in Sheik an instance in which the performance's success makes its performativity visible. The masculinity the game presents for half its length is revealed, in a flash of light, as a costume.

A feminist reading must register the ambivalence of this arrangement. The princess acquires her greatest agency—as warrior, guide, and teacher of songs—only in male disguise, and when she reveals herself as herself she is at once captured and restored to the condition of the damsel whose rescue motivates the hero, a trope that Anita Sarkeesian's critique of the medium made notorious (Sarkeesian 2013). Her knowledge, as Chapter III argued, had already been forced into covert channels by a court that would not hear it; Sheik is the shape a woman's knowledge takes in such a court. And yet the final movement of the game belongs to her. In the last battle she holds the beast immobile with her light while the hero strikes; she leads the sages in the seal; and the ending is her decision.

That decision deserves a precise name. Schmitt's sovereign decides on the exception and, in deciding, fills the gap in the order with his will. The princess, at the game's end, also decides on an exception—the most radical the game contains, the reversal of time itself—but her decision does not fill the gap. It empties it. She does not crown the hero, take the throne, or restore her father; she returns the hero's time, and with it the realm's, to the moment before the usurper's rise. Her sovereign act is a kenotic decision: an exception decided in order to give back rather than to take. In this sense the princess, not the hero, is the sovereign of *Ocarina of Time*, and her sovereignty is the chōric sovereignty of Axiom III—the power to keep the center open, exercised at the one moment when it could have been filled.

6.7 The Government of the Void

The Sages as Katechon

The power that seals the usurper is neither the hero nor the princess alone but a council of seven: Rauru, the ancient sage of light, one of those who raised the Temple of Time; Saria of the Kokiri; Darunia of the Gorons; Ruto of the Zora; Impa of the Sheikah; Nabooru of the desert; and the princess, the seventh, who leads them. Every people of the realm is represented, the desert's included. Councils of seven sages are an ancient form. The *apkallu* of Mesopotamian tradition were sent by the god Ea before the flood to give humanity the arts of civilization; the seven seers (*saptarṣi*) of Vedic tradition are identified with the stars of the Great Bear; the Seven Sages of archaic Greece, Thales and Solon among them, were credited with the maxims inscribed at Delphi; and the Seven Worthies of the Bamboo Grove, poets and philosophers of third-century China, withdrew from a corrupt court into wine, music, and Daoist conversation. Hyrule's sages combine the first and last of these. Like the

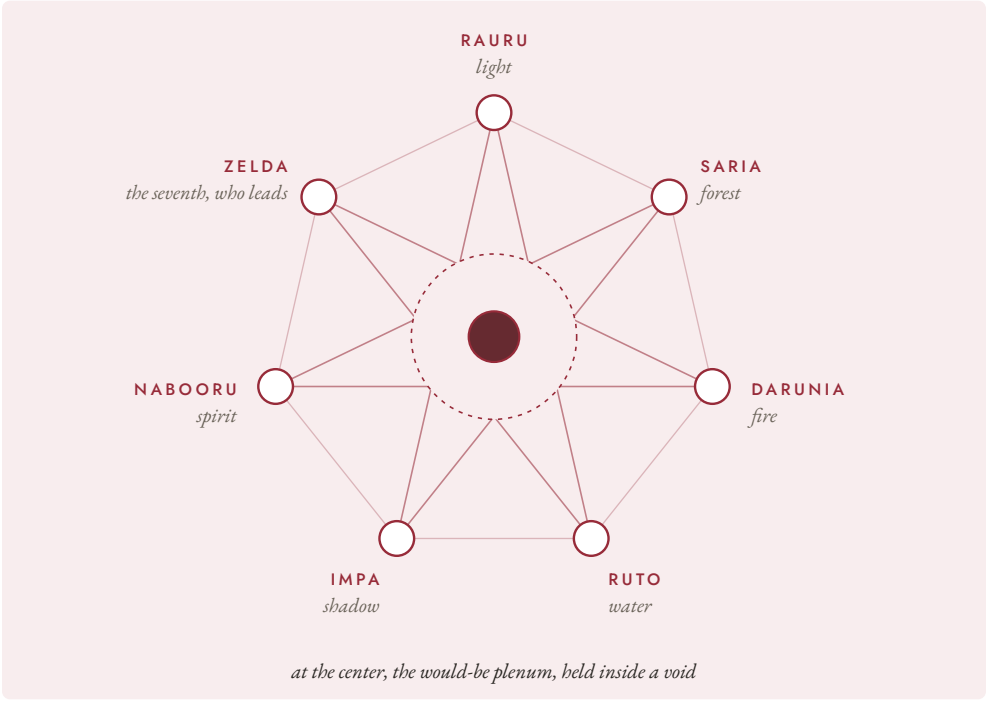


FIGURE 6.2 *The Seal*

The council of seven, every people of the realm represented, governs from the receptacle by withdrawal; the would-be plenum is contained within emptiness rather than destroyed. Schmitt's *katechon*, the one who restrains (§6.7).

apkallu they are guardians of order; like the worthies of the bamboo grove they govern by withdrawal. Once awakened, each departs from the world into the Chamber of Sages at the center of the Sacred Realm, becoming invisible to the realm they protect. The sages are a government of the void: a council that rules from the receptacle by having left the world.

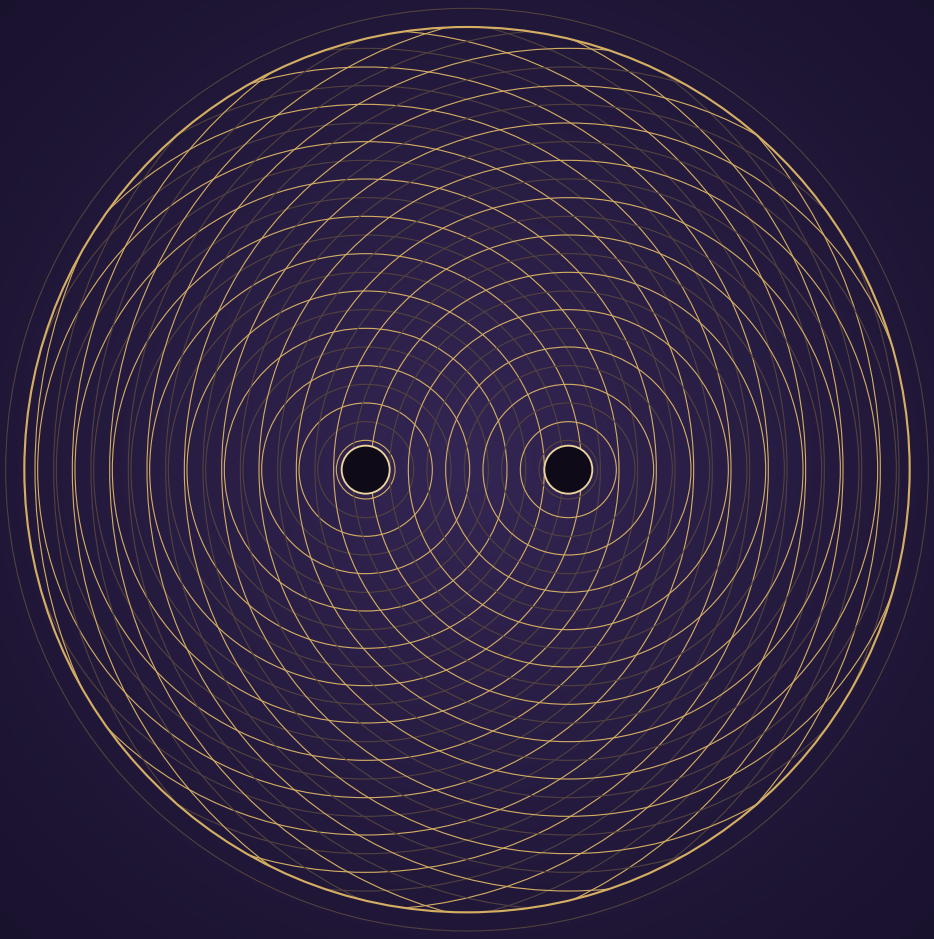
The seal they lay upon the usurper has a precise political-theological name. The Second Letter to the Thessalonians tells its readers that the day of the Lord will not come until the lawless one is revealed, and that the mystery of lawlessness is already at work, held back only by "the one who restrains" (*ho katechōn*) until he is taken out of the way (2 Thess. 2:6–7). Schmitt made the *katechon* the key to the Christian empire's understanding of itself: a historical power whose task is to hold back the Antichrist and so to delay the end, and he regarded the concept as the only one through which an original Christian faith could have understood history as more than a waiting for the last day (Schmitt 1950). The seal of the sages is katechontic in exactly this sense. It does not annihilate evil; it restrains it. It holds the usurper back, and in holding him back it opens an age of history that would otherwise be foreclosed. The series that follows is the history of a *katechon*: a seal that holds, weakens, is broken, and is renewed.

Two differences, however, separate Hyrule's *katechon* from Schmitt's, and both matter. Schmitt's *katechon* is an empire; Hyrule's is a federation. The restraining power is not the crown, which is absent, nor the hero, who returns to childhood, but a council of the peoples, each represented by one of its own, including the people that had no part in the sacred compact of the stones. And Schmitt's *katechon* is a conservative concept, legitimating an existing order as the bulwark against chaos; Agamben, reading Paul against Schmitt, argued that the *katechon* is the power that defers the messianic—the institution that holds back redemption as well as catastrophe (Agamben 2000). Hyrule's seal pays exactly this price. Because evil is restrained rather than abolished, it returns; because the seal holds, the cycle continues. The series' repetition, which Chapter IV read through Kuki as a vocation, is from this angle the cost of a katechontic politics: a world that prefers restraint to apocalypse must accept that its enemy will outlast every victory.

René Girard's account of the founding of order supplies a final and darker perspective. In *Violence and the Sacred* and *The Scapegoat*, Girard argued that communities overtaken by mimetic violence recover their unity through a unanimous act of expulsion: all against one, the violence of each converging upon a single victim, whose removal restores peace and who is afterward remembered as both accursed and sacred, the monster who returns as a god (Girard 1972; Girard 1982). The sealing of Ganon has the form of this mechanism. It is seven against one, a unanimous expulsion into the void, after which order returns; and the expelled one returns in every subsequent age, the perennial antagonist whose recurrence the series treats as a law of its world, cursed and sacralized at once. Girard's decisive insight, however, was that the mechanism depends on the misrecognition of the victim's innocence, and here the analogy breaks: Ganondorf is no innocent. Yet the people from whom he came bore an exclusion that preceded his crimes, and the sealing that restores order does not repair it. The game contains both the scapegoat structure and the beginning of its undoing, in the seventh seat of the council, where the desert's sage now sits among those who restrain her people's king.

At the game's end, then, sovereignty in Hyrule resides nowhere visible. The king is unseen; the princess is about to be a child again; the sages have withdrawn into the Sacred Realm; the usurper is sealed in the void; and the hero carries six medallions, tokens of the sages' power and of his relation to each of them. Power has been dispersed into relations, and the place of power has been emptied again, held open by a federation of the withdrawn. It is Lefort's empty place under the sign of the Triforce: a center that no one occupies, preserved by many. One vessel remains to be considered, the one that has animated every other. Chapter VII turns to the player.

CHAPTER



VII

Echo's Instrument

The Mute Hero, the Breathing Player, and the Ludic Ontology of the Vessel

大音希聲，大象無形。

The great note is faint of sound; the great image has no shape.

— *Daodejing* §41 (trans. mine)

L'attention est la forme la plus rare et la plus pure de la générosité.

Attention is the rarest and purest form of generosity.

— Simone Weil, letter to Joë Bousquet, 13 April 1942 (trans. mine)

7.1
The Hollow Hero
Silence, the Blank, and a Name Left Empty

Link does not speak. Others address him at length—the dying tree, the princess, the sages, the chiefs of every people, the shopkeepers and children of the market—and he answers, when the game lets him answer at all, by an assent or a refusal chosen from a short menu, by a gesture, by a nod. He cries out in effort and in pain; he never says a word. And the game leaves even his name empty. When a new file is begun, the player is asked to enter a name, and whatever is entered becomes the name by which every character in Hyrule addresses the hero for the rest of the game. "Link" is only the default. The hero's name is a variable: a field the player fills.

Nintendo's designers have said that the name was chosen because the hero is the link between the player and the game, and the early design history of the series is often reported to have included a scheme of travel between past and future that the hero would link. Whatever its history, the 1998 game makes the name procedural. It is not a proper name but a slot —an empty signifier in the sense §1.6 gave the action button, a term emptied of particular content so that it can bear whatever content the player brings. Wolfgang Iser argued that literary texts are built around blanks (*Leerstellen*), gaps in the connectedness of the text that the reader's activity must fill, and that these blanks, far from being defects, are the very structures by which a text engages its reader in the production of meaning (Iser 1976); Roman Ingarden had earlier described the literary work as a schematic formation containing spots of indeterminacy that each reading concretizes (Ingarden 1931). Link is the central blank of *Ocarina of Time*: a hero whose silence and whose empty name are the apertures through which the player enters. Umberto Eco's account of the open work, completed by its performer—the scores of Stockhausen and Berio that leave the order of their sections to the player—describes the game's structure at the level of the whole (Eco 1962). Link's silence describes it at the level of the person.

The silent protagonist was not new in 1998. The hero of *Dragon Quest* (1986), template of the Japanese role-playing game, speaks no lines, on the often-reported rationale that a hero who does not speak leaves room for the player to occupy him. And in the same week of November 1998 in which *Ocarina of Time* reached shops in Japan and North America, Valve released *Half-Life*, whose protagonist, the physicist Gordon Freeman, likewise never speaks. The two silences differ, and the difference is instructive. Freeman is hollowed of body as well as voice: the game is seen through his eyes, his body reduced to a pair of hands and a weapon at the bottom of the frame, so that the player occupies him from within. Link is hollowed of voice alone. His body is fully present, seen from outside and slightly behind—acting, gesturing, suffering—and only his speech is withheld. *Half-Life* makes the player a

gaze; *Ocarina of Time* makes the player a breath. The player does not see as Link. The player animates him, as breath animates a vessel.

Japanese dramaturgy theorized such a hollow long before. In the *Kakyō* (1424), Zeami located the highest interest of the Noh performer not in dance or chant but in what lies between them: the intervals of not-doing (*senu hima*), in which nothing visible happens and in which, Zeami argued, the actor's concentrated mind sustains the performance, so that the audience is moved by what is not done. Zeami named this the power of linking—*tsunagu*—the ten thousand skills by a single mind. The hero of *Ocarina of Time* is in this sense a performer of *senu hima*, a figure whose silences are not lapses but intervals, within which the player's mind does the linking. The hero's name and Zeami's doctrine of the interval meet in a single verb.

The hollow hero is the last and most important vessel of the game. Axiom II held that no vessel signifies without animation from outside itself. The silent hero is the vessel through which the player's breath passes into Hyrule, and the rest of this chapter examines the forms that breath takes: music, attention, gesture, failure, and the practices through which players have continued to breathe into the work long after its release.

7.2
The Semiotic Song
Kristeva's Chora and the Music Beneath Speech

Link cannot speak, but he can play, and his agency in the world is musical rather than linguistic. Julia Kristeva's theory of poetic language distinguished two modalities of signification: the symbolic, the order of syntax, reference, and law, the domain of the speaking subject; and the semiotic, the rhythmic and intonational pulsions of the drives, prior to and beneath language, organized in what she called, borrowing from the *Timaeus*, the *chora*—a mobile, maternal, receptacular space of rhythm (Kristeva 1974). Poetic language, for Kristeva, is the irruption of the semiotic within the symbolic: rhythm, sound, and pulse breaking through the order of meaning. The hero's songs are semiotic signification in exactly this sense. They have no propositional content; they mean nothing; and yet they act.

J. L. Austin distinguished constative utterances, which describe, from performative utterances, which do what they say—promising, bequeathing, naming a ship (Austin 1962). The ocarina's songs are performatives without words. To play the princess's lullaby before an emblem of the royal house is to prove a bond with it; to play the ranch girl's song is to summon the horse; to play the song of the sun is to bring the dawn. They are speech acts made of tones, efficacious without signifying, and they are, as Chapter IV argued, all received. The hero's speech is borrowed music.

One song makes the structure especially clear. The princess's lullaby, which opens the waterfall before the Zora's domain, the royal tomb, and the emblems of the Triforce, is taught to the hero not by the princess but by her nurse, Impa, who explains that she sang it to the princess when the princess was a baby. The key to the royal order is a nursery song. Kristeva's thesis is here made procedural: the doors of the symbolic order—the order of the crown, its gates, its tombs, its temples—open to the semiotic music of the nursery. Law yields to lullaby. The *chora* that Chapter II found in the Sacred Realm, the receptacle that takes the form of whatever enters it, has its acoustic counterpart in the songs of women—the lullaby of the nurse, the forest song of the friend, the ranch song of the girl—which the hero carries into the masculine orders of war and sovereignty.

Two features of the ocarina, finally, preserve a space that belongs to the player alone. The first is free play. At almost any moment the player may take out the ocarina and play whatever notes he likes; the game listens, recognizes a learned song if one is completed, and otherwise simply lets the music sound. The instrument is a space of what Roger Caillois called *paidia*, free improvisation, within a game otherwise organized by *ludus*, by rule (Caillois 1958)—Winnicott's potential space, in which play is its own end. The second is the scarecrow's song noted in Chapter IV, the one melody in Hyrule that the player composes. In the scarecrow's song Echo, for once, becomes a voice. The player's breath does not merely animate the vessel; it gives the vessel a melody of its own, and the world remembers it seven years later.

7.3
The Empty Button
Context and the Floating Signifier

Chapter I described the context-sensitive action button as an empty signifier; its full significance appears only when it is set within the whole interface. On the Nintendo 64 controller the player's hands hold a small set of instruments. One button swings the sword; one trigger raises the shield. Three yellow buttons hold whatever items the player assigns to them—the slingshot, a bottle, the ocarina—so that the hand carries three assignable vessels, refilled at will from the inventory. A fourth yellow button belongs to the fairy, summoning her counsel or shifting the view into the hero's own eyes. And at the center of the right thumb's reach stands the action button, labeled on the screen by a word that changes with every circumstance: open, speak, check, climb, grab, drop, return. The button's meaning is supplied entirely by the world. Pressed before a door, it opens; before a person, it speaks; at a ledge, it climbs.

Lévi-Strauss, introducing the work of Marcel Mauss, proposed that notions such as *mana*—the Melanesian term for a power that may be predicated of anything—function as floating signifiers: signifiers of zero symbolic value, which can take on any content precisely

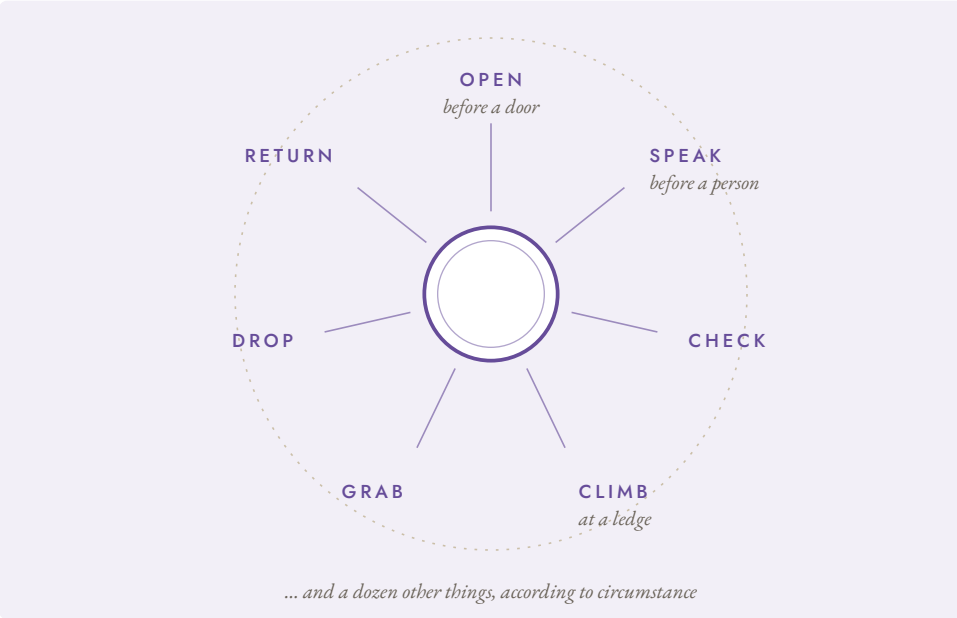


FIGURE 7.1 *The Empty Button*

A single input whose meaning the world supplies: before a door it opens, before a person it speaks, at a ledge it climbs. Its universality is purchased by its vacancy (§7.3).

because they have none of their own, and which mark the excess of signifier over signified that every symbolic system contains (Lévi-Strauss 1950). Laclau later politicized the idea: an empty signifier is the term that, emptied of particular content, comes to represent the universality of a chain of equivalent demands, and around whose filling hegemonic struggle turns (Laclau 1996). The action button is *mana* made into hardware. Its universality depends on its vacancy; every context in the game competes to fill it; and its operation is the operation of meaning in a world, a single gesture that becomes whatever the situation requires.

Phenomenologically, the action button is the purest instance of what Heidegger called the ready-to-hand. Equipment in use withdraws: one attends not to the hammer but to the nail, not to the button but to the door. The context-sensitive button withdraws further than any equipment Heidegger described, because it has no fixed function to which attention might return. The player does not think "press the button" but "open the door," and the button vanishes into the act. This withdrawal is the precondition of the absorption that critics of the period praised in the game. It is also, in the terms of this dissertation, a kenotic achievement of design: an interface that empties its central control of fixed meaning makes room for the world to speak through the player's hand.

One may observe, without pressing the point, that the configuration of the hand reproduces the configuration of the relic: three assignable slots, each a vessel the player fills, around

a center whose content the player does not choose but receives from the world. The hand that plays *Ocarina of Time* holds a small Triforce, and its center, too, is empty.

7.4
Attention as Ethics
Lock-On, Weil, and Murdoch

The innovation for which *Ocarina of Time* is most often credited in histories of game design is its lock-on system. When the player holds the trigger beneath the controller's central grip, the camera and the hero's orientation fix upon a single target—an enemy, a person, an object—marked by the fairy, who flies to it and hovers above it. The hero may circle the target, sidestep, spring backward, raise his shield, and strike, always facing it, while the camera reframes the scene so that hero and target remain together in view. The development team's oft-recounted inspiration was the *chanbara* performance of a Kyoto film-studio park, in which a lone swordsman surrounded by enemies engages them one at a time while the others await their turn—a convention of choreography long embodied by the genre's specialist extras, the *kirare-yaku*, whose craft is to be cut down. The lock-on system made this theatrical convention a principle of interface. In Hyrule the hero attends to one at a time.

Simone Weil made attention the center of her ethics and her spirituality. In an essay on the right use of school studies, she argued that the true purpose of study is to train the faculty of attention, which consists in suspending one's thought, leaving it detached, empty, and ready to be penetrated by its object (Weil 1942). Attention so understood is a kind of self-emptying, close to what she elsewhere called decreation. And she drew its ethical consequence from the Grail legend Chapter III examined: the love of one's neighbor, in its fullness, consists simply in being able to ask, "What are you going through?"—the question that, in the first legend of the Grail, the Grail itself awaits from whoever will put it to the wounded king. Attention, she wrote to Joë Bousquet, is the rarest and purest form of generosity.

Iris Murdoch, who took the concept from Weil, made attention the center of a moral philosophy opposed to the will-centered ethics of her day (Murdoch 1970). The moral life, she argued, is not a series of choices but a continuous effort of attention, "a just and loving gaze directed upon an individual reality"; its enemy is the ego in its fat and relentless self-concern, and its discipline is unselfing. Her most famous example is a kestrel. Looking out of a window, anxious and resentful, she sees a kestrel hovering, and in a moment the brooding self has vanished; nothing remains but the bird.

The lock-on system is, among other things, an apparatus of attention in Weil's and Murdoch's sense. It suspends the hero's free survey of the world and fixes it upon one other.

It decenters the frame: the camera, which otherwise follows the hero from behind, now composes the scene around the relation between the hero and the one he faces. And its use is not confined to combat. The player locks onto persons to speak with them, onto signs to read them, onto whatever the fairy marks as worth notice. In Hyrule one faces whomever one addresses; attention is the precondition of speech. The fairy who flies to the target is the hero's attention made visible—the *daimonion* of Chapter III become a pointer, saying not only "beware" but "look here."

Chapter IV argued that courage in the game is enacted as timing. The lock-on system is what makes timing possible, for the moment can be seized only by one who is attending. Attention prepares *kairos*. The game's ethics of combat is thus an ethics of the duel rather than of the mêlée: each opponent confronted in turn, as an individual, never as a mass.

The ethics of attention must nonetheless be set beside a darker genealogy. Paul Virilio's *War and Cinema* traced the convergence of the camera and the weapon across the twentieth century, the fusion of perception and targeting into a single logistics of perception in which to see is already to aim (Virilio 1984). Lock-on targeting belongs to this history as much as to Weil's. The gesture by which the hero turns his whole attention to the ranch girl, or to the village woman whose hens have scattered, is the gesture by which he aims at a skeleton's exposed skull. The game encodes attention and targeting in a single trigger, and its ethical weight depends upon what the player chooses to lock onto. That one act can be either the purest form of generosity or the preparation of a blow is not a defect of the design. It is a truth about attention that Weil herself, who wrote of the *Iliad* as the poem of force (Weil 1940), would have recognized.

7.5 The Instrument in the Hands

Body Schema, Prosthesis, and Breath

Merleau-Ponty's *Phenomenology of Perception* offers two images that describe the controller with uncanny precision. The first is the organist. Given an unfamiliar organ, with more or fewer stops than his own and differently arranged, an experienced organist needs only an hour of practice to perform upon it—not, Merleau-Ponty insisted, because he has memorized the positions of the stops as objective facts, but because he has incorporated the instrument, settling into it as one settles into a house, so that a direct relation is established between musical intention and keys and pedals (Merleau-Ponty 1945, Part I, ch. 3). The second is the blind man's cane, which ceases to be an object in the hand and becomes an extension of the body, its tip a zone of sensitivity through which the world is felt. In *Ocarina of Time* the Nintendo 64 controller becomes both. It is an organ in Merleau-Ponty's sense: the face of the controller is the finger-holes of a vessel flute, and players incorporate its songs

so thoroughly that the fingerings persist for decades. And it is a cane. The Stone of Agony, discussed in Chapter I, makes the controller tremble in the player's palm when the hero passes near a hidden grotto, so that a hollow beneath the earth announces itself, as through the tip of a cane, to the body before the eye.

The controller's own form completes the picture. It has three prongs: a left grip bearing a cross-shaped directional pad, a central grip bearing the analog stick with its trigger beneath, and a right grip bearing the buttons. *Ocarina of Time* asks the player to hold the center and the right; the directional pad on the left prong has no function in the game. The instrument in the player's hands, like every triad in Hyrule, keeps one of its three places empty.

André Leroi-Gourhan's paleoanthropology made the coupling of hand and face the hinge of human evolution. Upright posture freed the hand from locomotion for the making of tools and freed the face from grasping for speech; technics and language developed together; and human memory came progressively to be exteriorized in tools, writing, and machines (Leroi-Gourhan 1964–65). *Ocarina of Time* reverses the coupling in a single figure. The hero's face is silent and his hand speaks. All of his expression passes through the hands—sword, shield, instrument—and, through them, through the player's hands upon the controller. The game is an anthropology in which the hand has reabsorbed the office of the face.

Bernard Stiegler extended Leroi-Gourhan's account into a philosophy of technical memory. The human, he argued, is constituted by its exteriorization in technical objects, and to Husserl's primary retention, the just-past held in perception, and secondary retention, recollection, Stiegler added a third: tertiary retention, memory recorded in technical media, which permits a temporal object to be replayed identically (Stiegler 1994–2001). A game cartridge is tertiary retention twice over. It records the temporal object of the game, which every player replays; and through its battery-backed save memory it records each player's particular passage through that object, a lived time stored in a medium. Augustine called memory the stomach of the mind (*memoria quasi venter est animi Confessions* X.14.21), the organ in which experience is held and digested. The cartridge's three save files are such stomachs: three vessels of lived time, each holding a hero's life at the point where its player last laid it down. When a saved game outside a dungeon is resumed, the child wakes in his house in the forest and the man at the Temple of Time; within a dungeon, at its threshold. The child's home is his bed among the Kokiri. The man's home is the gate of time.

The Ocarina Principle calls the player a breath, and the figure must be qualified. On the Nintendo 64 the ocarina is played with buttons, and the player's breath is figurative, transmitted through the hands. The figure has nonetheless a material trace in the analog stick, with which the player may bend a note's pitch and add vibrato while it sounds—the expressive inflection that in a wind instrument belongs to the breath. And the series later made the figure literal. In *Spirit Tracks* (2009), for the Nintendo DS, the hero plays a set of pan-pipes by blowing into the handheld's microphone while sliding the stylus across the

pipes. The player's breath, at last, sounds the vessel. Eleven years after *Ocarina of Time*, the medium caught up with Axiom II.

7.6 Death, Failure, and the Bottled Life

When the hero's Heart Containers are emptied, he falls. If a fairy waits in one of his bottles, she is released at that moment, circles him, and restores his life; otherwise the screen darkens and the game offers the player the chance to continue with a portion of the hero's life restored. Death in Hyrule is a vessel emptied, and life is a vessel refilled—from another vessel, if the player has had the foresight to keep a fairy in a bottle. The bottled fairy is the vessel economy's final form: a second life held in reserve, a capacity for survival stored in glass.

Heidegger's analysis of being-toward-death made death Dasein's ownmost possibility: non-relational, since no one can die my death for me; certain, yet indefinite as to its when; and not to be outstripped, the limit of every other possibility (Heidegger 1927, §§46–53). Authentic existence anticipates this possibility and is individualized by it. Death in a game inverts each of these determinations. It is shared, for every player dies the same deaths in the same rooms; it is repeatable; it is outstripped by the continue; and it individualizes nothing. One might conclude that games, by their structure, cannot think death. *Ocarina of Time* suggests another conclusion. It does not imitate Heideggerian death but replaces it with something nearer the Epicurean consolation—that death is nothing to us—joined to an ethic of learning, in which each death teaches the player what the hero must do. Jesper Juul has called our willingness to seek out such failure the paradox of failure: we avoid failure in life and pursue it in games, and games make failure meaningful precisely by making it reversible and instructive (Juul 2013).

The structure of the game's deaths also echoes the rites of passage of Chapter III. A hero who falls within a dungeon and is resumed begins again at its threshold—at the doorway of the interior he failed to traverse. Death returns him to the limen. Each failure is a separation repeated, a renewed standing at the margin from which the passage into the hollow must be attempted again.

Freud, contemplating his grandson's game with the reel and the repetitive dreams of soldiers returned from the war, posited beyond the pleasure principle a compulsion to repeat, and behind it a drive toward death (Freud 1920). The player who dies and continues, dies and continues, before the same guardian in the same chamber, enacts the repetition compulsion in its most benign form: repetition as mastery, the *fort-da* of Chapter III played with the hero's life itself. Each death sends him away; each continuation brings him back.

The series' official history, as Chapter IV showed, has given these deaths an afterlife. The world in which the hero falls in the final battle has its own history, and the player's failures,

which the ordinary ontology of games consigns to nothing, have a branch of time in which they are true. Ludic modal realism is, from the player's side, a theology of failure. No death in Hyrule is wasted; each is the beginning of another world.

The bottled fairy and the continue are, finally, small instances of kenochrony. They return to the player time that was lost—the minutes of a failed attempt, the life of a fallen hero—not as a gift of new content but as a restoration of capacity: hearts refilled, the chamber reset, the attempt open again. The game's mercy toward its player is the mercy the princess shows the hero at its end. It gives time back empty, so that it may be lived again.

7.7
Afterlives of Play

Speedrun, Glitch, Randomizer, Rumor

A work of play does not end when its makers release it. For more than a quarter of a century *Ocarina of Time* has sustained a culture of practices through which players continue to breathe into it—practices that are themselves interpretations of the work, and that can be classified by the Ocarina Principle according to whether they hollow the work or fill it. Henry Jenkins's account of fans as textual poachers, who appropriate and rework the texts they love (Jenkins 1992), describes the general phenomenon. The particular practices that have grown around this game take its own themes—time, the hollow, the center—as their material.

The most celebrated is speedrunning, the competitive practice of completing a game as quickly as possible, in which *Ocarina of Time* has long been among the most closely studied works. Over two decades its runners have discovered techniques that collapse a journey of many hours into minutes: glitches that let the hero pass through walls; others that send him from the chamber of a dungeon's guardian directly to the end of the game; and, more recently, methods of arbitrary code execution that allow a player, using nothing but the controller, to rewrite parts of the program's memory while it runs. The speedrunner is a Hero of Time in the literal sense, a master of the game's temporality whose art is an art of *kairos* measured in single frames. The practice is ambivalent in the terms of this dissertation. It empties the game of its duration, a kenotic achievement, the hollowing of time; and it aims at total mastery of that time, an ambition the usurper would recognize.

Glitch-hunting, the discovery and cataloguing of the program's unintended behaviors, is the community's Lens of Truth. Heidegger observed that equipment, which withdraws in use, becomes conspicuous when it breaks, and that in its breakdown the whole of references to which it belongs flashes into view (Heidegger 1927, §16). Rosa Menkman's theory of the glitch made that moment of breakdown into an aesthetic, in which the medium, ordinarily transparent, shows itself (Menkman 2011). The glitch is *alētheia* in the sense of Chapter V:

the unconcealment of the code beneath the fiction. Players who pass through the walls of Hyrule treat every wall as a false wall and every surface as one of the Shadow Temple's illusions; they see through the world to the hollow behind it. Volunteer efforts to reconstruct, from the compiled game, a human-readable form of its source code have carried the same impulse to its limit: the whole work rendered legible through the lens.

Randomizers—community-built programs that, since the late 2010s, have shuffled the locations of the game's items, redistributing the tools of Hyrule among its chests and guardians under rules that keep the game completable—are the most purely kenotic of these practices. A randomizer empties every vessel of its designed content and refills it by chance. The slingshot may lie in the fish god's belly and the hammer in a chest in the forest; the designed sequence is hollowed, and the world becomes newly playable. Caillois's *alea*, the play of chance, enters a game of *ludus* and reopens it. And each random seed is a possible world, a branch the designers never built: ludic modal realism practiced by players, a Leibnizian palace of Hyrules.

Rumor is the oldest of these practices and the one most revealing of the community's desires. In the years after 1998, schoolyards and early internet forums circulated rumors of secrets the game did not contain, and the most persistent held that the Triforce itself could be obtained. Social psychologists and folklorists have long studied rumor as a collective improvisation upon shared anxieties and wishes (Allport and Postman 1947), and the digital age has multiplied its forms (Blank 2012). The Triforce rumor is a folk theology. It expresses the wish to fill the empty center—to possess the relic that the game withholds—which is to say the usurper's wish, transferred to the player. The game's refusal to grant the wish is the game's theology; the rumor is the community's heresy.

In 2022 a collaborative project of players used arbitrary code execution to stage, within the original game, the acquisition of the Triforce that the rumor had promised for more than two decades. The heresy was enacted as a rite. Mikhail Bakhtin described carnival as the festive suspension of hierarchy, in which a mock king is crowned and uncrowned, the sacred is parodied, and the world is renewed through laughter (Bakhtin 1965). The staging of the forbidden acquisition belongs to this order: the filling of the center performed not as usurpation but as festival, with an affection for the work whose theology it inverts. It confirms, by inversion, the thesis of this dissertation. The players who filled the center knew that it had been empty, and that its emptiness was the game.

7·8 Coda

Who Is It That Blows?

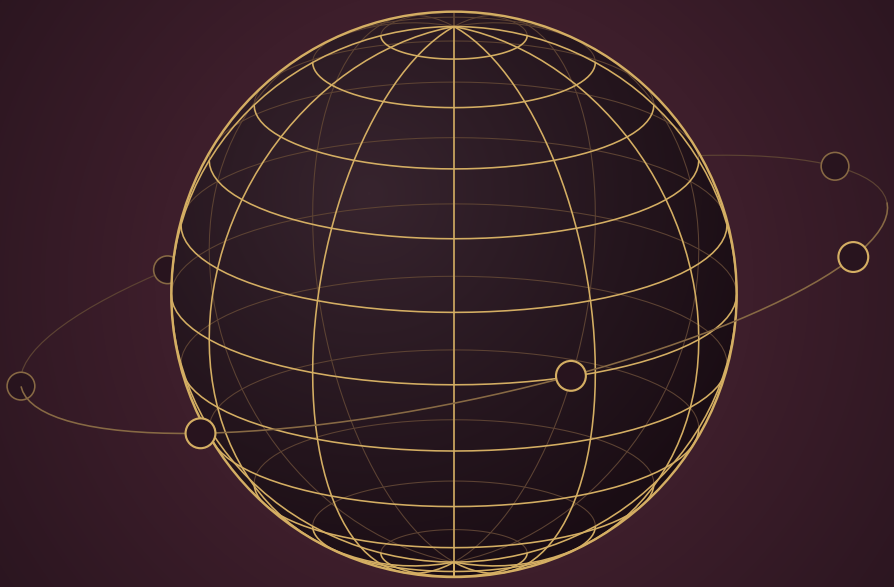
TABLE 7.1 *The afterlives of play, classified by the Ocarina Principle.*

PRACTICE	WHAT IT DOES TO THE WORK	RELATION TO THE VOID	EMBLEM WITHIN THE GAME
Speedrunning	compresses hours of play into minutes	ambivalent: hollows duration, masters time	the Song of Time
Glitch-hunting	exposes the code beneath the fiction	kenotic: reveals the hollow behind every wall	the Lens of Truth
Randomization	redistributes tools among the world's vessels	kenotic: empties each vessel and refills it by chance	the empty bottle
Rumor	imagines what the game withholds	plenary: wishes the center filled	the Triforce
Code execution	rewrites the game from inside	carnivalesque: fills the center as festival	the scarecrow's song

The teacher of the *Zhuangzi*, having described the pipings of humans and of earth, asked who it is that blows through the ten thousand hollows, so that each sounds in its own way and each takes what it is from itself. *Ocarina of Time* gives an answer that is also a question. The breath that sounds its hollows—the ocarina, the hero, the dungeons, the bottles, the Sacred Realm—is the player's. But the player, too, is a vessel. Gadamer insisted that all playing is a being-played: the to-and-fro of the game absorbs the player, who is moved by the play as much as moving it (Gadamer 1960). The player fills the hollow hero with breath and is in turn filled by Hyrule—by its songs, which the hands remember; by its places, which memory keeps; by the attention it trains and the failures it teaches. The chain of vessels does not end in the player. It passes through him.

The last chapter turns from the work to its afterlife in the medium: to the games that inherited or refused the Ocarina Principle, and to what a criterion drawn from a single game of 1998 might say about the design of the games that followed.

CHAPTER



VIII

Conclusion

Toward a Kenochronic Poetics

南海之帝為儵，北海之帝為忽，中央之帝為渾沌。儵與忽時相與遇於渾沌之地，渾沌待之甚善。儵與忽謀報渾沌之德，曰：「人皆有七竅以視聽食息，此獨無有，嘗試鑿之。」日鑿一竅，七日而渾沌死。

The emperor of the South Sea was Shu, the emperor of the North Sea was Hu, and the emperor of the Center was Hundun. Shu and Hu often met in Hundun's land, and Hundun treated them very well. Wishing to repay his kindness, they said: "All men have seven openings, through which they see, hear, eat, and breathe; he alone has none. Let us try boring some for him." Each day they bored one opening, and on the seventh day Hundun died.

— *Zhuangzi*, ch. 7 (trans. mine)

... Negative Capability, that is when man is capable of being in uncertainties, Mysteries, doubts, without any irritable reaching after fact & reason.

— John Keats, letter to George and Tom Keats, December 1817

8·1
The Argument Recapitulated

This dissertation began from a single acoustic fact—that the instrument giving *Ocarina of Time* its title sounds from its emptiness—and proposed that the fact is the master-figure of the work. It formalized the figure as the Ocarina Principle and decomposed it into five axioms: that capacity precedes content; that no vessel signifies without a breath from outside; that the center of every triad must remain vacant, and that evil is the attempt to occupy it; that the game distinguishes a privative hollowness from a receptive emptiness and leads through the one to the other; and that time in the game is a vessel whose highest gift is to be returned empty. To discipline the comparisons on which the argument depends, it adopted a procedural criterion: a homology drawn from another tradition is admitted only when it is structural, triangulated, and enacted in the game's rules.

The chapters tested the axioms at every level of the work. Chapter II found in the cosmogony a structure of shaping, withdrawal, and trace; read the Triforce as a balance that divides an unbalanced soul along its fault lines, as Plato's beast, lion, and human being; and showed, across Dumézil's functions, the Confucian triad, the Tridevī, and the Kabbalistic *sefirot*, that the term missing from the relic is the virtue of benevolent relation—humaneness, mercy, care—which, being a relation, can appear in a distribution of possessions only as the empty space between them. Chapter III read the hero as the hidden child of the theogonic and messianic traditions, the seven-year sleep as an adolescence excised, the narrative as a rite of passage run backward, and the ending as the princess's Kleinian reparation, the undoing of the forced growth Mencius condemned. Chapter IV constructed the Triforce of Time—*chronos*, *kairos*, and *aion* around a receptacle outside time—and opposed the tyrant's chronophagy to the kenochrony of the ending, a jubilee in which the hero is returned to his own. Chapter V read the dungeons through Bachelard's material imagination as a sequence of interiors whose final content is not treasure but a person. Chapter VI developed the political theology of an unseen king, a plenary usurper, a people with no part, a kingdom with a cellar, a princess whose sovereignty survives in disguise and is exercised as a gift, and a federation of sages that restrains rather than annihilates. Chapter VII located the player as the last vessel and as the breath that sounds all the others, and read the practices of the work's afterlife as kenotic and plenary appropriations of it.

The contributions announced in the abstract can now be stated with the evidence behind them. The first is a unified reading of the game as a philosophical fiction whose arguments are carried by its rules: by the vessel economy, the context-sensitive button, the lock-on system, the recognition of songs, and the canonized defeat. The second is a set of portable concepts—the Ocarina Principle, kenochrony and chronophagy, chōric and plenary sovereignty, the vessel economy, the Triforce of Time, ludic modal realism—each defined against this game but formulated for use beyond it. The third is a revision of the *mukokuseki* thesis:

what the game deodorizes at the level of iconography returns as structure, in a Japaneseness that already contains the *Timaeus* and the *Zohar*. The fourth is the normative criterion to which the second half of this chapter is devoted.

The method has its limits, and they should be stated plainly. Not every resonance this study proposed satisfied the procedural criterion. The reading of the dead tree in the mirror-room as the hero's lost guardian, the observation that the controller leaves its third prong unused, the Sierpiński figure for the series, and the onomastic coincidences of Din and of the scales of Enoshima were offered as images and probabilities rather than demonstrations, and the reader is entitled to weigh them accordingly. The game's representation of the desert people was criticized rather than redeemed; its gender politics were found ambivalent; its political theology was shown to contain a cellar that its ending does not empty. A philosophical fiction need not be just in every part to be profound as a whole.

8·2
Afterlives I
Majora's Mask *and the Plenum That Falls*

The first afterlife of the Ocarina Principle is its own sequel. *Majora's Mask*, released in 2000, opens with the hero on a private journey in search of a beloved friend—the fairy who flew from the Temple of Time—and carries him into Termina, a world adjacent to Hyrule, in which a moon with a grimacing face will fall upon the town at the world's center at the end of three days. The town is preparing its Carnival of Time. The hero cannot stop the moon within the three days; he can only return, by playing the Song of Time, to the dawn of the first day, keeping what he has learned and some of what he has gained, and try again.

Chapter IV observed that *Ocarina of Time* has songs for the sun and the storm but none for the moon, and that the moon, the inactive center of the *Kojiki*'s celestial triad, is the empty middle of its weather music. In *Majora's Mask* the absent center returns as a plenum falling from heaven. The moon is the sequel's image of a center that will not stay empty: a weight descending upon the world's middle at a fixed hour. And the sequel's temporal structure is the dark twin of kenochrony. In *Ocarina of Time* the princess gives the hero back his time once, as a gift; in *Majora's Mask* the hero must give time back to a whole world, again and again, by his own labor. The return of empty time becomes a compulsion. Nietzsche called the thought of eternal recurrence the greatest weight (*The Gay Science* §341); *Majora's Mask* turns the gift of the first game into that weight, and asks what it costs to be the one who returns time.

The sequel's other great device confirms the reading of Chapter III. The hero acquires masks that transform him into members of the peoples of Hyrule's world—a Deku child, a Goron hero, a Zora musician—and each of these masks is the face of someone dead, received

through a song of healing that converts the grief of the departed into a mask the living can wear. A hero who in the first game could only echo the songs of others now wears the faces of the dead. *Majora's Mask* is a work of mourning in Freud's sense (Freud 1917): it does the grieving for the losses that *Ocarina of Time*'s ending declined to mourn—the fairy, the adult self, the friends left in a future that no longer exists. A popular reading, widely circulated among players, maps the sequel's four regions and its town onto the five stages of grief proposed by Elisabeth Kübler-Ross (Kübler-Ross 1969); one need not accept the schematism to recognize the intuition behind it. *Ocarina of Time* gives time back. Its sequel counts the cost.

The festival toward which the doomed town prepares is a carnival in Bakhtin's sense, the feast in which order is suspended and renewed—and it is the Carnival of Time. The sequel thus completes a figure the first game began. The time returned empty is a time of festival, and the festival is perpetually threatened by the plenum overhead.

8·3
Afterlives II
Breath of the Wild *and the Emptied World*

Nineteen years after *Ocarina of Time*, the series returned to its founding structures in a new key. *Breath of the Wild* (2017) opens with the hero waking in a chamber called the Shrine of Resurrection after a sleep not of seven years but of a hundred, into a Hyrule ruined by a calamity he failed to prevent. The Urashima pattern of Chapter III is amplified to the scale of a century: the hero returns to a world in which almost no one he knew survives and in which the kingdom itself is a field of ruins. And the game's design takes the hollowing of the world as its premise. From the moment he leaves the plateau on which he wakes, the hero may go anywhere, including directly to the castle at the world's center, where the calamity coils. The vast land between is sparsely inhabited; its map is blank until climbed and seen; and its interiors are dispersed into more than a hundred small shrines rather than gathered into a few great dungeons.

The title names Axiom II: the world is a breath, and the player breathes through it. The game's progression, moreover, preserves the vessel economy with a candor that seems almost to acknowledge the argument of this dissertation. The hero grows by exchanging tokens earned in the shrines for Heart Containers or for what the game calls, explicitly, Stamina Vessels, and the hundreds of seeds he gathers from the forest spirits are exchanged for room —an enlarged capacity to carry weapons, bows, and shields. Growth is still the enlargement of hollows, and the game names its hollows vessels.

The political theology of Chapter VI returns as well, revised. The calamity has been restrained for a century not by a council of sages but by the princess alone, holding it within

the castle by her power: the *katechon* personified, the restrainer who holds back the end until the hero returns. And the federation that failed to prevent the calamity—four champions drawn from four peoples, the Zora, the Gorons, the bird-people of the Rito, and the Gerudo—includes from the first the desert people whom the order of three had excluded. The part that had no part in 1998 has its champion in 2017. The sequel, *Tears of the Kingdom* (2023), presses the princess's kenosis further still. To restore the broken Master Sword across the ages, she swallows a sacred stone and becomes a dragon, surrendering her human form and her memory to the work of restoration—a self-emptying the game presents as the highest act of sovereignty, and which it reverses only at the last. Beneath that game's Hyrule lies a vast underworld of darkness, the Depths, mirroring the surface world above: the kingdom's cellar of Chapter VI made into a second world.

The open world of 2017 is thus an afterlife of the Ocarina Principle rather than its abandonment. Its emptiness—of the map, of the land, of a center open from the start—is a capacity, not a lack; its progression enlarges vessels; its sovereign is a restrainer and, in the sequel, a self-emptying gift. What has changed is the scale and the distribution of the hollow. In 1998 the vacancy was concentrated in a few places: the center of the Triforce, the Sacred Realm, the seven years. In 2017 it is spread across a whole world, which the player is free to fill or to leave empty.

8.4
The Hollow as Damnation
Dark Souls *and the Criterion of* Kyomu

Chapter I set *Ocarina of Time* beside Hidetaka Miyazaki's *Dark Souls* (FromSoftware, 2011) as its structural inversion, and the comparison can now be completed. In *Dark Souls* the player is one of the cursed undead, branded with a dark sign, who revives at bonfires after every death and gradually goes Hollow, losing humanity and memory until reduced to a mindless husk. The world is an age of fire burning out. Its founding sovereign, Gwyn, Lord of Sunlight, sacrificed himself long ago to rekindle the first flame and prolong the age; when the player reaches him at the end of the game, he is a withered husk, a hollowed king guarding the embers. The final choice is whether to link oneself to the fire and sustain the dying age, as Gwyn did, or to let it fade into an age of dark.

Every element of the Ocarina Principle is present in *Dark Souls*, and every one is inverted. The hollow is damnation, not capacity: to go Hollow is to lose oneself. The cycle is a curse to be endured, not a vocation to be taken up. The sovereign is not a vacancy kept open but a husk at the center, a center emptied by its own self-sacrifice and still occupying the throne. Death is not a vessel emptied and refilled but an erosion: each death costs the player what he has gathered, and the world's enemies return at every rest. In Nishitani's terms, *Dark Souls*

is a game of *kyomu*—nihility, the relative nothingness that opens like an abyss beneath the self—as *Ocarina of Time* is a game of *kū*.

The distinction is not a judgment of quality. *Dark Souls* is among the most accomplished games of its century, and its achievement is precisely to make nihility playable: to bring the player to the bottom of the abyss Nishitani described, where, he argued, the breakthrough to emptiness becomes possible. And the game contains its own breakthrough. Its hollow world is populated by the traces of other players: messages written on the ground, the bloodstains that replay their deaths, the phantoms of those who answer a summons for help—what one of the game's characters calls jolly cooperation. In a world of nihility, relation persists as an asynchronous gift among strangers, each leaving a sign for others who will pass the same way. The virtue the Triforce could not hold, *Dark Souls* distributes among its players.

The comparison yields the criterion this dissertation proposes. A design is kenotic when its emptiness is a capacity—for the player's breath, for relation, for return—and nihilistic when its emptiness is a loss without return. Both kinds of design can be profound, and each can be true to aspects of human experience the other cannot reach. But the distinction allows the critic to say what metaphysics a game encodes in its rules, independently of what its fiction proclaims; and it makes visible a third kind of design, neither kenotic nor nihilistic, which has become in the quarter-century since 1998 the dominant form of the medium.

8.5
Against the Plenum
A Critique of Saturated Design

In the decade after *Dark Souls*, much of the commercial medium converged upon a template for the large open world that critics came to describe with weariness: towers or vantage points that, once climbed, unveil a map saturated with icons; activities, collectibles, and side-tasks distributed at regular intervals across the terrain; checklists whose completion is tracked by percentages; and, increasingly, structures of live service—daily rewards, seasonal passes, time-limited events—designed to occupy the player's time continuously and indefinitely. Such games may be generous and skillfully made. But their metaphysics, in the terms of this dissertation, is plenary. Their maps are Parmenidean plenums without void; their progression accumulates contents rather than enlarging capacities; and their economies of engagement treat the player's time as a resource to be captured.

Herbert Simon observed, at the dawn of the information age, that a wealth of information creates a poverty of attention (Simon 1971); Jonathan Crary described late capitalism as a world without pause, a regime of continuous availability waging war on sleep itself (Crary 2013). The plenary game is chronophagy as a business model. It occupies the center of the player's day as Ganondorf occupied the Sacred Realm, and its ideal, like his, is a

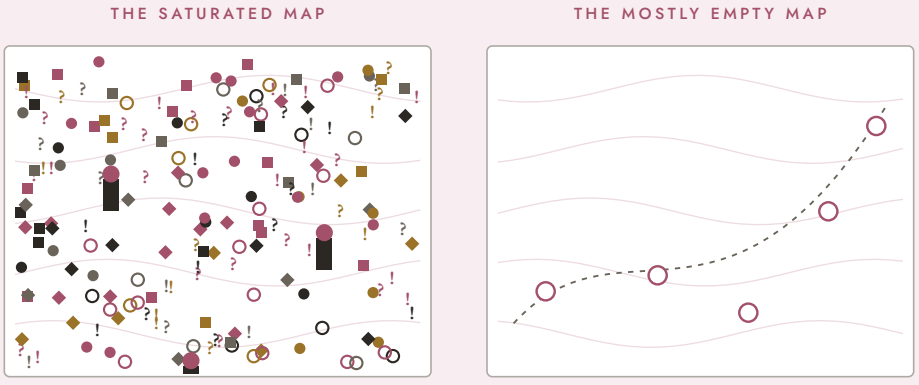


FIGURE 8.1 *Plenum and Hollow*

Two metaphysics of the map: terrain saturated with icons, activities, and checklists, against a map left mostly empty, whose rewards are room (§8.5; Table 8.1).

reign without end. Against it the Ocarina Principle offers a criterion and a counter-example. *Ocarina of Time* ends. Its hero sleeps for seven years at the center of the world. Its map is mostly empty. Its rewards are room. Its last act is to give time back.

Roger Caillois, having classified games by their governing principle—competition (*agôn*), chance (*alea*), simulation (*mimicry*), and vertigo (*ilinx*)—devoted a chapter to their corruption, to what befalls each when the boundary separating play from ordinary life is breached. Competition degenerates into violence and trickery, simulation into alienation, vertigo into intoxication, and chance into superstition and the gambler's compulsion (Caillois 1958, ch. 4). The monetized randomness that the plenary model has made central—paid draws of chance for characters and items—is Caillois's corrupted *alea*: chance severed from the enclosure of play and joined to money and compulsion. The randomizers of Chapter VII keep *alea* within play, a chance that empties the world's vessels so that the world may be played anew; the paid draw is *alea* as capture, a chance that empties the player's purse to fill a ledger. The two practices share a mechanism and invert a metaphysics.

A kenotic poetics of games is not merely a historical memory. It has been practiced since 1998 by works that design by subtraction—a phrase often attached to Fumito Ueda's *Ico* (2001) and *Shadow of the Colossus* (2005), whose vast and nearly empty lands surround sixteen colossi and a silence; by *Journey* (2012), whose companions are anonymous and wordless; and most rigorously by *Outer Wilds* (2019), in which a solar system ends in a supernova every twenty-two minutes and the player returns to the beginning carrying nothing but knowledge, so that understanding is the only form of progress and time is given

TABLE 8.1 *Three metaphysics of game design.*

	KENOTIC	NIHILISTIC	PLENARY
EMPTINESS IS	a capacity to be sounded	a loss to be endured	a lack to be filled
TIME IS	given back empty	eroded by repetition	captured and occupied
THE MAP IS	blank until breathed into	a ruin	saturated with icons
PROGRESS IS	enlarged capacity	survival against erosion	accumulated content
THE CENTER IS	kept vacant	a husk upon the throne	occupied
EXEMPLARS	*Ocarina of Time Outer Wilds*	*Dark Souls*	the saturated open world

back empty at every loop. These works differ greatly from one another and from *Ocarina of Time*, but they share its axioms: capacity before content, breath from outside, a center left open, an emptiness that receives rather than consumes, time returned rather than seized.

The criterion is not a rule of composition. A game cannot be made kenotic by subtracting content, any more than a vessel can be made by removing clay at random; the potter shapes the void by shaping the walls. Nor is it an aesthetic preference for minimalism, for *Ocarina of Time* is crowded with people, places, songs, and secrets. What the criterion asks of a design is whether its abundance is organized around a hollow the player may sound, or whether it fills every hollow in advance.

8.6 The Principle Beyond the Medium

The Ocarina Principle was derived from a game, but throughout this dissertation it was assembled from traditions in every medium, and it can be returned to them. Three instances, from cinema, music, and architecture, suffice to show that it describes a recurrent achievement of art rather than a peculiarity of one work.

The films of Ozu Yasujirō are punctuated by shots in which nothing happens: an empty corridor, washing on a line, a smokestack, a vase in a darkened room. Noël Burch called them pillow shots, after the pillow-words of classical Japanese poetry (Burch 1979); Paul Schrader found in them the stasis of a transcendental style (Schrader 1972). The most famous, in *Late Spring* (1949), shows a vase in a darkened room, set between a shot of the daughter smiling and a shot of her on the verge of tears. Deleuze, in the second volume of his study of cinema, made this vase the paradigm of what he called the time-image: the still life, he argued, is time itself, the unchanging form within which everything that changes changes (Deleuze 1985).

The image of time, for Deleuze as for this dissertation, is an empty vessel. Ozu's grave, at the temple of Engaku-ji in Kamakura, bears a single character: 無, nothingness.

John Cage's *4′33″* (1952), first performed by the pianist David Tudor at Woodstock, New York, consists of three movements during which the performer plays nothing. The work is a vessel of time—its duration marked, its movements articulated, its instrument present and silent—which the sounds of the hall, the audience, and the world outside fill as breath fills the ocarina. Cage had come to it through his study of Zen with D. T. Suzuki and through his discovery, in an anechoic chamber, that perfect silence does not exist, since the listener still hears the sounds of his own body. The piece makes the listener the breath that sounds the vessel; it is, in the terms of Chapter VII, an open work whose only performer is attention. That it is composed in three movements, a triad of silences, is a coincidence the reader may enjoy without the procedural criterion's permission.

The inner shrine of Ise, the most sacred site of Shinto, is rebuilt every twenty years in the ceremony of *shikinen sengū*. Beside each shrine lies a second plot of the same dimensions. At each rebuilding the new shrine is raised on the vacant plot and the old one dismantled, so that the two sites alternate across the centuries, and the site that waits empty preserves, beneath a small shelter, the place of the sacred central post. The shrine is at once more than thirteen centuries old and never more than twenty years old; its permanence is a rhythm rather than a substance, and its future is held in an empty plot. Ise is kenochrony in timber: a sanctuary whose continuity consists in the empty site that waits for it.

Ozu's vase, Cage's silence, and Ise's empty plot are not influences upon *Ocarina of Time*, and the game is not their equal in every respect. They are its kin. Each locates the power of a work in a hollow that the work shapes and does not fill, and each makes its audience, its listener, or its time the breath that completes it.

8.7 Nostalgia and the Lost Future of 1998

The last afterlife of *Ocarina of Time* is its reception. For a generation of players who met it in childhood, the game has become an object of nostalgia, and its reception has followed both of the courses Svetlana Boym distinguished (Boym 2001). Restorative nostalgia seeks to rebuild the lost home: the remake of 2011 for the Nintendo 3DS, the re-releases on later consoles and subscription services, the orchestral concerts that toured the world in the 2010s performing Kondō's music. Reflective nostalgia dwells in the longing itself, aware that return is impossible: the players who revisit the game not to recover the past but to inhabit their distance from it.

Mark Fisher, borrowing a phrase from Franco Berardi, diagnosed in the culture of the early twenty-first century a slow cancellation of the future—a sense that the futures

promised by the popular culture of the late twentieth century had failed to arrive, and that the present is haunted by them (Fisher 2014). Derrida's hauntology, his account of the specter that returns from a time out of joint, gave the diagnosis its philosophical vocabulary (Derrida 1993). For many who played it, *Ocarina of Time* is one of these lost futures. The open plain of 1998, crossed on horseback beneath a sky that had never before been rendered in three dimensions on a home console, promised a medium in which every horizon would open onto discovery. The first bars of the melody of the Lost Woods, which Chapter IV called a cultural madeleine, carry that promise as a ghost.

But the game anticipated its own reception, and in a way that disarms the melancholy of hauntology. Its ending is itself an act of reflective nostalgia. The hero returns to childhood carrying the memory of a future that will now not occur, and he goes forward anyway—into a garden, toward a princess, with the whole of a life before him. The adult player who returns to *Ocarina of Time* enacts its ending: a grown person returning to a scene of childhood, remembering the future, given back an empty time in which to play. The game does not ask to be restored. It asks to be returned to, as its hero is returned—knowing what he knows, and beginning again.

8.8 Coda

Hundun and the Child at Play

The parable set at the head of this chapter, which closes the inner chapters of the *Zhuangzi*, is the most searching objection to this dissertation, and it deserves the last word but one. Hundun, emperor of the Center, has no openings. He is a whole without apertures, undivided and kind. His friends, wishing to repay his kindness, bore in him the seven openings that every human face possesses, one each day, and on the seventh day he dies. The parable seems at first to reverse the Ocarina Principle. Here it is the boring of holes that kills, and the hollow made in the center is death.

But the parable's lesson is not that openings are evil; it is that they cannot be imposed. Shu and Hu act from benevolence, as the princess acted when she planned to secure the Triforce and as the man of Song acted when he pulled at his sprouts. They force upon the center a form that is not its own, and the center dies of their kindness. The ocarina's holes are not bored at random into a solid block; they are shaped with the vessel, by one who understands the void the vessel holds. Rightly understood, then, the Ocarina Principle is neither a doctrine of apertures to be multiplied nor a formula for design, but an ethic of letting-be: what the *Daodejing* calls *wu wei*, action without forcing, and what Heidegger, late in his life, called releasement (*Gelassenheit*), a comportment that lets things be what they

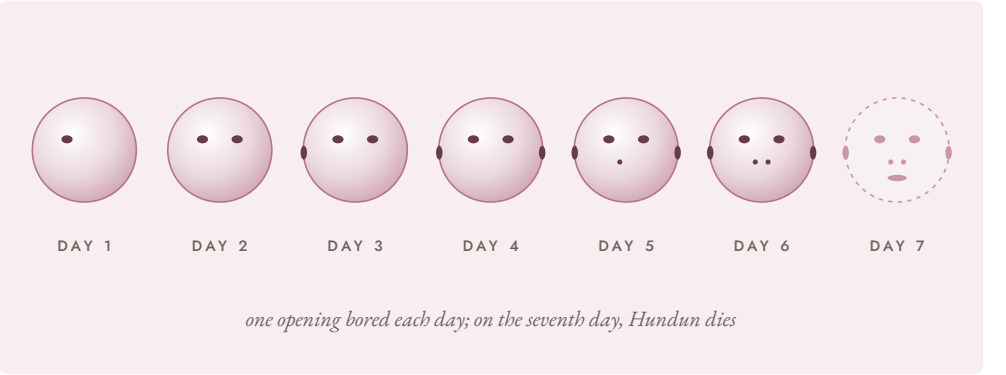


FIGURE 8.2 *Hundun's Seven Days*

Zhuangzi, ch. 7: wishing to repay his kindness, Shu and Hu bore one of the seven openings into the emperor of the Center each day, and on the seventh day he dies. The center must be neither filled nor forced open (§8.8).

are (Heidegger 1959). The center must be neither filled, as the tyrant would fill it, nor forced open, as the well-meaning would force it. It must be kept.

The objection applies to this dissertation as well. A theory of emptiness can become a plenum of its own, a system that fills every hollow of its object with concepts and leaves the work no room in which to answer. The procedural criterion was adopted as a discipline against that danger, and Gadamer's priority of the question, with which this study's method began, is its proper close. The thesis has proposed that *Ocarina of Time* is organized around a hollow. It should end by leaving that hollow open—for other readings, other traditions, other players, and for the work itself, which will go on sounding long after its interpreters have fallen silent. Keats's negative capability, the power of remaining in uncertainties without any irritable reaching after fact and reason, is the critic's form of the vessel.

The game ends, as this study began, with a child. Having laid down the sword, released his guardian, and given back the instrument, the hero walks into a garden toward a princess, and the whole adventure lies at once before and behind him. Heraclitus said that *aiōn* is a child at play, moving pieces on a board, and that the kingship belongs to a child. In Hyrule the kingship belongs to the child not because the child rules—the child rules nothing—but because the child alone keeps the game open. The player sets down the controller. The ocarina falls silent. The vessel waits for breath.

παιδὸς ἡ βασιληίη.

BACK MATTER

Works Cited

Note on citation. Ancient, medieval, and early modern texts are cited in the body by their standard divisions (Stephanus and Bekker pages, Diels–Kranz numbers, book and line, chapter and verse, section numbers) and are listed below by work; translations of passages quoted from them are the author's own. Modern works are cited by author and year of first publication in the original language. Games are cited by title and year of first release.

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THE HOLLOW AT THE HEART OF TIME

The Ocarina Principle, Chōric Sovereignty, and Kenochronic Play in The Legend of Zelda: Ocarina of Time

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